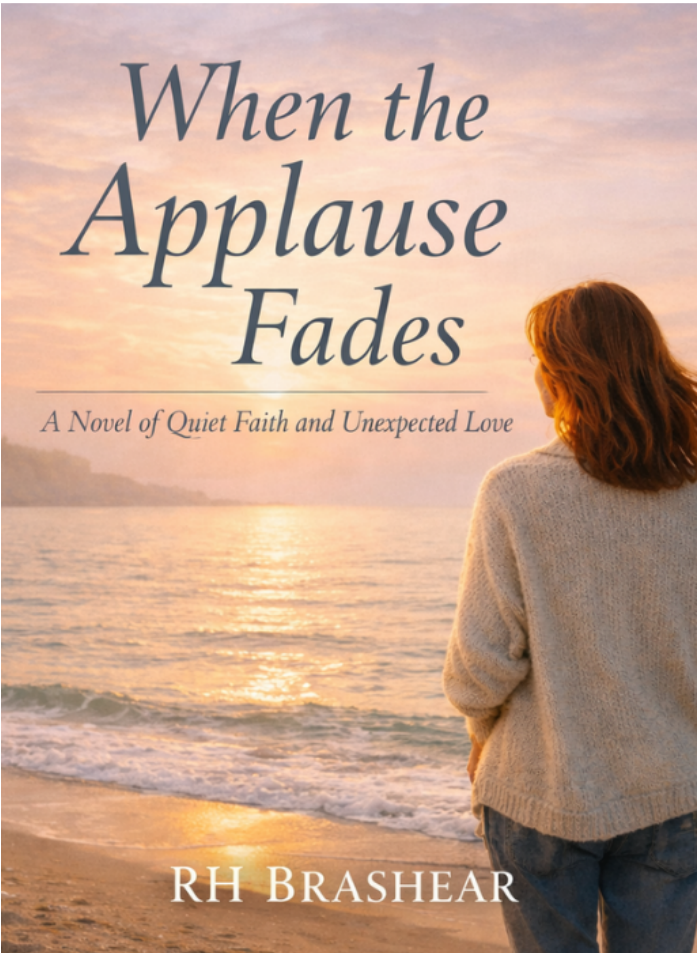




When the Applause Fades

A Novel of Quiet Faith and Unexpected Love

RH BRASHEAR

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CHAPTER ONE

*One day I hope somebody will see
The woman behind this melody.*

- Nova Hart, from “Lonely Light”

5 weeks at #1

ELLIOT

Elliot Brooks closed the laptop the moment the advertisement flashed across the screen.

Meet mature singles in your area.

At fifty-five, after five years of widowhood and his grown daughter’s ongoing attempts to “help,” the internet had decided he required help too.

The house still held a whisper of coffee from earlier that morning. Beyond the back windows, the ocean moved in slow gray-blue lines beneath an overcast sky. Early April couldn’t decide what season it wanted to be.

In another month, Oceanside's boardwalk would fill with tourists and rental bikes and sunburned families. For now, the town still belonged to the locals.

Saturday was uncomplicated—Scripture, coffee, maybe a walk on the beach if the weather behaved.

Not camera crews.

Not a global pop star standing on his porch.

All because he clicked the wrong advertisement while checking stock reports three weeks earlier.

Elliot adjusted the cuffs of his shirt as he crossed the foyer, already trying to think of a polite way to survive whatever this experience was supposed to be.

The doorbell rang.

Too cheerful. Too loud.

He opened the door.

And there she was.

Nova Hart.

Until she stepped inside, Elliot had never noticed how much noise the old house made.

Not because she was louder than the room.

Because nothing about her belonged to rooms this quiet.

The woman beside her looked smaller than the version the world projected onto stadium screens.

Not less striking.

Just more real.

A tall man lingered near the porch steps in a dark windbreaker, alert and composed, watching the street with practiced discretion.

"We're clear," he said.

"Thank you, Reid," she replied, her voice low and calm.

The man gave Elliot a brief nod before stepping back toward the SUV.

“Security,” Nova said, sounding apologetic. “Reid distrusts anything without metal detectors.”

“Reasonable philosophy these days,” Elliot replied.

That earned the first real smile he’d seen from her.

She stepped inside with the calm ease of someone long accustomed to cameras and strangers. A trace of cool ocean air followed her into the foyer before fading. The denim jacket she wore looked softened with use rather than styled for effect.

Her boots tapped across the hardwood.

When her eyes met his, he forgot whatever polite thing he had been about to say.

He had expected someone younger, somehow.

Less composed.

Less... real.

The next voice arrived before he could think too hard about that.

“This light is incredible.”

A woman swept through the doorway, carrying both a tablet and enough energy for the entire group. Her eyes began tracking windows, angles, and reflections.

“Right here by the staircase,” she announced. “The people who built this house apparently respected natural lighting.”

Nova gave Marcy a look that suggested she’d heard this speech before.

“Most houses ignore their potential,” Marcy said.

The woman turned toward him and smiled.

“Marcy,” she said, glancing past him toward the growing commotion in the foyer. “If somebody starts moving furniture without asking, let me know before Nova sees it.”

Elliot stepped aside before the rest of the production team ended up standing on his porch.

“Nice to meet you.”

“Promise we’ll be quick,” Marcy said, already adjusting a camera lens.

Behind them, the rest of the crew entered with a steady wave of movement and equipment.

Cases thumped onto hardwood floors. Light stands unfolded. Voices overlapped.

Elliot’s foyer no longer felt entirely like his.

The photographer lifted his camera.

“There we go, Mr. Brooks. Relax those shoulders. Just like you’re enjoying this.”

Elliot exhaled.

Be still.

He let the breath go.

His shoulders had not fully relaxed since the morning his wife died.

Through the movement and camera flashes, Nova’s grin caught him mid-thought.

“Elliot Brooks?”

“That depends,” he said. “If you’re here to sell me a cable bundle, I’m not interested.”

Her smile widened.

“And if you’re the pop star,” he added, “I’m probably in trouble.”

She looked down at the floor briefly, but the smile stayed.

“Good,” she said. “I’d hate to start with a disappointment.”

He blinked, surprised into laughing with her.

Nova paused near the staircase, her gaze lifting toward the tall windows and chandelier overhead.

“It’s beautiful,” she said. “Big, but lived in.”

Her hand brushed along the polished banister as if testing whether the house was real or just another staged backdrop.

“Right here,” the photographer called. “Window light is perfect. Nova, lean in a little. Mr. Brooks, step beside her.”

Elliot moved into place before common sense could interfere.

The photographer circled them.

“Closer.”

Nova angled toward him, one shoulder brushing his arm.

He reminded himself it was only a photograph.

Details he hadn’t noticed a moment earlier began surfacing anyway.

The faint scent of salt air caught in her jacket. The warmth beneath the denim.

“Arm around her, Mr. Brooks.”

Elliot hesitated only a second before resting a careful hand against the middle of her back.

Dangerous complication, he thought immediately.

Too public.

The photographer snapped several quick shots.

“There we go. Stay right there.”

Nova tilted her head toward him.

“See?” she murmured. “You’re surviving.”

“Barely.”

That earned another real laugh from her.

“Look at each other,” the photographer said.

Elliot obeyed before thinking better of it.

Her eyes met his.

Green. Steady. More tired than he had expected up close.

The camera clicked around them, but the noise no longer felt centered on either of them.

Then Nova blinked and stepped back first, almost as if she had remembered where she was.

The photographer lowered the camera.

"Oh, that is good," he said. "Don't lose that."

Across the foyer, Marcy was no longer watching the lighting.

Nova glanced away, smoothing one hand along the sleeve of her jacket.

"Do you ever get used to this?" Elliot asked, nodding toward the equipment and movement surrounding them.

"You don't," she said. "You just get better at pretending it's normal."

The crew shifted toward the windows for another setup while cables slid across hardwood floors.

Nova remained beside him instead of following.

Her gaze moved around the foyer again.

"Your house has a kind of peace to it," she said finally. "Even with all this."

"Mostly it's just dust that's learned to settle."

A laugh escaped her.

"No," she said. "It's something else."

For a moment, neither of them moved.

Then the photographer lifted the camera again.

"One more."

Nova looked toward him this time instead of the lens.

And Elliot had the sudden, deeply inconvenient feeling that something inside the room had shifted.

"That's enough," Nova said, and the crew stopped moving.

Greg looked at his watch. "Nova—"

"Ten minutes," she said without looking at him.

Something in her tone ended the discussion.

Reid lingered near the doorway a moment longer, studying Elliot with the calm attention of someone used to evaluating risk.

Elliot met the look directly.

After a second, Reid gave a small nod.

"I'll be outside."

"The most rebellious thing I've done this week was eat ice cream for dinner," Elliot said. "I feel that should factor into your assessment."

To Elliot's surprise, Reid almost smiled before stepping out and closing the door behind him.

Silence settled over the house in slow layers after that.

Not complete silence.

The refrigerator hummed in the kitchen. Waves rolled somewhere beyond the back windows.

But compared to the last twenty minutes, it felt almost sacred.

Nova looked around the foyer again, the tension in her shoulders easing now that nobody was directing her where to stand.

"I hope we didn't completely take over your morning."

"It's all right," Elliot said. "Though I'm fairly certain my house now qualifies as a production studio."

That drew another small laugh from her.

Her attention drifted toward the mantel.

A silver-framed photograph sat near the edge, beside an old clock.

A younger Elliot stood smiling beside a woman with warm eyes and a little girl tucked between them.

Nova's attention settled on the picture.

"Your family?"

Elliot nodded once.

"My wife passed away five years ago."

Saying it out loud still felt unfamiliar sometimes. Not sharp anymore. Just heavy in familiar places.

"I'm sorry," she said.

And unlike most people, she didn't rush to fill the silence after saying it.

That alone made him like her a little.

"You really don't seem like my usual fan," she said after a moment.

"Should I be fanboying more?"

Her mouth curved into a slight smile.

"Probably."

She leaned against the edge of the mantel, studying him for a second.

"Most people either perform for me or panic around me."

"And I'm doing neither?"

"You're studying the exits," she said.

"That's habit."

"Military?"

"Long time ago."

She nodded as if that explained more than he intended to reveal.

Then her eyes returned to him again, thoughtful now.

"Most people want the fantasy," she whispered. "You seem more interested in what's real."

Her words left a lingering impression on both of them.

Elliot let out a breath.

"I'm still not convinced this whole contest thing actually happened."

She looked down, smiling before she could stop herself.

For a moment, she looked nothing like the woman on the magazine covers.

"Well," she said, "congratulations."

He raised an eyebrow.

"You are officially my most accidental fan."

“Glad to stand out.”

She didn’t look away immediately this time.

Not for the cameras.

“Oh,” she murmured. “This is going to be fun.”

CHAPTER TWO

ELLIOT

The house settled into a slower rhythm. Somewhere behind them, the surf eased against the shore. A gull passed overhead, its cry carrying through the air.

Nova tipped her chin toward the hallway. “We have what, eight minutes?”

Elliot checked the grandfather clock. “Seven, if your manager is punctual.”

“He is punctual about ruining fun.” She let out a small, conspiratorial smile. “Show me something they didn’t photograph.”

He almost said no. His house was not a showplace. The floors carried scuffs, the rugs had survived years of traffic, and the mugs never matched. Still, he motioned toward the archway. “This way.”

He led her into the den. Shelves lined one wall, filled with novels whose spines were sun-faded, a fine trace of dust catching the beam of light that slipped through the window. A low table held faint circles from forgotten coffee cups. On the mantel, a photograph rested at a

slight angle, a young girl at the beach holding driftwood like a treasure, a woman's hand reaching in from the side of the frame to take it.

"You have books," she said softly. "I like that."

"Old habits," he said. "My wife, Sarah, used to call them clutter with bindings."

A brief smile touched his mouth, gentle and worn. "She passed five years ago. The books stayed."

"I am sorry," she said.

Nova's gaze lingered on the photo a moment longer, then returned to him. She didn't ask anything else.

He was grateful for that, and offered a small nod in return.

Her fingers brushed the back of a chair. "Hotel rooms all look the same. I forget what real rooms feel like."

He almost told her this one didn't always feel like home to him either, not anymore, but he nodded toward the windows instead. "There is a better view in here."

Elliot paused. "My life is not exactly a tour."

"Good," Nova said, her mouth curving. "I am tired of rehearsals."

She wandered a few steps farther into the room. Her fingertips brushed the edge of a table beside a half-empty coffee mug. Her gaze moved to a worn Bible, the cover softened from years of use. She touched the corner lightly, as if testing the story behind it.

She glanced around again—the worn rug, the dip in the sofa cushion, books stacked unevenly on the side table.

"It's real here," she said softly. "Most places I walk into feel staged. This one doesn't."

"That is because it is," he said. "I would not know how to fake it."

"You can feel when a place has been prayed in."

He looked at her. "You can?"

She lifted her eyes, offering a small, knowing smile. "You would be surprised by what people try to get when the noise fades. It gets quiet out there too. Just... different."

He didn't answer right away, as if the answer had landed somewhere he hadn't expected. "Honest answer," he said.

Her gaze moved around the room again, slower this time. "Surrounded and still alone," she said. "Then maybe I should see more of it. Whatever makes this place feel the way it does."

He studied her, then nodded toward the hallway. "You really want to see it?"

He led her to the glass doors at the far end of the den. They opened to a small balcony above the dunes. The ocean stretched wide and gray-blue, unhurried. A strand of hair slipped loose, and she tucked it behind her ear while her eyes stayed on the horizon.

"Okay," she whispered. "That is an unfair view."

"It came with the house."

"You did not bargain for the ocean?"

"I am not much of a bargainer."

She reached for the door handle at the same time he did.

Their hands brushed on the handle.

Just for a second.

But long enough for him to notice.

Nova looked toward the ocean after that, tucking a loose strand of hair behind her ear as if she suddenly needed somewhere else to focus.

Up close, the silver threaded through her auburn hair and the tiredness around her eyes became impossible to miss.

Older than the magazine covers suggested, and somehow more real because of it.

"Most of the places I stay don't even open their windows," she said quietly. "Here, it smells alive."

"Maybe that is the ocean reminding you it exists," he said.

Some of the performance slipped out of her expression.

"You notice things."

"Sometimes," he said, "when it matters."

He expected her to step away after that.

She didn't.

The moment stretched between them, filled with the distant wash of the surf and the cool salt air drifting through the open doorway.

Then Nova nodded toward the hallway.

"Come on," she said lightly. "Before my time is up. I need to see if your coffee is as serious as your bookshelf."

They moved back through the den to the kitchen. Sunlight stretched across the counters, glinting against the kettle and the row of mismatched mugs beside the sink.

Nova lifted herself onto the counter as if she belonged there already, boots dangling just above the hardwood.

"So, Elliot," she said, swinging one foot lightly, "what do you recommend for somebody who's forgotten what an actual meal tastes like?"

He opened the refrigerator and studied the sparse contents.

"Probably another poor decision."

He pulled out a foil-covered tin.

"Half a cherry pie," he said. "Assuming time has not claimed it."

"Perfect." The teasing in her voice lingered longer than it should have. "Seven-minute pie date. I will take it."

He peeled back the foil and handed her a fork.

Their fingers brushed briefly.

Warm enough to notice.

Nova broke through the crust with the edge of the fork and took a bite, her eyes closing briefly afterward.

"Most of what I eat lately comes in plastic packaging and gets handed to me in a car."

She looked down at the pie again.

"This feels... nicer than it probably should."

"Sugar and questionable judgment," Elliot said.

"The best kind."

She nudged the pie tin toward him.

"Your turn."

He took a bite and considered it seriously enough to make her laugh again.

"Better than expected," he admitted.

"That is your review?" she asked. "You are hard to impress."

A small smile pulled at the corner of his mouth.

"Maybe I just don't hand out reviews easily."

Something thoughtful moved across her expression then.

"You don't seem like someone who does anything easily."

Elliot leaned lightly against the counter.

"That sounds dangerously close to psychoanalysis."

"Occupational hazard."

"Pop star?"

"Human observation."

The answer caught him off guard enough that he looked away briefly.

"Tell me something real," she said. "Not favorite-color real. Actual real."

He thought about it.

"I read the Bible every morning," he said. "I burn toast at a statistically impressive rate. And I tried jogging on the beach once. The beach won."

Nova laughed fully this time, her head tipping back slightly.

"That makes sense," she said. "Sand is absolutely a scam."

Elliot glanced toward the clock near the stove.

"You are down to five minutes."

"Then stop hiding behind the clock."

Her tone stayed light, but the words landed differently anyway.

"This is your home," she said. "What do you actually like about this place? Oceanside."

Elliot shrugged slightly.

"It minds its business. You can walk the boardwalk and nobody cares if you buy seashell magnets in your fifties."

She smirked.

"Do you buy seashell magnets in your fifties?"

"Only on reckless occasions. Sometimes I even buy taffy."

"Dangerous."

Her eyes warmed again before she looked toward the kitchen window, toward the narrow square of pale sky beyond it.

"My turn," she said more quietly. "Something real."

She hesitated just long enough for him to notice it.

"I like this better than stadium lights."

"And," she added with faint humor, "the attention of fans isn't the same thing as being seen."

The words settled into the room between them.

Nova tapped her fingers lightly against the countertop before giving him a smaller smile.

"Anyway," she said, "you are an excellent host."

"All I did was give you pie I probably should not even own."

"Exactly," she said. "Authentic."

She set the fork down beside the tin.

"Next time we skip the small talk."

Elliot raised an eyebrow.

"Next time we skip the small talk."

Elliot raised an eyebrow.

"Honestly, I trust people who lead with pie."

Her hand settled on the counter beside his.

Then stayed there.

The warmth of her fingers settled against the back of his hand.

After a second, her pinky shifted slightly against his.

Small and careful.

Not accidental.

He didn't move either.

The contact lingered between them until the knock came from the foyer.

"Nova. Schedule," Greg called.

Her hand slipped away immediately.

The absence of her hand felt noticeable.

Elliot straightened slightly, pretending his attention had already shifted toward the hallway.

Nova smoothed one sleeve of her jacket, the polished composure from earlier slipping back into place almost instantly.

"Duty calls," she said.

She hopped down from the counter, though when she looked back at him, the expression in her eyes softened again.

"Thanks for not making this weird."

Elliot let out a quiet breath.

"I am trying my best at not understanding any part of this."

"Keep doing that," she said. "The not trying part."

She took one final bite of pie before setting the fork down carefully beside the tin.

"Nova," Greg called again, closer now.

She started toward the doorway, then stopped halfway there.

“There is a local experience thing included in this contest, right?” she asked. “The fine print nobody reads?”

Elliot blinked once.

“Possibly.”

“Good.”

She pointed lightly toward him.

“I am cashing it in.”

“That sounds mildly threatening.”

“Breakfast tomorrow,” she said, ignoring that. “Somewhere normal. No cameras. You pick.”

Elliot opened his mouth, several reasonable objections arriving all at once.

She was already moving again before he could say any of them.

“Text Greg,” she called over her shoulder. “He will pretend this was his idea.”

She reached the door and glanced back one last time.

“For the record,” she said, “that was a superb pie date.”

Elliot looked down at the pie tin, unable to hide the reaction entirely.

“I will add it to my résumé.”

Her grin widened.

“Careful. You will get requests for sequels.”

He watched her pull the door open, ocean wind catching the edge of her jacket again.

“I’m coming, Greg,” she called, her voice brighter now.

Then quieter:

“See you tomorrow, Elliot.”

The door closed behind her.

Silence settled back through the kitchen in slow layers.

The refrigerator hummed softly.

Somewhere beyond the windows, waves rolled against the shore.

Elliot looked down at the half-finished pie, the two forks resting beside each other, the faint warmth still lingering where her hand had touched his.

For the first time in years, he found himself wondering if God answered prayers in ways people never thought to ask for.

“Breakfast,” he murmured quietly to himself. “Right.”

Ten minutes later, his phone buzzed.

Remember. Breakfast tomorrow. You choose. — N

Elliot stared at the screen a moment before typing back.

Okay. 9 a.m. Harbor Light Cafe. Good coffee. Terrible chairs.

Need to be done by ten. Church.

Her reply appeared almost immediately.

Perfect. I like terrible chairs. Keeps a girl humble.

And I promise not to make you late for church.

He laughed softly under his breath, saved her number as “N,” and set the phone face down on the counter.

Around him, the house slowly settled back into itself.
He told himself tomorrow would be easy.
As if saying it might make it true.

CHAPTER THREE

*I used to sing beneath the trees,
Barefoot dreams in the summer breeze.
No stage, no lights, no plans to prove,
Just sound and sky, and room to move.*

- Nova Hart, from “Before the Noise”

12 weeks at #1

NOVA

It was not easy. Not at all.

Nova tightened both hands on the steering wheel as the rented SUV rolled past the marina for the second time.

Harbor Light Café sat just ahead, tucked beside the boardwalk beneath a faded blue sign that looked older than half the buildings around it.

She still had time to leave.

That was the problem.

At a red light, she glanced down at the open text thread and typed before she could reconsider it.

Running a few late. Didn't tell Reid.

He would've followed me.

No rush. Chairs are still terrible.

Perfect.

Have not driven a car myself in months!

Despite herself, Nova laughed.

Five minutes later, she parked beside the marina and killed the engine.

For a moment, she stayed there listening to gulls somewhere beyond the boardwalk and the soft rattle of the wind against the SUV.

Then she pulled the hood a little lower and stepped out into the salt air.

Warm light glowed through the diner windows.

She spotted Elliot immediately.

He looked like the kind of man who arrived early to places.

He sat in the corner booth with both hands around a coffee mug, calm and completely at home in the low hum of the diner.

She drew one slow breath and opened the door.

The small bell above it jingled softly.

A few people glanced up before returning to their breakfasts.

Elliot looked up last.

His expression changed the moment he saw her—not dramatically, just enough for her to notice.

Warmth.

Relief maybe.

Something she suddenly found herself wanting to see again.

She crossed toward the booth, morning light catching the edge of her hair beneath the ball cap.

“You made it,” he said, starting to stand out of reflex.

She slid into the opposite side first. “Wouldn’t miss it. Besides, I owed you a normal breakfast.”

“Normal might be ambitious,” he replied, smiling.

Elliot wrapped both hands around his mug. “So. This is ... surreal.”

“Which part? The pie for breakfast guy or the pop star who bribed her manager with airline miles to get an extra morning in town?”

He blinked once. “You bribed him?”

“I prefer negotiated. I told him I would do the late-night talk show in Los Angeles if he gave me a real morning here. And by real, I mean one that does not involve lighting, excessive makeup, or microphones.”

He shook his head. “Seems like a high price for coffee.”

“That is how you know it is worth it,” she said. “Besides, you promised terrible chairs. I am here for the full local experience.”

Elliot tried not to stare.

In daylight, she looked less polished than she had on camera yesterday. Freckles showed beneath the makeup she no longer wore, and exhaustion blurred the polished edges the world usually saw.

Nova turned her mug slowly between her hands. “You know the funny part? We did the whole official shoot at your house yesterday. Lights, crew, the works. Greg was thrilled with the pictures.”

Elliot nodded once, waiting.

"Then Greg took one look at them later and vetoed the whole batch."

Elliot raised an eyebrow. "That bad?"

A faint smile touched her mouth. "His exact words were: 'These don't look promotional anymore.'"

Elliot set his mug down carefully but didn't say anything.

Nova glanced toward the window, her expression softening into something quieter. "Unscripted moments tend to get expensive."

Elliot leaned back slightly. "So the staged photos stay private, but the terrible-chair breakfast is the dangerous one?"

"Exactly," she said with a low laugh. "The internet likes the unscripted version best."

Doreen approached with her order pad and a pot of coffee, smiling in that half-curious, half-knowing way only small-town waitresses seemed capable of perfecting.

"Morning, hon. Coffee?"

She poured Nova a cup before waiting for an answer.

Nova took a sip, winced immediately, then grinned. "Wow. That is strong enough to qualify as a medical procedure."

Doreen laughed. "House blend."

Then she glanced toward Elliot with a teasing look. "Thought you said you weren't expecting anyone, Mr. Brooks."

Elliot nearly choked on his coffee. "Guess I was mistaken."

"Lying to waitresses now?" Doreen topped off his mug with a smirk. "Bold strategy for a first date."

"It is not a date," Elliot said, though the denial arrived thinner than intended.

Doreen gave him a patient look. "Honey, I've worked breakfast shifts for twenty-three years."

Nova pressed her lips together, trying not to laugh.

Doreen gave them both a look that suggested she'd seen this kind of thing before.

Then her eyes shifted back to Nova.

Recognition landed almost instantly.

Nova felt her shoulders tighten.

For a second she expected the shift—the excitement, the questions, the sudden change people always made once they realized who she was.

Instead, Doreen stepped back toward the booth and lowered her voice.

“Don’t worry, sweetheart,” she said gently. “Your secret’s safe with me.”

Nova blinked, caught off guard by the sincerity.

“I believe you.”

Doreen patted the edge of the table once before straightening. “Enjoy your breakfast, honey.”

Elliot watched the exchange over his coffee, amused. “Even in disguise, you still get recognized.”

Nova stirred cream into her cup. “Yeah. But at least she feels like somebody who knows how to keep a secret.”

“Most people here do,” he said. “Part of the charm.”

Something about the quiet certainty in his voice made her lower her guard before she meant to.

“Then maybe you picked the right café.”

“Maybe I did.”

Nova leaned back slightly in the booth. “So tell me something, Elliot. What exactly is your deal? You look like somebody who alphabetizes his spice rack.”

“I do,” he admitted. “Except for paprika. I cannot commit to where it belongs.”

Nova frowned thoughtfully. "Technically, isn't paprika just ambitious pepper?"

Elliot stared at her for a second. "That may be the most upsetting thing anyone has ever said in this diner."

"Wild man."

"Living dangerously," he agreed.

"And you?" he asked. "Do pop stars alphabetize?"

The humor faded slightly from her expression.

"I don't unpack anymore," she said. "Half the time I don't even know what somebody packed for me."

Elliot studied her quietly over the rim of his mug.

"I don't think that's supposed to sound as lonely as it does."

The honesty of it caught her off guard enough that she looked away briefly.

"People expect shiny," she said eventually, tracing one finger along the edge of her mug. "Nobody really knows what to do with normal."

Elliot rested his elbows lightly against the table. "You get tired of being expected all the time?"

Nova laughed once under her breath. "I get tired of pretending it's easy."

Silence settled briefly between them.

"Yesterday slowed down for a minute," she admitted.

Elliot frowned slightly. "When?"

She looked down briefly, composure slipping for a second.

"The pie."

Heat climbed into his expression almost instantly.

"And the quiet," she added gently. "You didn't rush to fill it."

Elliot leaned back slightly. "I'm not especially gifted at filling things. Conversations. Empty rooms. Holes in drywall..."

Doreen returned with a pen poised above her pad. "So, what are we having this morning?"

Nova handed back the menu she had barely opened. "Pancakes, bacon, and those crispy potatoes that make people rethink their life choices."

"Home fries," Doreen corrected, scribbling it down approvingly. "Good choice."

Elliot closed his menu. "Eggs and toast. Predictable but safe."

"Nothing wrong with safe," Doreen said before heading toward the kitchen.

Nova watched her go, then looked back at him. "You do not strike me as a man who is actually safe."

He lifted an eyebrow. "No?"

"You act steady," she said, studying him over the rim of her mug. "But I bet there's a little chaos tucked under the collar."

He smiled. "Chaos feels generous. These days I'm mostly routine and tax deductions."

"Please." Her expression drifted into amusement. "You were halfway charming before you started sounding like an accountant."

"Halfway?"

She leaned forward slightly. "You'd probably get the other half if you stopped trying so hard to be predictable."

Elliot laughed then, low and real. "You think I'm trying to be boring?"

"Definitely."

"That harsh?"

"That observant."

He tilted his head, amused. "And you figured that out before breakfast arrived?"

Nova smirked. "I'm good at reading people. Comes with the job."

Elliot opened his mouth to answer, but Doreen appeared with two steaming plates balanced along one arm.

"Here we are," she said brightly. "Pancakes, bacon, eggs, and what looks suspiciously like a first date."

Elliot opened his mouth, reconsidered, and reached for his coffee instead.

Doreen smirked as she slid the plates onto the table. "Honey, I've worked breakfast shifts too long to miss this kind of thing."

Nova hid a grin behind her coffee cup.

"We appreciate the service, Doreen," she said lightly.

"Mm-hmm." Doreen straightened. "Enjoy yourselves, sweet-hearts."

Elliot waited until she disappeared toward the counter before exhaling. "You did not have to encourage her."

"Sure I did." Nova reached for the syrup. "Watching you panic has been the highlight of my morning."

He shook his head, faint color rising into his face. "Then I should probably tip better."

"Good answer."

Nova drowned her pancakes in syrup, then immediately winced.

"Too much. Proof I shouldn't adult before noon."

Elliot smiled into his coffee. "You seem to overthink syrup more than most people overthink their life choices."

"I have a complicated relationship with breakfast," she said, cutting into the pancakes. "Every tour morning some nutritionist lectures me about fueling my instrument. I just want pancakes."

Elliot watched her over the rim of his mug, smiling despite himself. She caught him looking. "What?"

"Nothing," he said. "Just collecting data."

"Data?"

"You talk faster when you're nervous, you overthink syrup, and you enjoy pretending you're not famous."

She tilted her head slightly. "You think you have me figured out after one awkward photo shoot and half a breakfast?"

"Half a breakfast is plenty of data."

Nova smirked. "You're confident for someone who looks mildly terrified."

"I'm not terrified," he said. "Just aware the world might implode if people realize you're having pancakes with a middle-aged man."

Her laughter came quick and genuine. "Then let's make a deal. You don't act starstruck, and I won't sign your napkin."

"Deal," he said. "Though if you did, I might auction it later."

Her grin widened. "You're getting better at this."

"At what?"

"Not pretending you dislike me."

He froze for half a heartbeat. "Didn't realize that was on the table."

"That's usually how breakfast works."

He laughed, surprised at himself. "You really don't have an off switch, do you?"

"Not when the conversation's good."

"Apparently I smiled first."

"You did."

"And that means?"

"In my world?" She leaned back slightly, eyes warm now. "It means you're in trouble."

He met her gaze evenly. "I'll take my chances."

"Careful, Elliot. You might make me forget I'm supposed to be mysterious."

He let out a quiet laugh. "Too late."

Neither of them reached for words right away.

Nova looked down at her pancakes, smiling faintly. "I don't remember the last breakfast that wasn't scheduled or photographed."

Elliot lifted one eyebrow. "Well, now it's both."

She laughed again, softer this time.

A bell jingled near the front door as a customer headed outside.

At the counter, a woman in her thirties with a local real estate tote lifted her phone slightly, pretending to scroll while angling the camera toward their booth.

The shot would have caught both of them clearly: Nova mid-laugh, hood half-down, leaning toward Elliot across the remains of breakfast.

Unguarded.

Unmistakable.

Elliot noticed immediately.

The woman glanced up and met his eyes.

She froze, lowered the phone, and looked back down at her plate.

Nova never noticed.

She speared another piece of pancake. "So... you have kids, right?"

Elliot hesitated briefly. "One. Grown. My daughter teaches here in Oceanside."

"She probably has opinions about all this."

"She doesn't know about this," he admitted. "And I'd prefer to keep it that way."

"Because?"

"Because I don't have the energy to explain why a pop star came over for pie."

Nova laughed. "You say that like it's a normal sentence."

"I'm adapting."

"Fast learner."

He sipped his coffee, avoiding her eyes. "You get used to strange situations when you live alone long enough. Everything is either absurd or boring."

"Then let's keep it absurd," she said, smiling faintly. "At least until my manager finds me."

"He'll probably track you by the scent of rebellion."

"And syrup," she said, brushing a sticky spot from her thumb.

His eyes followed the movement before he could stop them.

She noticed immediately.

Neither of them fixed it.

Nova broke first, laughter rounding her voice. "You are terrible at pretending you don't notice things."

"I'm out of practice," he admitted, his voice lower than intended.

Her smile lingered this time. "That's okay. I notice things too."

They both looked back down at their plates, letting the moment settle instead of rushing to fill it.

Somewhere near the counter, a phone chimed to life and one of Nova's songs drifted through the café—bright, familiar, impossible to miss.

Elliot reached for his coffee.

Nova groaned softly. "Well, that's awkward."

"It's catchy."

"Tell that to the guy who's about to realize I'm sitting five feet from him."

The man at the next table looked up, froze briefly, then blinked hard.

Nova pressed a finger lightly to her lips.

He nodded once and returned to his breakfast like he had just been entrusted with classified information.

Elliot smiled into his coffee. "That was impressive."

"Fear and charm," she whispered back. "Very effective combination."

Doreen returned with the check and set it beside Elliot's coffee.

"Y'all holler if you need anything else," she said before heading back toward the counter.

Nova watched her go, smiling faintly. "She definitely thinks you're the stable one."

Elliot folded the receipt once before reaching for his wallet. "That is because I radiate middle-aged dependability."

"You really do," she said. "It's honestly impressive."

He paid while the café carried on around them—plates clattering softly, low conversation drifting between booths, the steady rhythm of another Oceanside morning.

When they finally stood, neither of them seemed especially hurried to leave.

Nova pulled her hood back up, a faint smile still lingering at the corner of her mouth. "Thanks for breakfast."

Elliot nodded once. "Anytime."

She lingered for a second longer than necessary.

"Careful, Elliot," she said lightly. "You're starting to sound believable."

He met her eyes. "And that's dangerous?"

Something quieter flickered across her expression then.

"Maybe."

He held her gaze calmly. "Good mornings are rarer than people think."

Color touched her cheeks, faint but real.

"I should probably leave before Greg sends a search party."

"That seems wise."

Nova reached out then, fingertips brushing briefly against the sleeve of his jacket.

“Don’t disappear on me yet.”

Something gentler crossed his face. “Go before your manager starts a manhunt.”

She laughed under her breath.

“Thanks,” she said quietly. “For the normal.”

Then she slid her sunglasses back on and slipped out through the side door.

Elliot stayed where he was a moment longer, watching the door swing shut behind her.

Doreen appeared beside him almost immediately, coffee pot still in hand.

“Well,” she said. “You’re in trouble now.”

Elliot let out a quiet breath through his nose, unable to argue with that.

A minute later, he stepped outside.

Salt air drifted off the water, cool against his face. Beyond the boardwalk, the ocean moved in long blue-gray lines beneath the brightening morning sky.

Somewhere down the street, a car door closed.

He found himself smiling before he realized he was doing it.

The Harbor Light Café sign creaked softly overhead as Oceanside carried on around him, ordinary and unchanged.

Except somehow it wasn’t.

CHAPTER FOUR

CLARA

The last twenty minutes of the school day belonged to art projects, low attention spans, and the slow collapse of classroom discipline.

Clara Brooks moved between desks while construction paper, markers, and glue sticks spread steadily across every available surface in her third-grade classroom at Oceanside Christian Academy.

“Remember,” she said, stepping around a backpack abandoned in the aisle, “the assignment is somebody you admire. Not just somebody famous.”

“That’s basically the same thing,” Ethan announced from the back table while coloring a drawing of Michael Jordan.

“It absolutely is not.”

A few students argued immediately.

“My dad says famous people are mostly weird.”

Clara smiled despite herself.

Third graders possessed a unique ability to speak with complete confidence about subjects they understood only slightly better than raccoons understood traffic laws.

She stopped beside a little girl near the windows carefully coloring bright red hair with intense concentration.

"That's pretty," Clara said. "Who's yours?"

The girl looked up proudly. "Nova Hart."

Of course it was.

The drawing featured enormous green eyes, oversized earrings, and a microphone roughly the size of a baseball bat.

"Very nice," Clara said. "You worked hard on this."

"She writes her own songs," the little girl explained seriously. "And she gave money to animal shelters after the hurricanes. And my mom says her red hair is real."

A nearby boy leaned over immediately. "My brother says famous people all have chefs."

The little girl nodded solemnly. "I would still do it."

The classroom dissolved into overlapping conversations again.

"Can I admire Batman?"

"No fictional characters."

"What about Christian athletes?"

"Yes."

"What about my dog?"

"That depends. Is your dog honorable?"

The boy considered carefully. "Sometimes."

Clara laughed softly and moved toward the classroom library shelves while students continued coloring and debating with the energy only eight-year-olds could sustain at three-thirty in the afternoon.

Outside the tall windows, parents were already beginning to gather near the pickup line.

The room smelled faintly like crayons, dry-erase markers, and the cinnamon candle warmer hidden behind a stack of curriculum binders she technically was not supposed to have plugged in.

The final bell rang.

Instant chaos.

Backpacks zipped.

Papers shoved into folders.

Three students suddenly remembered entirely separate emergencies.

Parents filled the hallway outside the classroom now, waiting on children who moved at the speed of distracted squirrels.

“Ethan,” Clara called as a boy attempted to surf across the classroom floor standing on a rolling reading cart, “if you crash into my bookshelf again, I’m assigning extra memory verses.”

The boy grabbed the edge of a desk before the cart could hit the wall.

“That feels spiritually aggressive,” he complained.

“It’s supposed to.”

A few parents laughed from the hallway.

By 3:41, the classroom had finally settled into silence.

Not true silence. Third graders left behind too much evidence of themselves for that—crooked chairs, uncapped markers, paper scraps, and the lingering smell of crayons and animal crackers.

A knock tapped lightly against the open doorway.

“You still alive in here?”

Melissa Harper leaned against the frame holding an iced coffee and her phone.

Clara looked up from her desk. “One of my students asked if Noah got tired of shoveling giraffe poop.”

Melissa laughed. “That’s a fair question.”

Clara sat down with a sigh. “I told him we were out of time.”

Melissa smirked. “Nice deflection.”

She stepped inside.

Melissa taught fourth grade across the hall and somehow survived every school year through caffeine, sarcasm, and what Clara privately suspected was divine intervention.

"You staying late again?" Melissa asked.

"Parent emails and trying to figure out how twenty-seven glue sticks disappeared in three days."

"The glamorous life of private Christian education."

"Truly."

Melissa's mouth twitched. "Speaking of independently wealthy..."

"No," Clara said immediately. "I am not going on another blind date at thirty-one."

"I wasn't even going to say that."

"You absolutely were."

Melissa grinned.

Then she glanced back at her phone.

"Apparently Nova Hart is secretly seeing somebody in Oceanside now."

Clara rolled her eyes.

"Nobody secretly dates anyone in Oceanside. Mrs. Patterson at the pharmacy would know by dinner."

Melissa laughed.

Clara shook her head. "Besides, the average age of single men in this town is about sixty."

"That's not true."

"Fine. Fifty-eight."

Melissa smirked faintly. "Okay, fair. Your dad's what now?"

"Fifty-six in August."

Melissa's expression changed.

"...Wait."

She crossed the room quickly and turned the phone toward Clara.

The image was grainy and badly zoomed, obviously taken from somewhere inside Harbor Light Café.

Nova Hart leaned across a breakfast table mid-laugh, sunglasses pushed onto her head instead of hiding her face. Morning light caught the edge of her auburn hair while one hand rested near a coffee mug.

Across from her sat a man in a brown canvas jacket.

You couldn't fully see him.

Mostly shoulders.

Back profile.

One hand near a coffee cup.

But Clara's smile faded instantly.

The jacket was the same brown canvas one her father wore to church on rainy mornings.

Her stomach dipped.

"That looks like my dad's jacket."

Melissa leaned closer.

"Wait... the brown jacket?"

Clara zoomed in further even though the image blurred.

But it was not really the jacket that convinced her.

It was the posture.

Steady.

Patient.

Completely focused on Nova like the rest of the room had quietly disappeared.

Her father listened to people that way.

Like what they were saying mattered completely.

Melissa's eyes widened.

"Oh my gosh."

Neither of them spoke for a second.

"Melissa..." Clara said quietly. "What if that's actually my dad?"

Melissa looked back at the picture.

“I mean... maybe?”

Clara stared at the screen.

“What is he doing?”

Not angry.

Just genuinely bewildered.

Because Elliot Brooks did not end up in blurry celebrity gossip photos.

He drank coffee on his porch.

Led elder meetings.

Helped neighbors reset their Wi-Fi passwords.

He belonged to quiet things.

Outside, a bus hissed loudly as it pulled away from the curb.

Clara kept staring at the image.

Not posed.

Not polished.

Not celebrity careful.

Just... unguarded.

And somehow that unsettled her more.

Melissa lowered herself backward into one of the student desks.

“Well,” she said carefully, “local Facebook is currently acting like Harbor Light hosted the royal wedding.”

“That’s ridiculous.”

“You haven’t read the comments.”

“I do not want to read the comments.”

Melissa ignored that completely.

“Apparently half the town thinks she’s filming something here.”

“That would honestly be preferable.”

Melissa studied her for a moment. “You okay?”

Clara opened her mouth automatically to say yes.

Then stopped.

After her mother died, there had been months when Clara wondered if her father would ever sound fully awake again.

Eventually he had rebuilt a life anyway.

Slowly.

Deliberately.

The man in that photograph looked more alive than her father had in years.

That should have made Clara happy.

Instead, it scared her a little.

Melissa stood slowly.

“For what it’s worth,” she said gently, “your dad deserves to feel alive again too.”

The words lingered after she left.

Clara stared back at the photo.

At Nova Hart leaning toward her father like whatever he was saying mattered more than the noise around them.

Then her eyes drifted back to Elliot.

Or what little of him the picture revealed.

Broad shoulders.

Brown jacket.

Completely focused on her.

Her phone was already in her hand before she consciously decided to call him.

Elliot answered on the second ring.

“Hey, kiddo.”

Warm.

Easy.

And somehow lighter than usual.

Clara leaned back slowly in her chair.

“So,” she said carefully, “how famous are you currently?”

His groan rumbled softly through the speaker.

“I was wondering how long it would take before somebody sent you that picture.”

Despite herself, Clara smiled faintly.

“So it is you.”

A pause.

Then, cautiously, “In my defense, Harbor Light usually feels safer than this.”

She laughed softly.

And there it was again.

That warmth in his voice.

Not forced.

Not polite.

Real.

“How bad is it?” she asked.

“Well, Doris at church texted me three prayer hands and a winking emoji, so I assume civilization is ending.”

Clara laughed before she could stop herself.

But the sound faded quickly.

For the first time in years, her father sounded like someone expecting tomorrow to matter.

And somehow that frightened her more than the picture itself.

CHAPTER FIVE

ELLIOT

The Harbor Light Cafe photo reached Elliot the way most modern news traveled: through a family member with faster thumbs.

It was a little after two when his phone buzzed across the counter while he rinsed a mug.

The preview showed Clara and a message that began without a greeting:

Dad????

His stomach sank before he even opened it. Nothing good ever started with that tone.

Then came another bubble, a screenshot from a local food blogger he didn't know, someone who tagged coffee shops and breakfast plates with equal devotion.



“Pretty sure that’s @NovaHartHQ at breakfast in Oceanside!”

The photo was grainy, taken at an angle from somewhere near the counter. Nova’s hood was half-down, her cap beside her on the table. She was mid-laugh, leaning toward him across the remnants of breakfast. Not performing. Not posing. Her expression open in a way that did not belong to magazine covers or interviews.

Beneath the image, Clara had repeated:

Dad!!!!

He typed the safest thing he could think of.

The chairs were terrible.

Her typing dots appeared, vanished, reappeared, then the messages came in rapid succession.

I see your jacket.

The one you’ve “retired” three times.

Call me.

Elliot paused, then set the phone face down on the counter.

He called.

She answered on the first ring. "Please tell me that is your doppelgänger."

"It's me," Elliot said.

She exhaled sharply. "I'm just trying to understand how my dad ends up in a picture with one of the most famous people in the world. Start from the beginning."

Elliot stared out the kitchen window. Some of the tension had left his shoulders.

He took that as God doing what He often did — steadying him before he knew he needed it.

"The prize ended at the photo shoot," he said. "Breakfast was her idea. I just picked the chairs."

"The prize to what, exactly?"

"The contest," he said. "The one I accidentally entered."

She paused. "What contest?"

"There was a web banner," he said. "I thought it was market alerts."

There was a beat.

"Probably not," he admitted.

"Dad," she drawled. "I feel like I'm missing a step."

He cleared his throat. "Well ... technically, breakfast wasn't part of the original plan."

"What does that mean?"

"The prize was supposed to be a short promotional visit," he said.

The pause felt sharper this time.

"Promotional how?"

He hesitated. "A, uh ... photo shoot."

"A photo shoot?"

"For a promotional thing," he blurted. "Nothing dramatic. She was polite. Professional."

"Where was this photo shoot?"

"Here," Elliot said.

"Here, here?"

"At my house."

"Dad. What?"

Neither of them spoke right away.

"Give me ten minutes," she said, concern threading through the words she tried to keep steady. "I'm coming over."

He had time to turn off the kettle and pour the steaming water into the French press before the doorbell rang.

She stood on the porch with her tote bag threatening to split under the weight of a laptop, a water bottle, and the general burden of being the responsible one.

Her ponytail showed she hadn't stopped moving since dawn.

He opened the door. "That was fast."

"I was already halfway here," she said, stepping past him. Her eyes made a slow sweep of the entryway, taking inventory with the precision of someone who notices what others miss.

"Someone tagged the photo at Harbor Light Café. So it really was you. At that table. With her."

He exhaled. "Guilty."

Clara dropped her tote on the chair and leaned against the counter, arms crossed like she was bracing for impact.

"I'm not mad," she said.

The word almost held.

Almost.

Clara crossed her arms tighter and looked toward the sink instead of at him. "I'm scared."

Elliot did not answer. Not yet.

"Mom's been gone five years," she said. "And you've been fine."

Fine did not mean fine.

“Too fine,” she added. “Bible every morning. Church every Sunday. Work. Coffee. Helping neighbors reset passwords like nothing ever happened.”

Her eyes moved toward the mantel, then away again.

“But I see it, Dad.”

That landed harder than he expected.

“The way you look at Mom’s picture when you think nobody’s watching.”

Elliot stepped forward and pulled her into a hug.

She held on tighter than she had in years. When they finally pulled apart, Clara wiped her eyes and gave a shaky laugh. “Okay. I needed that. Now ... tell me everything else. Because people are already writing the love song.”

“I mean ... she’s Nova Hart, Dad.” Clara’s voice climbed with each word. “People are already acting like this is some hidden love story. You’re older, nobody knows who you are, and that somehow makes it worse. They’re reposting it everywhere. Someone made a reel. There’s slow-motion analysis of her smile. Someone even set it to piano music.”

Clara glanced at the dirty pie tin in the sink. Her voice thinned. “Two forks?”

He looked toward the hallway. “Photo shoot. Long story.”

“A what?”

“It was part of the promotion,” he said. “Photos in the house. By the windows mostly.”

Clara stared at him.

He lifted a shoulder. “Apparently my foyer tested well.”

Clara’s eyebrow climbed. “You posed with her?”

“Briefly.”

"In *this* house?"

Elliot looked away.

Clara stared at him longer this time, like she was trying to picture it and regretting succeeding.

Her eyes moved to the corner of the room where her mother's lamp used to sit. She pressed her lips together and looked away.

"Unbelievable."

"She was polite," he said.

"I'm sure she was. Most people are when they're rearranging your furniture for online content."

He almost smiled. "You sound like your mother."

She went to the sink, grabbed a fork, then set it back down.

"Mom loved mornings like this," she whispered.

The kitchen still smelled faintly of coffee and breakfast.

"She did," he said, and the answer came without the familiar ache.

Clara straightened and crossed her arms again.

"It really was nothing, Clara. Truly."

Her expression softened just a little. "You keep saying that like it's supposed to make me believe you."

He smiled, the kind that didn't need defending. "It's supposed to make you worry less."

Clara shook her head, fighting the corner of a reluctant grin. "You really don't see what this looks like, do you?"

"It looks like breakfast," he said. "With terrible chairs."

The corner of her mouth twitched, but the concern stayed. "Dad, people aren't reacting to the pancakes. They're reacting to the way she was looking at you."

Elliot blinked, confused. "Looking at me?"

“Yes,” she said, drawing the word out. “Like you were the only person in the room. Like—” she hesitated, wrinkling her nose, “—like goo-goo eyes, if people still say that.”

He tried not to laugh. “I don’t think people have said that since 1987.”

“Exactly my point,” she said. “Which makes it even weirder that my dad is starring in a viral almost-romance.”

He raised an eyebrow. “You make it sound like a scandal.”

“Dad, she’s closer to my age,” Clara said. “People twist that faster than they breathe. You become the headline before anyone remembers you are a person.”

He leaned back against the counter, unruffled. “You think I’m worried about comments?”

“I think you should know that,” she said. “Because once people decide what story they want, facts barely matter. And right now they’ve decided you’re some mysterious older man who swept a pop star off her feet.”

He gave a slight smile. “I was just having breakfast.”

“I know.” Her voice softened. “That’s what worries me. You see the moment. They see the story.”

The humor faded into something gentler. “I’m not trying to ruin your ... whatever this is. I just don’t want people using you to sell a story.”

He nodded once. “I know.”

Elliot exhaled, slow and steady, but he did not step away from the weight of it.

“I can’t promise I won’t get hurt, Clara. Or that the world will be gentle.”

He looked toward the mantel. “Sometimes I miss your mom. The kind that comes from missing the way life used to sound.”

Her eyes flicked toward the mantel, to the photo of her mother. "I miss it too."

For a while, neither spoke. The clock hummed. The ocean murmured somewhere beyond the windows.

He met her gaze. "But I can promise you I'm not hiding from grief. And I'm not asking someone else to carry it."

He let the words settle before adding, "I am still here."

Clara searched his face, not for certainty but for truth. After a moment, she nodded once, as if deciding something.

Then she straightened, wiping her palms against her jeans. "Okay. I'm making rules."

"Of course you are."

"One," she said, holding up a finger, "don't post, don't comment, don't even like anything about this. Two, if she reaches out again, keep it private. No public cafes, no cameras, and definitely no news crews. And three, if this gets complicated, you call me first."

He smiled. "That's fair."

She exhaled, some of the tension slipping from her shoulders. "Good. Because I really don't want to explain to anyone that Dad's the reason TMZ discovered Harbor Light Café."

He laughed. "I'll try to keep my scandals local."

"That's all I ask." She gave him a quick hug. "Be careful, okay?"

He gave a nod, but the meaning of "careful" had become unclear, especially after hearing her laugh in his kitchen.

"Always."

She grabbed her tote, hesitated at the door. "You like her," she said.

He didn't answer right away. "I like that she is real. And kind. And not what I expected."

Clara studied him for another heartbeat, then nodded. "Okay. I can live with that."

The door closed with a whisper behind her.

The house returned to the stillness he had lived with for years, but it felt different now.

He cleaned the pie tin, the mugs, and the two forks and left them beside the sink.

CHAPTER SIX

*I used to chase the noise to feel alive.
Turns out quiet had been waiting all along.*
- Nova Hart, "Still," unreleased

NOVA

Nova sat on the edge of the hotel bed, the white duvet rumpled beneath her knees, unread notifications stacking faster than she could clear them.

Greg had already called twice. PR had sent a string of messages flagged urgent, and her label had forwarded three separate articles about the café photo.

She let the phone go dim in her hand and stared at the carpet until the noise inside her slowed.

But she lifted the phone again.

The viral image glowed across the screen, and she froze.

The photo caught them leaning toward each other across the table, her cap resting beside his coffee mug in the soft morning light. The

caption read: “Nova Hart spotted on breakfast ‘date’ in a small-town diner. Who’s the mystery man?”

Comments were already starting, some teasing, some sharp.

Her stomach twisted. It looked intimate. Not posed. Her expression was open in a way she never allowed publicly.

Unguarded.

The camera had caught something real, and now everyone was looking.

The only thing she cared about was whether Elliot had seen it alone.

She opened their thread and typed before she could second-guess herself.

You OK?

The typing dots appeared almost immediately.

Still standing. You?

Some tension loosened in her chest.

I saw the picture. Greg’s in crisis mode.

Another reply appeared.

I’m not.

She smiled despite herself.

Just wanted to make sure you're not overwhelmed.

The pause before his next message felt longer this time.
She typed:

Thank you for making space for me.

His reply came back quickly.

Anytime.

Dangerous offer.

I'll try not to abuse it :)

Concert prep in an hour. I'll go dark. But ...

She stared at the blinking cursor for a second before typing.

Don't disappear, okay? -N

The answer came back almost immediately.

I am good at staying put.

Something in her softened at that.

Then another message appeared.

And you do not have to keep signing with
“-N.” I figured it out.

A real smile pulled at her mouth.

Good. Because I’d hate to waste an extra
keystroke.

She hesitated before typing again.

And before you ask, I saved you as...

Pie Date!!!

His reply took longer this time.

You saved me as Pie Date?



Obviously. You earned it. And it made me smile.

She stared at the screen longer than necessary after that. Another message appeared.

I saved you as N. It seemed safer than your real name.

One letter. That feels careful and sweet all at once. The typing dots appeared. Vanished. Returned.

I like that you didn't make it complicated.

He responded quickly.

I am better at simple things.

Good. I could use more of those.

Greg's name flashed across the top of her screen again. She ignored it for one more second.

Gotta run. Greg's calling. Don't vanish, okay?



Not going anywhere.

She heart-reacted to the message and let the phone rest against her knee.

The chat went still.

But it no longer felt empty.

A knock sounded at the door, followed by the soft click of a key-card.

Marcy came in without ceremony, tablet under one arm, her other hand already raised. “Before you say anything, Greg is handling it. PR has a draft statement. Nobody needs you to respond tonight.”

She placed the tablet on the dresser and looked at Nova with the expression she reserved for situations that were both a crisis and not.

“Are you okay?”

“I’m okay,” Nova said.

Marcy studied her for a beat longer than necessary. “You’re smiling.”

“I’m not.”

“You were when I walked in.” She tilted her head. “Is this about the cybersecurity guy?”

Nova looked at her. “He’s not—how do you even know what he does?”

“I Googled him approximately four minutes after the photo dropped.” Marcy picked up the tablet, unbothered. “He seems steady. I like steady for you.”

She moved toward the door, then paused with her hand on the frame.

“Concert prep in forty. Eat something first.”

“I will.”

“And Nova.”

She stopped without turning around.

“The way you were looking at him in that photo.”

A beat.

“I hadn’t seen that in a while.”

She left before Nova could answer.

Nova sat with that for a moment.

Then she reached for the guitar leaning against the bed frame. The notebook lay open beside it, pages already marked with crossed-out lines from earlier in the week.

She balanced the guitar against her knee, fingers drifting over the strings without playing, and let her eyes settle on the half-finished lyrics.

A notification banner slid across the top of her screen.

The café photo again, reposted by another outlet, another fan, another stranger who thought they understood her life.

She silenced the phone and let it fall on the bed beside her.

The noise could be deafening. Yet something steadier had settled in this morning.

Her fingers moved across the old page, following the words of a song she had written long ago.

Mercy has a voice; I hear it through the silence.

Something in her eased.

Not fear.

Not pressure.

Recognition.

Silence wasn’t the right word anymore. Not after this morning. Not after him.

She crossed it out with one clean line and wrote a new word beneath it.

Mercy has a voice; I hear it through the quiet.

Her hand stilled over the page.

The kind of peace that didn't need an audience. The kind she had found sitting across from a man who hadn't tried to impress her.

Who hadn't chased her attention.

Who hadn't filled the space.

A man whose house felt prayed over without him ever saying so.

She shut the notebook and whispered, not to the room, not to the song, but to the God she hoped still listened in the middle of all her chaos.

"Thank You for the quiet. I didn't know how much I missed it."

Outside, city traffic murmured.

Inside, something in her settled.

She turned off the lamp, the notebook still open beside her.

And for the first time in a long time, Nova Hart fell asleep to peace instead of applause.

CHAPTER SEVEN

*I wasn't trying to make a scene,
just breathe where the world can't chase.
Then you laughed like the room turned clean
and I saw it there on your face.*

- Nova Hart, "That Look on Your Face", unreleased

NOVA

The space was dimly lit, and the echoes seemed to hang in the air.

Nova sat cross-legged on a black road case center stage, guitar balanced across her lap, a notebook open against one knee. A single work light burned overhead, washing the empty seats in a pale glow. Far up the aisles, someone tested cables; the faint buzz of an amp rose and faded again.

Her fingers shaped a soft chord, just half of one, the kind you play just to hear what it feels like. The note lifted, drifted through the rafters, and came back changed, but still hers. She tried another and hummed a few words that had been sitting on her tongue since breakfast two days ago.

“That look on your face...” The words came out low, almost cautious, as if testing their own weight.

She smiled to herself, reached for the pencil, and scratched out “Untitled E” and wrote the title across the top of the page: That Look on Your Face.

The ink dotted a little at the end where her hand had hesitated.

Reid lingered in the wings, half-lit by his phone, present without hovering. He did not ask questions or demand attention. He stayed where he was, enough to keep things from tipping. It wasn’t comforting the way Elliot’s presence had been. But it kept the room steady enough to play.

Her pencil tapped a rhythm on the notebook’s spine. “He didn’t fill the silence,” she murmured, “he made space for it.”

She wrote again, lines half-formed:

If the world gets loud, I’ll read it in the small places.

She tried the phrase aloud. The arena carried it and laid it back at her feet. The echo felt like agreement. Or maybe a nod she couldn’t see.

For a few minutes she forgot everything else: the lights, the crew, the trending page waiting on her phone. She just strummed, building the edges of a melody until it felt true.

The phone buzzed anyway. Greg.

Nova sighed, flipped the phone face up, and answered. Greg’s name had been waiting there for a while.

“Tell me you’ve seen it,” he said, no greeting. “#HarborLightBreakfast is everywhere. Half the commenters think it’s a music video stunt. The label’s already watching.”

She let him finish, eyes still on the ceiling. “They can watch something else. Not this.”

Greg breathed on the other end.

“Nova,” he said more carefully now, “it’s already being framed. If you don’t shape it, someone else will.”

“I’m not turning him into content.”

“He’s not a prop.”

Her pencil moved without her noticing, tracing a small spiral in the margin. “No names. No winks. This is not clickbait.”

“Nova—”

“I’ll handle it,” she said evenly. “We’ll talk later.”

She ended the call.

Reid glanced up from his phone in the shadows. He had heard enough to understand.

He lifted one eyebrow and gave a small nod, the kind that said he was on her side even without words.

“Next time you need pancakes,” he said, “let me drive.”

She almost smiled. “Next time I’ll let you.”

She looked down at the notebook again, at the messy scrawl and coffee ring staining the corner, and smiled.

“Looks like it’s just us,” she told the page.

She set the phone face down, slid her pick between the strings, and leaned back on her hands. A single work light burned overhead, washing the empty seats in a pale glow. Even by tour standards, the Raleigh stop had been loud.

Then, softly, she sang the verse again.

I wasn’t trying to make a scene...

The sound floated up into the rafters and settled back over the stage. When it faded, she felt as if the space had handed her voice back to her, clearer than before.

“That’s the line,” she whispered, and wrote it down before it could get away.

By mid-afternoon the stage was alive again, techs shouting cues, floor lights pulsing in rehearsal rhythm, the scent of ozone and coffee thick in the air. Nova's mic waited at center stage, its cord looped neatly like an obedient pet.

Greg's voice reached her before he did. "You're trending in four languages. We need a post today."

She didn't turn. "We need a rehearsal."

He climbed onto the stage, phone already in his hand, eyes flicking between screens. "It doesn't have to say much. A lyric line, a selfie, a grainy backstage shot ... anything that keeps you in control of the story before the internet writes it for you."

Nova kept her gaze on the empty seats, the way the light cut through the dust. "He's not a story."

Greg exhaled through his nose. "Everything is a story, Nova. At least let it be your version. Give them something, caption, an emoji, Morse code, I don't care. Just post."

She finally looked at him. "No."

He blinked. "Excuse me?"

"I said no. I'm not throwing him into the feed because you're nervous about optics."

"I'm nervous about your career," he shot back. "Blank silence looks guilty. You hired me to keep you standing, and right now standing means staying visible."

"I hired you to manage schedules and contracts," she said evenly. "I'll manage my conscience."

For a moment, the stage hummed louder than either of them.

Greg dropped his gaze to the phone, jaw tight. "Fine," he said at last. "Just don't make it worse."

"I'll make it music," she said.

He nodded once, almost imperceptibly, then walked off, his voice rising as he barked orders to a tech.

When the noise died down again, Nova sat on the edge of the stage, legs dangling over the side, and picked up her phone.

A new message blinked from Pie Date.

Hope sound check is quieter than those chairs.

Her mouth curved.

Barely. But I found a corner of the stage nobody's using.

His reply came almost instantly.

That's rare. Guard it.

She stared at the words, thumb hovering before she typed.

Want to hear what it sounds like when the noise stops?

A pause.

If that is an invitation, I may already be in trouble.

Her smile deepened.

After the show. I will send something.

She slipped her phone into her jacket, looked out over the empty seats, and whispered, "That's the plan."

By the time she reached the hotel, the streets had thinned to passing headlights and the hum of traffic.

The hotel suite was still half-lit from the mirror bulbs she hadn't bothered to turn off. A bouquet of congratulatory roses drooped in its vase beside the untouched catering tray. A thin hint of hairspray hung in the air, the last trace of the stage.

Nova kicked off her boots, letting them fall. Her pulse still ran too fast, a low thrum in her ears from the lights and noise. She pressed her fingers to her temples and waited for it to slow.

The room stayed loud inside her for a while.

Eventually, her breathing slowed.

She crossed to the window and pulled the curtain back an inch. The ocean outside was a dark mirror, the pier lights trembling across the surface. Somewhere below, a delivery truck hissed down the street. The normality of it felt like mercy.

On the vanity sat her guitar, exactly where Marcy had left it that morning after checking the tuning "just in case." Nova smiled, sat, and let the strap fall across her shoulder.

She strummed once, soft, ragged, the sound too small for an arena and right for a hotel room.

Then another chord, gentler. The air conditioner provided the beat.

Her phone waited beside the roses. She hit record.

“Okay,” she murmured, voice hoarse from the night. “One more before I lose it.”

The mic clicked on, and she played the lines that had followed her all day:

*That look on your face gave me my first quiet morning,
I kept it safe like a note between the pages.
If the world gets loud, I'll read it in the spaces between pages,
That look on your face, that look on your face.*

The words floated back through the room, thinner and truer than she expected. She let the last chord die before stopping the recording.

For a moment she just listened to the soft ring in her ears, the ocean below, the faint hum of electricity in the lights.

She trimmed the clip down to eleven seconds. No title, no emojis, no explanation. Just the sound.

Her thumbs hovered over the keyboard, then she typed:

In case you needed this tonight.

Send.

The message disappeared into the dark, carried by signals and satellites she didn't care to imagine.

Nova set the phone face down and leaned back in the chair. For the first time all night, the room felt still enough to breathe in.

CHAPTER EIGHT

I didn't know I was tired until someone let me rest.

- Nova Hart, "Still," unreleased

NOVA

A knock, then the soft click of a keycard.

Marcy swept in like the start of a storm, hair in a battle-ready knot, tote slung over one shoulder, scissors clipped to her pocket. "Tell me you did not make pod coffee again," Marcy said, already toeing off her boots.

Nova twisted the cap back on her water bottle. "You are such a coffee snob. But I did. It was an experiment in humility."

Marcy snorted, unpacking a practiced flurry of brushes, pins, and labeled jars.

"You are humble enough. And also cruel. Admit it tastes vaguely flammable."

Nova laughed. "Says the woman who weighs her coffee grounds as if she is performing surgery."

"Accuracy matters," Marcy said. "Sit."

Nova obeyed. The vanity lights hummed around them, casting their warm-white glow.

Marcy draped the cape around her shoulders, then paused. "New necklace?"

Nova touched it once — a small gold cross, thin enough to disappear under a collar. "Not new," she said. "Just wearing it again."

Marcy looked at her in the mirror for a half second longer than necessary, then reached for her brush. "Okay."

"You look like you slept," Marcy said.

"I did. No restless dreams. Just quiet."

That made Marcy glance up in the mirror. "You haven't said that since the pandemic."

"Don't throw confetti," Nova said. "Could be a fluke."

Marcy spun the chair toward the window, where a strip of ocean shimmered beyond the glass. "Better view. So, what's today's circus?"

"Rehearsals, fittings, radio, Greg's damage-control tour."

"Mm. Classic," Marcy clipped a section of hair. "For someone who sings in front of sixty thousand people, you've been awfully inside your own head lately."

Nova offered a faint smile. "Maybe I'm listening."

"To what?"

"Not feeling chased."

Marcy's brow lifted. "And what exactly lives in there lately?"

Nova hesitated, then gave in to the look Marcy was giving her. "Fine. The last two days have been different."

Marcy's eyebrow lifted. "Different like ... Pie Guy?"

Nova let out a small breath of amusement. "Do not start."

Marcy smiled without looking up. "Too late. Go on."

Nova turned toward the window, watching sunlight creep across the carpet.

“Breakfast that didn’t feel like work. A conversation where nobody was performing. He paid attention like he actually expected me to be real.”

She traced the edge of the window frame with her finger. “He actually thinks before he talks.”

A smile played on Marcy’s lips, but she said nothing, continuing to work through her hair.

Nova’s voice softened, wondering aloud. “He’s older. But it doesn’t feel off.” Her lips curved into a slight smile. “He made coffee as if it mattered. And there was pie. No plates. No pretending. We ate straight from the tin, Marcy.”

She glanced back at Marcy. “Somehow that made it feel honest.”

Marcy’s gaze met hers in the reflection, warm and unsurprised. “So he is the opposite of everything your life looks like right now.”

Nova exhaled, almost laughing. “Yes. That is it. It felt normal in a way I forgot I missed.”

Marcy didn’t answer right away. She kept working, fingers precise.

“You know they’ll pick him apart, right?”

Nova’s smile paused in the mirror. “Who?”

“The internet.” Snip. “Age. Background. Church attendance. Whether he tips twenty percent or nineteen.” She met Nova’s eyes in the reflection. “They’ll Google his lawn.”

Nova let out a breath that almost passed for a laugh. “He’s not running for office.”

“No,” Marcy said gently. “He’s just standing next to you.”

Nova looked down at her hands. “He didn’t ask for that.”

“Exactly.”

Marcy placed her hand on Nova’s shoulder for a moment. “I’m not telling you to stop. I’m telling you to know the cost before you call it simple.”

Nova nodded once. "It didn't feel complicated."

Marcy's mouth softened. "That's usually when it is."

She kept talking before she realized how much she had said. About the ocean air. The chairs. The way he listened.

Marcy did not interrupt. She did not have to.

When Nova finally caught herself smiling, she looked down and tucked a strand of hair behind her ear.

"We just texted," she said.

Marcy's reflection met hers in the mirror, one corner of her mouth lifting. "Sure you did."

They settled into the rhythm of snips and the hum of the air unit.

After a few minutes, Marcy spoke again, voice softer. "Write it down, whatever it is. Two lines. Even if it is trash."

Nova smiled. "You are bossy."

"Correct. Also, eat something that is not air."

Nova laughed. "You sound like my conscience."

"I am your conscience with better shoes."

Marcy packed her tools, kissed Nova's cheek, and said, "Text me after the fittings. Try not to let Greg turn your life into a press release."

When the door clicked shut, Nova turned back to the mirror. The ocean flashed behind her, endless and bright. Her phone lay on the vanity, screen dark.

She tapped it once. The screen filled with his name.

Heard it. Still hearing it.

There's something I should say before this goes any further.

Not tonight. Just so you know.

I move slow where my daughter is concerned.

Nova read the message twice. The smile emerged, then stayed. She closed the screen and whispered to her reflection, “Good.”

CHAPTER NINE

*The rushing of the ocean waves
is just what I need to breathe,
I left my noise in the city
and found what I can't keep.*

- Nova Hart, from "That Look on Your Face"

NOVA

The morning after the concert, Nova woke with the strange feeling that she had actually rested. Elliot's text waited on her phone like a held breath:

I move slow where my daughter is concerned.

She read it three times, thumb tracing the words. No rejection. Just truth. The kind she hadn't heard in years.

By noon, a local radio spot had been canceled, cracking the schedule open. A rare empty afternoon opened after last night's show up the coast. Greg was in meetings. Reid was checking the perimeter. She looked at the coastal road on her map app, then at the diner pin she'd saved weeks ago.

She texted Reid:

Heading to Oceanside. Back by evening.

Reid answered without delay.

Not alone. I follow at a distance or no go.

Nova typed back:

About two and a half hours coastal route. No convoy. I need this.

A pause, then:

Tracking stays on. Hourly check-ins. One deviation and I pull you back.

Don't make this a habit.

She exhaled, thumbs hovering, then:

Deal.

Then she drove. Nearly three hours of open road ahead, windows down, the sea breathing beside her, Reid's black SUV a small shadow in her rearview every few miles.

She checked her mirrors once, then again.

Old habit. The phone buzzed on the passenger seat and she left it face down. Two hours of road and she let herself pretend, just briefly, that she was nobody in particular going somewhere ordinary.

At the first stoplight into town, a car eased up beside her. Music spilled out — her own voice, soft and unmistakable. The driver sang along, smiling at the road, oblivious. Nova reached forward and turned off her radio. The silence swallowed the melody.

Oceanside came into view, steady, and salt-worn, like it had been waiting for her. The diner sign buzzed, half-lit and stubborn, brave against the wind.

She pulled into the small gravel lot beside the diner. Tires crunched. The windows glowed warmly against the early afternoon light.

Nova took one steady breath.

Then she texted Reid.

I made it. I am going inside for a bit.

She had texted Elliot only one line earlier: Heading your way. Diner, 2:30?

His reply had been simple: I'll be there.

She slipped her phone into her pocket before she could overthink it. She crossed the lot before she could reconsider it.

The bell above the door chimed as she stepped inside.

Inside, the diner was almost empty. A few stools lined the counter. The lights were soft and a little dim. The air smelled like coffee and syrup and salt.

Elliot sat near the window with a folded newspaper in his hands. When he looked up, surprise flickered across his face, then settled into something calmer. Relief, maybe. Or recognition.

Before Nova could speak, Doreen stepped out from behind the counter. Her eyes widened in recognition, but her voice stayed easy.

"Well," Doreen said. "I wondered if the waves might bring you back."

Nova smiled, unsure. "You remember me?"

"Hard to forget the morning we ran out of pancakes because of you," Doreen said, and she winked. "Coffee."

Nova nodded.

Doreen leaned in just a little. "He has been in that seat for a while," she whispered. "Straightened that paper twice. Go on."

Nova walked to the table and slid into the booth across from Elliot. For a second, neither of them spoke.

Then Elliot exhaled. "Hi."

"Hi," Nova said. Her voice came out smaller than she wanted.

Doreen brought a mug and placed it in front of Nova.

"On the house," Doreen said. "And don't worry. Nobody here is looking for trouble."

Nova's shoulders eased. "Thank you."

Doreen nodded once and returned to the counter like she was guarding the entire room.

Elliot kept his eyes on Nova. "Are you sure it's a good idea to be here?"

"Probably not," Nova said. "I missed places that sound like this."

Elliot folded the newspaper and set it aside. "Then let us keep it honest."

Nova held his gaze a second longer than she meant to.

"I don't know how to do this quietly," she admitted.

Elliot didn't answer right away. He leaned back, eyes steady on hers.

"Then we learn," he said. "One honest moment at a time."

She nodded, as if that sounded possible.

They started small. Coffee beans. Weather. A broken fence down the street.

Then slower.

"Sarah used to say the ocean sounded like starting over," he said quietly.

Nova traced the rim of her mug. "My mom said the same about rain."

They talked in the kind of slow rhythm that asked nothing of either of them. Small things gave way to bigger ones, spoken slowly and with care: the pain after loss, love that ended too soon, daughters who worried, and parents who were gone.

A burst of static snapped from the speaker above the counter. A host's voice was halfway through a sentence about the diner photo when it cut out.

Doreen moved fast, switching the station without looking at Nova, as if she had done it a hundred times before.

Nova held back a laugh. "She is quick."

Elliot nodded. "She is kind."

After a while, the door opened and the bell rang again. A small group walked in, laughing. One of them glanced toward Nova. His eyes widened.

Doreen stepped forward at once, cheerful.

"Afternoon," she said, and steered them toward the far end of the counter. She started talking fast about pie and daily specials, as if she had thrown a blanket over a spark.

Nova watched it happen. She met Elliot's eyes.

“Maybe we should go,” Nova said quietly. “Before this stops feeling simple.”

Elliot nodded.

He left cash under the coffee cups. Doreen caught Nova’s hand as they passed.

“The beach is better company anyway,” Doreen whispered. “Go on now. You have good company tonight.”

Nova squeezed her hand back. “Thank you.”

Elliot pushed the door open.

The late afternoon air rolled in, cool and salty.

Nova stepped outside with him, the door swinging shut behind them, the ocean louder now than anything calling her name online.

CHAPTER TEN

*I didn't bring my armor to the shoreline.
Just my bare feet and whatever was left.*
- Nova Hart, "Low Tide," draft 1

Near the edge of the sand, they took off their shoes. Cool grains pressed under Nova's feet, and the wet sand still held the last warmth of the day as the tide turned back.

For a while, they did not speak.

The beach asked nothing from them but to stay there. The horizon stretched ahead, the sea blurring into the fading sky. "It's strange," she said. "When the noise stops, I hear what I've been avoiding."

Elliot watched the surf roll in. "Maybe that's why people avoid stillness."

Nova let that sit between them.

Waves rolled over their footprints almost as soon as they appeared.

"I deleted the apps this morning," Nova said. "Before I could talk myself out of it."

Elliot glanced at her. "All of them."

“Well, at least the loud ones,” she said with a small laugh. “Greg still sends updates. But I don’t have to watch the world yell anymore.”

She shrugged. “I’ll probably add them back tonight. I still need to know what’s going on.”

“The noise is still there,” Elliot said. “You just hear yourself better without it.”

Nova smiled. “I think I could get used to that.”

They walked closer to the water. The tide touched their ankles. Cold surged up her legs, sharp enough to snatch the air from her lungs, and she laughed before she could stop herself.

“When I was a kid,” Nova said, “my mom used to bring me to the coast. We stayed in a tiny rental house down in South Carolina. No schedule. No real reason to hurry anywhere. I thought it was boring.”

Elliot gave a small smile. “And now.”

“Now I would give anything for one more boring summer,” she said. “Before every feeling turned into a headline.”

Elliot did not answer right away. He let the silence stretch.

“She used to sing while she cooked,” Nova said. “Old hymns, mostly. Her voice was not perfect, but she meant every word.”

She swallowed. “After she died, I tried singing them again. It felt strange after that. Like the words belonged to someone braver than me.”

Elliot watched the water. “My wife did that too,” he said quietly. “She hummed while she folded laundry. Sometimes I still catch myself waiting for it.”

“That must still hurt.”

He nodded. “Some days it sits quietly in the background. Some days it’s all I can hear.”

There was no despair in his voice. Just truth, carried carefully.

"When things feel heavy," Nova said, "I still try to pray. I don't always have words. I just whisper like she used to. Sometimes it's the only thing that slows my mind down."

Elliot breathed in slowly. "Maybe prayer isn't always certainty," he said. "Maybe sometimes it's just not wanting to disappear."

Nova looked down at the water at her feet. "Do you think God listens?"

"I do," he said. "Even when we don't know what to say."

She nodded, slow and thoughtful. "I think I stopped believing He was close."

Elliot didn't rush to fill that.

"Maybe the noise just got loud," Nova said.

The tide reached them again, cool and steady. Nova turned toward him.

"Thank you," she said softly. "For not needing me to say something all the time."

Elliot's smile was slow to form, worn at the edges, but real.

He was quiet for a moment after that, watching the water. Then he spoke again, carefully, the way he did when something mattered.

"There is something I should say. Before this goes any further."

Nova turned toward him.

"This is real to me," he said. "I want you to know that."

He looked out at the water for a moment before continuing.

"I don't move fast," he said. "Not because I'm uncertain. I just know what loss does to people."

His voice stayed even, but quieter now.

"After my wife died, Clara and I both learned how to survive it differently. She's still finding her footing sometimes. So am I."

He met Nova's eyes again.

"I just need you to know what you're walking toward."

Nova held his gaze. The tide moved between them, steady and indifferent.

“Thank you,” she said quietly. “For telling me the truth instead of making it easier.”

“You said you were tired of pretending.”

“I did,” she said. “I meant it.”

She looked out at the water for a moment, then back at him. “I’m not asking you to move fast. I’m just asking you not to disappear.”

“I told you,” he said. “I am good at staying put.”

She nodded once, as if that settled something. Then she stepped closer and wrapped her arms around him.

Elliot held her carefully, one hand warm against her back. Neither of them hurried to let go.

“Goodnight, Elliot,” she said.

“Goodnight, Nova,” he answered.

Nova got into her car and sat for a moment with both hands on the wheel. She watched him in the mirror as he turned toward the pier.

She did not start the engine right away.

She opened her voice memo app and whispered, “Low tide. Keep the melody simple.”

Then she hummed a line that moved with the waves.

The notes came slowly at first, then settled into place.

She saved the file and typed a title.

Low Tide, draft one.

Nova rested her forehead against the steering wheel. Her prayer was more breath than words.

“Thank You, God, for the calm,” she whispered. “Help me not to lose it.”

When she lifted her head, Elliot stood near the seawall, his shoulders slightly rounded against the night, his gaze fixed on the dark water.

He did not look back.

She was grateful for that.

The moment needed nothing else to be real.

Nova started the engine and pulled onto the coastal road. The ocean stayed beside her, steady and faithful, all the way out of town.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

I kept the quiet like a secret.

- Nova Hart, "Without You," unreleased

Weeks passed, and the quiet she had found in Oceanside became memory. Nova and Elliot kept finding each other in small ways, late-night texts, voice notes, and photos of the sea. Nothing public or dramatic, only words that felt steady in a world that moved too fast. In those messages, the noise of fame faded for a while, replaced by the calm she had felt on his porch.

Meanwhile, *That Look on Your Face* kept climbing, reaching number one in country after country until the world claimed it as its own. Every chart update came with headlines and interviews she did not want to read. She silenced the notifications, turned her phone face down, and tried to remember the sound of the waves outside Elliot's house, the way her shoulders had finally loosened there. She had rewritten the bridge twice since Oceanside. The new version said things she hadn't planned to say.

She had just finished her main set.

The arena pulsed like a living thing. Sixty thousand voices tangled in the dark, rising higher.

“We want Nova! We want Nova!”

Nova stood just behind the curtain for her second and final encore, guitar strap tight against her shoulder, palms damp. The floor vibrated as the last notes of the transitional track faded away.

Marcy appeared at her shoulder, headset pushed back, offering a bottle of water.

“Last chance to back out,” she whispered. “You sure you want to go with the new version?”

Nova took the bottle, her grip steady. “I’m sure.”

Marcy studied her, something soft and knowing in her eyes.

“Okay,” she said. “Then sing it to them as it was given to you.”

Nova steadied her pulse, fingers tightening on the guitar strap.

Marcy nudged her arm. “Go change something out there.”

The stage manager called time.

Reid moved a few paces behind, scanning the wings and the exits, then gave a small nod to the crew. When his eyes met hers, he didn’t speak. The gesture was enough.

Nova moved toward the curtain, straightening her shoulders as the noise swelled beyond it.

Her heart kept time with the lights. On the screens above the stage, a looping video played pieces of her past, press clips, red carpets, magazine covers, small fragments of the woman she used to be. The crowd shouted her name in waves.

She waited for the cue, chin lifted, eyes closed.

The voice in her earpiece said, “We’re live. Cue Nova.”

She stepped forward.

The lights struck her face, hot and blinding, forcing her to blink. The roar rose and folded over itself. Phones lit the air like a thousand

tiny mirrors. For a moment she could see only blur and color. Then, as her eyes adjusted, the signs came into focus.

WHO IS HE

WE LOVE YOU NOVA

THAT LOOK ON YOUR FACE

SING IT AGAIN

THAT LOOK LIVE

She smiled because she had to. The noise was a storm, and she was its lightning rod, carrying the charge alone.

Nova lifted her guitar a little higher and stepped toward the mic.

“All right,” she said, voice steady. “One more for tonight.”

The crowd surged, a mix of cheers and playful groans.

“This one means something different to me now.”

The noise softened, as if sixty thousand people leaned in at once.

She let her fingers settle on the guitar.

The band went still.

The last of the transition music faded out.

The stage fell into a low, waiting hush. The lights dimmed until only a single amber beam held her in its center.

She strummed once. The lone chord cut through the dark like a match being struck. It was still the song they knew, only quieter, opening on the same verse, with a new bridge she had written in the silence.

“Peace has come over me like a gentle flame.”

Her voice wove through the rafters, thin at first, then stronger as the melody found its footing. The arrangement was spare, with only

acoustic guitar, soft piano, and a brush of strings. Every note felt like a confession.

Faces in the crowd tilted toward the stage, phone screens lifting like stars. Flashlights flicked on, spreading in uneven waves. Some swayed, arms raised, holding the light steady as if it mattered.

Nova sang the next lines, her gaze drifting beyond the spotlights. The brightness made it hard to see the audience, yet she could sense them. The atmosphere shifted. Curiosity bent into stillness.

As she sang, images rose in her mind, Doreen behind the counter, the smell of warm pie and coffee, Elliot's calm eyes lifting to hers without hurry, waves folding against the shore. Not memories. Echoes of peace she could hold onto as the song moved through her.

Halfway through the song, she felt a tremor of uncertainty. The lyrics were raw. Not polished. Not approved. Her throat tightened, but she did not stop.

Her fingers slipped once on a chord. It was barely noticeable. She felt it like a pulse of honesty.

As the last note of the verse faded, she leaned toward the microphone and let the music breathe around her.

"This song came to me when everything felt loud," she said softly. "The quiet showed me how to sing it back. I just wanted to remember what peace sounds like."

The arena stayed still. She eased into the next progression, her voice soft as she moved into the bridge. "Here is the part I only sing when it is quiet."

She strummed the final chord of the bridge. It rang into the rafters. She lifted her hand from the strings.

The guitar fell silent.

The spotlight tightened.

Sixty thousand people waited without a sound.

She sang the last lines a cappella, her voice bare and trembling.

I do not have to carry this alone.

Even though I am gone, He still knows my name.

Her voice caught on the last word, rising just enough to carry across the silence. Somewhere behind the curtain, someone went very still.

As she sang it, her hand rose to her chest without thinking. A small, unplanned gesture full of sincerity.

The arena held its breath in frozen quiet, then the eruption crashed forward.

Nova stepped back, let the last of the quiet settle inside her, and whispered, "Thank you."

She pressed her hand briefly to her chest again, then lifted her eyes to the front rows, meeting a few faces. A small smile found her before she could stop it.

The lights exploded to full white. The storm returned in shouts and applause and camera flashes. Yet beneath it all she felt something steady, a small core of peace no one could take from her.

The band slipped into the soft outro they used to close the night, a gentle rise of instruments meant to carry the crowd through the final applause. Nova stepped back from the mic, offering a small wave as the arena roared.

She walked offstage as the music swelled behind her, the sound of sixty thousand voices lifting and falling like a tide. The concert was over. The moment she had created was not.

Backstage was chaos.

One of the younger crew members near the curtain glanced down at her phone as Nova stepped past. A fan video of the final line had

already appeared on her feed, shaky and bright with stage light. The girl tucked her phone away quickly, eyes a little wide.

Greg caught her halfway down the corridor, tablet already vibrating with messages.

"The crowd loved it, fine, sure, but what was that last line? 'He still knows my name'? Nova, the label was watching the live stream. They saw the a cappella moment, the hand to your chest. Every executive started texting at once."

Nova pulled the monitors from her ears. "It was honest."

Greg followed her, waving the tablet like a warning flare. "Honest is fine in interviews. Not for live lyrics that sound like prayer. Fans are tagging it as worship. Bloggers are asking if you went faith based. PR is begging for clarification. They want to know if you are pivoting genres. They want to know if this is a faith era. Sponsors already want answers."

Crew members rushed past, congratulating her and setting up lights for interviews she had not agreed to. Someone pressed a towel into her hands. She blinked at it, then looked down the hallway at the glowing exit sign.

"Nova, they want you live in five for post show coverage," Greg said.

She gave a small smile. "Tell them I already said what I needed to."

The air smelled of wet asphalt and electricity.

Nova stepped into the storm. Rain struck her, cool and sharp, pulling sweat and stage heat from her skin. The noise of the arena softened behind the concrete walls. All she could hear was the steady rhythm of rain.

The SUV waited under the overhang, engine running, headlights low. A small group of dedicated fans stood behind metal barricades across the loading lane, umbrellas tilted, posters pressed to their chests. They had left the show early to get a place at the stage door.

At the front, a girl held her phone high, recording with both hands.

The guitar was still in Nova's hands, the one she had carried off-stage. Water gathered on the polished wood. She lowered it gently to the ground, her fingers brushing the strings as if the song were still moving through them. She whispered the lyric again. "Peace has come over me like a gentle flame."

Camera flashes flickered at the far edge of the loading dock. Someone had found her. She did not hide. The rain felt like a baptism.

In her chest, the melody kept circling. Even though I am gone, He still knows my name.

She closed her eyes and let the moment settle.

Reid hovered a few steps back, giving her space while watching the fans. Greg's voice grumbled from the corridor behind them. The fans held their breath, phones ready to capture a moment, waiting for even a single glance.

Nova took a slow, steady breath. She let the rain wash the glitter from her skin and did not reach for her phone.

She lifted her face to the rain again and whispered, "Thank You for finding me again."

The storm answered in its own rhythm, rising and falling, a sound older than applause.

She smiled through it, not radiant but real.

A few yards away near the stage door, the girl with the phone lowered her umbrella. When she saw Nova step into the rain, she froze, eyes wide.

Nova offered her a small, tired smile as she passed.

"That was beautiful," the girl said, her voice threading through the rain just enough to reach her.

She walked toward the waiting car, rain washing over her, knowing the storm inside the arena had only just begun.

CHAPTER TWELVE

*Mercy has a voice; I hear it through the quiet.
The distance between us sparks beneath the riot.
Now that we're apart, I can feel the start of us.
Maybe this beginning comes with you breaking my glass heart.*

- Nova Hart, from "Glass Heart"

Trending #2 worldwide, heading to #1

Elliot Brooks had returned to normal.

At least, that was what he told himself while standing in the cleaning products aisle of Martin's Grocery, holding two nearly identical bottles of laundry detergent as if one of them contained the answer.

The overhead lights buzzed with a faint flicker, casting everything in a tired yellow wash. A toddler in a cart practiced siren noises, rising and falling like a runaway ambulance, while his mother bargained with a pack of paper towels. Somewhere behind Elliot, a stock cart rattled over a loose tile. The air smelled faintly of oranges from the produce section and floor cleaner that never fully evaporated.

Yet something had shifted inside his head. The quiet no longer felt empty. It paused, like the moment after a song ended, when you were not ready for the next sound.

He dropped a bottle of laundry soap into the cart, double-checked that it was unscented, and moved on.

The café post had burned through its moment weeks ago: a burst of hearts, a local headline, a handful of harmless conspiracy theories, and then silence. *That Look on Your Face* had been out for two months and showed no sign of slowing. Somewhere in that same stretch, Nova had dropped *Glass Heart* quietly. It was already moving. The internet found brighter fires to chase. Elliot's face, or rather, the back of his head, had long been replaced.

He was fine with that.

At the checkout, Doreen from Harbor Light Café, off-duty with her hair in a messy bun and groceries balanced in her arms, recognized him. "Morning, Mr. Brooks," she said with a half-smile. "Life holding up?"

He hesitated. "Always does."

"She was nice," Doreen said, nudging a loaf of bread forward with her wrist as the plastic crinkled. "That singer girl. Tipped big. Not all of them do."

"She was polite," he agreed.

"Polite don't cost nothing," Doreen said. "But she meant it. You could tell." Then, as if realizing she had wandered into something private, she winked. "See you Sunday."

Elliot nodded and left with his bag, the bell above the door giving its familiar jangle.

Outside, the air had the chill that made the sea smell clean. The boardwalk was half-empty, gulls staking their claims on railings. One of them hopped sideways as he passed, eyeing his bag like it had a

personal vendetta. He took the usual route past the bookstore and down to the overlook.

Everything was the same. Only he was not.

He wondered how long before the world circled back.

And whether he would still be standing when it did.

He stopped at the overlook, bag dangling at his side, and watched the water break in slow, patient curls. The sea sounded different today, a rhythmic surge that rose and fell like steady breathing. The wind brushed against his collar, carrying the faint sting of salt on his skin.

His phone buzzed. Reflex made him reach for it. It was Nova.

Does the ocean still sound the same?

He almost laughed. Of course she would ask that.

Sometimes it argues with itself...

He leaned against the railing, the metal cool enough to prickle against his forearms, thumbs hovering.

At least it ends in peace most days.

A moment passed.

Then maybe I am the tide still learning how

He smiled quietly, not like a man starstruck, but like someone recognizing a familiar melody. A warmth settled in his chest, faint and steady, matching the rhythm of the waves below.

Give it time. Even the tide learns when to rest

Another pause before she responded.

You always say the calmest things

He glanced toward the pier where the fishermen were packing up for the morning, their buckets clanking as a gull swooped low to argue over stray bait. His phone buzzed again. Clara calling.

He hesitated, then typed:

I have to go. My daughter is calling. Try not to sing over the ocean today.

Three dots blinked, then her reply came.

No promises. Talk soon, pie guy...

He chuckled, the sound carried off by the wind, and answered the call from Clara.

"Hey, Dad. Still famous?"

"Still zero," he said. "Aspiring to less."

Clara laughed, light and brief. "Good. I saw a clip of Nova Hart on TV last night. She looked fine. Like famous fine. I take it you are not suddenly part of her entourage?"

"I don't own enough black clothing," he said.

"Stay that way." Then, softer, "You okay?"

"I am," he said, surprised by how true it felt in his chest. "Just... quieter inside than usual."

"That sounds like progress," she said. After a beat she added, "You know, Mom used to say quiet's only good if it listens back."

He smiled. "She was usually right."

"Usually?" Clara teased.

"She married me," he said, and they both laughed, the kind that came from muscle memory and something tender.

When the call ended, Elliot slipped his phone into his pocket and walked down toward the beach. The tide was low, the sand freshly smoothed where last night's waves had rewritten everything. He stepped out onto the damp shoreline. For a few yards, there were no footprints at all. Then his appeared behind him, faint at first, then clearer, temporary proof he was, in fact, here.

He stood there a moment longer, listening to the shore breathe.

He told himself to be careful. He wasn't sure, anymore, what that meant.

But late that night, Nova sat cross-legged on the hotel carpet, notebook open, guitar resting across her lap.

A half-finished cup of tea had gone cold beside her. Outside, the city hummed in distant pulses, softer this high up.

She strummed lightly, the muted chords barely carrying past the bed. On the blank page she wrote a line in pencil:

The quiet underneath still sings

She paused, pressed her finger to the page, then scratched it out. Beneath it she wrote again, slower this time:

If I listen long enough, it sounds like home

Was it a verse or a confession? Maybe both. Before she could overthink it, she snapped a photo of the notebook and hit send.

Elliot saw the picture come through while brushing his teeth. He froze mid-motion, toothbrush still in hand, foam gathering at the corner of his mouth. The glow of the phone lit his reflection in the bathroom mirror.

He rinsed quickly, dried his face, and typed back.

Keep that one.

A moment later her reply went out.

It is yours, too.

He blinked, the words settling deeper than he expected. Something quiet. Something steady.

He saved the photo in the same folder where he kept screenshots of grocery lists and recipes he would never cook. Somehow, it felt right there, close, familiar, easy to find.

Part of his everyday life.

A week slipped by. Oceanside quieted. Nova's days blurred: rehearsal, interviews, traffic that crawled block by block.

The tourists thinned. The boardwalk quieted. Elliot fixed a loose cabinet hinge. Nova flew to New York, then Chicago, then Austin.

They texted when they could. Small things. Weather reports disguised as check-ins. She usually started there.

Windy here

Loud here

Texas question...

I'm listening

Do they serve cherry pie

I heard they do, I would not recommend.

Texas is more of an apple pie place.

It was nothing, technically.

It was everything, quietly.

Saturday evening, Elliot sat on his porch with a book open to the same page for twenty minutes. The horizon was fire and silver, the sky sliding toward night in slow layers. His phone buzzed.

On stage in ten... sending you the quiet first

He frowned, confused, until a short audio clip followed. It wasn't a song, just the sound of ocean waves. A loop she must have kept from the balcony. His balcony.

He played it twice, then three times, and let it run low while the sun folded itself into the sea. The breeze shifted as it dimmed, cool on his face, stirring the edges of the page he still had not read.

When the sound faded, he sat for a while, hands still on the porch railing, the surrounding hush deeper than before. He smiled and typed:

I heard it. I hear you

She hearted his text.

Hours later, in a greenroom glittering with plastic applause, Nova sat cross-legged on a couch, makeup half-wiped, phone glowing. She read his message and chuckled softly to herself.

"You have no idea," she murmured.

You heard it

She stared at the message after it sent, the echo of the stage still humming through her chest. The quiet she had carried with her felt steady and present, not yet lost to the noise.

In his dark kitchen, Elliot set the phone down and listened to nothing at all. The wave loop was gone, but the hush remained, alive and full.

He heard the hush between the songs.

The applause faded before the sound in her ears did. Back in her hotel room, the air felt hollowed out, as if the cheering had carved space she didn't know how to fill. Makeup wipes. Half-eaten fruit. A dozen versions of her reflection in the mirrors.

Nova sat where she had sat before, cross-legged on the carpet. The city lights blinked through the window, all pulse and motion, but inside the room it was still. She reached for the notebook. The page from earlier waited, creased from travel, pencil smudged across the bottom. Beneath the four lines she had sent—the ones he had told her to keep—she added one more, the words barely a whisper even on paper:

Mercy still has a voice; tonight it sounds like you

She stared at the line until it blurred, like starlight when tears finally win.

For a moment she almost wrote You, capital Y, but stopped. Maybe someday she would know the difference between the two. For now, lowercase was enough.

Nova closed the notebook and laid her guitar across it like a promise. Outside, a siren wailed and faded. Somewhere two thousand miles away, the ocean kept its own rhythm, endless and patient.

She breathed with it, let the stillness answer back, and for the first time in a long while, she did not feel alone.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

I sang the Name the world refused to hear.

I sang it loud and my voice grew strong.

I was told to whisper, keep my faith untold.

Love is where I run when the silence holds.

- Nova Hart, “The Name They Fear,”

leaked clip viral worldwide,

labeled “content sensitive”

by the studio within 48 hours

The studio air was so still that even a breath felt loud.

Nova stood behind the microphone, eyes closed, headphones resting lightly against her ears, the red recording light glowing steady.

When the track rolled, she didn’t think about pitch or phrasing or charts. She let the first line rise from her chest, unguarded, as if it had been waiting for her.

Her voice trembled once, then found its footing.

I sang the Name the world refused to hear.

The next word waited in the silence ahead of her.

She knew it.

She had been warned about it.
Suggested around it.
Encouraged to soften it.
Her fingers curled against the mic stand.
She said it anyway.

God.

The sound didn't echo. It settled.
Like something finally spoken aloud.
The shift came before sound, something in the space leaning toward her, listening.
She reached the last line and did not read it off the page. She lived it.

*I was told to whisper, keep my faith untold.
But I will stand for You.*

The final note faded.
The silence that followed felt almost holy — no one moved, not the engineers, not Marcy, not even the equipment.
Finally, Greg's voice crackled through the headset.
"Well, that one is different."
Nova slipped the headphones off. Her pulse was steady. Her smile was small but certain.
"Yeah," she said. "I know."

Through the glass, the control room stayed frozen, caught between awe and alarm. Greg stood with his arms crossed too tight, his expression no longer about music alone. He opened his mouth, closed it again, then rubbed the back of his neck like he was bracing for impact.

"It is beautiful," he said slowly. "But you know what this sounds like, right."

Nova met his eyes through the reflection. "It sounds true."

Greg turned toward the team, frustration simmering just under control. "We can't drop a song that names 'God' like that and expect radio to play nice. And while we're at it, someone already connected the café photo to the bridge lyrics. They're calling him your inspiration. Nova, if this song is about faith and he's the face of your quiet era, the label is going to want answers about both."

Marcy straightened on the couch. "Maybe that is the point."

Greg looked to Reid. "You tell her. You are the practical one. This is not good business."

Reid did not move. "It's her song."

Greg blinked at him. "You, of all people, understand what happens when the world decides something is dangerous."

"I do," Reid said evenly. "And she appears to have already decided it is worth it."

Nova caught his eye and gave him a small nod. Gratitude. Recognition. Enough.

Marcy leaned forward again, voice steady but fierce. "She is not trying to start a fight, Greg. She is tired of pretending faith is off limits."

Greg pressed a palm to the wall as if bracing himself. "Streaming will carry the song. Radio is where they get nervous. And when radio hesitates, sponsors and partners start paying attention."

The red light above the door flickered off, but the charge in the air remained.

Nova set her headphones down. "Then we're finished here."

Greg dragged a hand through his hair and exhaled hard. "You just burned a lot of safe bridges, Hart."

"Good," she said. "They were never really safe, anyway."

Outside the booth, hallway lights hummed. Nova walked past a rack of spare microphone stands. Voices carried from the control room in low tones.

"I loved it," one engineer whispered. "It felt real."

"Real is risky," another muttered.

A third voice, sharper than the rest, said, "Did she really just say God in a pop track?"

Nova paused near the water cooler, filled a paper cup, and drank. The water tasted of paper and cold metal, but it steadied her. She did not join the debate. She did not need to.

The song already had its own voice.

Reid met her at the curb. The night had settled, warm and close. Traffic along the avenue sounded farther away, rounded at the edges, as if the heat had pressed it back.

"Are you good?" he asked quietly.

Nova let out a long breath. "Good enough."

"You will be," Reid said. "Truth has a way of standing, even when everything else panics."

She slid into the back seat of the SUV, still humming pieces of the melody. Neon streaked across the windows. Her phone lit up with notifications. Emails from Greg. Missed calls from the label. Texts from Marcy.

She turned the phone face down.

She rolled the window down and let the warm air rush in. It smelled faintly of ocean salt, or memory pretending to be. She thought of Elliot's porch, the quiet between his words, the steady peace he carried without effort.

When they reached her building, Reid opened her door. "Sleep," he said. "Let the noise chase itself."

She nodded, squeezed his hand once in thanks, and walked inside.

Her hands shook once when the elevator doors closed. She let them. Her phone buzzed again. A notification from the cloud drive where she stored demos. Someone had pulled a fifteen-second clip from The Name They Fear, raw and unfinished, and released it.

“Well, that was fast,” she muttered to herself.

A studio tech, maybe. An assistant. Someone careless, or someone who felt the moment mattered.

Instead of fear, a calm settled in her chest.

In the bright hallway she said it like a dare. “Then let them hear it.” She did not take it back.

She stepped inside her apartment and crossed to the window. The chorus replayed in her mind in quieter, more personal notes. Her own voice, steadier than she remembered, echoed lines she did not regret.

By dawn, the clip had slipped beyond the studio walls.

The industry reacted fast.

The label called it content sensitive. Sponsors used phrases like “brand safety” and “market alignment.”

Greg’s phone call came early.

“This is moving fast,” he said. “You need to get ahead of it. Call it rehearsal. Call it a warm up. Say something before this defines you.”

“That would not be true,” Nova said.

“This is not about honesty,” Greg replied. “This is about survival.”

She stood by the hotel window, hair still damp from the shower, city light spilling across the floor.

“Then let it define me,” she said.

The call ended.

Nova did not post a statement.

She turned her phone off.

That afternoon, Elliot stopped by the church to drop off canned goods for the food drive. The building smelled of coffee and floor wax.

Behind the shelves, a cluster of teenagers talked over one another.

"Is that really her?"

"I thought it was fake."

"No, it's real. My sister sent it to me."

"Wait, she really said it?"

"Yeah. Straight up."

Someone snorted. "That's gonna be a thing."

An older volunteer sorting labels shook her head without looking up. "Everything's a thing now."

Elliot set another box on the table. He was reaching for another when the radio clicked on in the fellowship hall. Traffic. Weather. Then Nova's voice cut in through the static, followed quickly by the host's.

"—already drawing strong reactions online," the voice said. "Some calling it bold. Others saying she crossed a line."

Elliot waited until the radio went quiet again.

He set the box down. "Sometimes people hear what they weren't expecting."

A tired smile from the woman. "That's one way to put it."

He carried the cans to the shelf in silence, the soft clink of metal the only sound.

By evening, Nova's phone was a battlefield. Public relations messages. Invitations disguised as concern. Criticism wrapped in advice. She had turned it off that morning. Now she turned it back on. She pushed the notifications away until her thumb ached. Then she opened their thread and typed.

But is anyone even really listening?

His reply came quickly.

Someone always is. You just might not know their name.

She read the words twice. For a moment, she could almost hear his voice, steady and grounded in something beyond applause.

She set her phone on her chest and breathed until her heartbeat slowed.

Then she opened her notebook and wrote.

Truth in static.

Peace under pressure.

A name you sing even when no one claps.

She lifted her guitar and shaped the final line again.

"Love is where I run when the silence holds."

Soft enough to feel like breathing.

Sleep came late, but gently. City lights shifted their colors. Far away,
the ocean kept its patient time.

And in the stillness, the Name remained.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

*The stadium chants as the neon lights glow,
The crowd applauds what it thinks it knows.
But in the silence between the songs,
I hear the voice where my heart belongs.*

**- Nova Hart, "*The Noise and the Quiet*"
#1 worldwide**

Two days after *The Noise and the Quiet* climbed to number one, Nova found herself caught in a different spotlight. The same clip of *The Name They Fear* had spread fast. It was rough, unfinished, and one clear word crackled on the mic. *God*.

The reaction split the moment it hit the internet. Some people praised her. Some people mocked her. Some people tried to label her, as if a single word could decide who she was. Talk shows replayed the clip and asked the same question in different outfits. Was she changing, or was it just a moment getting too much attention?

And now she sat under studio lights, facing the questions head-on.

The interview had been going well. The audience clapped on cue, and the host laughed. The questions remained within the lane that Greg had approved.

The walls carried a slow wash of light that shifted from gold to rose and back again. Cameras stared from their metal towers. Red tally lights blinked on and off. A producer lifted two fingers for time. A stagehand slipped in with water and a smile that looked practiced.

Nova sat tall but not stiff. In through the nose. Hold. Out through the mouth. The heat from the lights warmed her shoulders. The tremor in her legs stayed low, felt only where her dress hem brushed the cushion. Her heartbeat settled into a steady rhythm, like a drummer during sound check.

"It has been an incredible season," she said. She let the words move at a calm pace. Not rushed. Not dragged. She watched the host's eyes, watched the friendly lean that meant the next question mattered.

"Your new single, *The Noise and the Quiet*, has people talking," the host said. "They say it feels more vulnerable than anything you have released. What changed?"

Nova smiled. She had practiced this line in the green room until it felt simple and true. She prayed for words that told the truth without hurting anyone. Not her team. Not herself. Not the still shift happening inside her.

"I think it's about finding peace where there should not be any," she said. "The kind that does not depend on charts or crowds."

The host nodded, but she was not moving on. Nova saw it in the slight tilt of her head, the way her hands settled in her lap.

"Before we go any further, I have to ask about *The Name They Fear*," the host said. "The leaked clip has sparked a lot of conversation. Some people call it inspiring." Her smile tightened just a little. "Others

say it crosses into faith, something we rarely hear on pop radio. Was that deliberate, or just interpretation?"

Nova felt the question land. She had known it would come.

"I sang what was true," she said. "That is all it was."

The host blinked once, like she hadn't expected the answer to stay that steady.

"So you are not walking it back?"

Nova kept her voice even. "I am not here to build a message for people to argue about. I am here to sing what is true."

"No," she added softly. "I am learning that you can be honest without making a show of it."

A small murmur moved through the audience. Some curious. Some unsure. All listening.

The host offered a careful smile, like someone finding balance on a narrow bridge. "Thank you for sharing that," she said. "Now let us come back to your number one single. There is a lot of emotion in *The Noise and the Quiet*. What were you hoping listeners would hear?"

Nova could feel the energy in the room change. The lights seemed warmer. The applause was a little too eager. She recognized that kind of attention, the kind that looks for something to headline.

Then came the setup. The host leaned in. "That sounds like growth," she said. "Or maybe someone helped you find it."

And there it was.

The gentle nudge toward the story. The glimmer of a headline. Nova felt the air tighten, not colder or warmer, just close, the way rooms feel when people lean in together.

The screen behind them changed. A soft sound effect rolled through the speakers as the image sharpened.

The photo froze behind them. Her breath caught for half a second, then fell back into rhythm. Offstage, Greg's posture changed. From

the couch, Nova saw his tense mouth and how he clutched his phone. A producer leaned toward him, and his eyes narrowed.

"It looks like you had a lovely morning in Oceanside," the host said softly.

Nova kept her face steady. She lifted her eyes to the host and shaped her smile small and clean. "Just breakfast," she said. "Even pop stars run on coffee."

The audience laughed. The host watched her longer this time; her smile softening into thought. Her gaze revealed unexpected comprehension.

"Of course," the host said gently. "But the way you were looking at him in the photo. There is a story there. Your eyes said more than your words do now."

The laughter faded. The room went still, attentive and close. One world asked her to spin this into a story. The other asked her to guard what mattered.

She met the host's gaze. "I think sometimes a kind person shows up at the right time," she said. "That is all it was."

Nothing moved. No camera rolled. No stagehand shifted. The stillness held, then released, and applause rose. It started polite, then warmed as the room relaxed. The host smiled with relief and pride. Every show wanted a clean sound bite. This one did not quite get it.

The break cue flashed from the producer. Music lifted for commercials. Nova unclipped her mic with careful fingers and felt the small mark the clip had left on her blouse. The noise rushed back at once. Crew members spoke over one another. A makeup brush touched her cheek. Someone adjusted her hair. Someone said trending, another said top three, another asked for a pull quote for the network site.

Greg appeared beside her with a smile that tried to look supportive but never reached his eyes. His voice dropped, but its tension pierced.

He leaned in, lowering his voice. "The label is already asking who you are becoming. Be ready to answer that. And the diner photo ... we need a plan. Tonight."

Something inside her tightened. Silence did not feel peaceful anymore. It felt managed.

Nova nodded. Nodding was something she was good at. Silence, she knew, was sometimes the better choice. She pressed the cross between her fingers and prayed without moving her mouth.

"Great segment," the host said as they walked toward the backstage door. "You have everyone talking tonight."

"Thank you," Nova said. She let the words sound polite, then let them fade.

The hallway outside the studio was a wash of cool air and softer light. The carpet softened the steps of people who moved fast and spoke faster, their schedules folding over one another. Nova stepped out of the stream and stood by the glass wall. The city outside looked like a river of windows. Screens flashed. Headlights drifted in long lines.

For a brief second, the world dimmed in her mind. She closed her eyes and let her breath slow, steady and unforced.

When she opened them, the hallway had not changed. Voices echoed. Phones rang somewhere behind closed doors.

She walked on anyway.

Reid touched her elbow. "Car is ready," he said.

She smiled and followed.

Elliot had not planned to watch.

He had left the television on, just as he sometimes let the radio play hymns in the kitchen while he read. He was washing a mug when he heard the host say Nova's name. He looked up and saw her framed in stage light, calm in a room that liked to be loud.

The picture was too bright for the hour. Studio colors always looked that way to him, like candy on a shelf. He reached for the remote and lowered the volume until the sound was a thin ribbon beneath the room.

He watched her breathe before she spoke and her hands settle on her knees. He watched the tilt of her head when she listened. A person who did not know her would call it poise. Elliot saw something that lived under poise. He saw practice and patience and a small river of fatigue that nobody else would notice.

The host asked about change. Nova answered with the line about peace. He nodded though she could not see him. He had heard that line at his kitchen table. He had seen her look at the window while the kettle hissed and say that quiet did not mean empty. It meant full. It meant present. He had not forgotten.

Then came the part he had hoped she might avoid. The leaked clip. The faith question. The kind people asked when they wanted truth to fit inside a headline.

He watched her steady herself, watched the tiny pause that someone else might call a breath but he recognized as courage.

When she said she was not here to build a message for people to argue about, something warm and heavy settled in his chest. Something closer to recognition.

He could tell she was choosing her words carefully. Not to impress anyone. Not to win. Just to get through it without giving away what mattered.

The screen behind her shifted. The photo filled the studio and then filled his living room. Elliot knew the image before his mind named it. The slant of morning light through the blinds. The angle of the table. The curve of her smile when she was listening. He felt his breath slow.

He knew the script. He could not rewrite it.

He watched her hold herself together. He watched her make the smile that let the moment pass without lying. He turned the volume down again until only the set lights reflected on his window. He watched her lips form the words "everyone needs coffee" and he let the sound die.

He did not need to hear the host to understand the push. He could read the slight lean of the shoulders. He could read the audience in the tilt of heads across the rows. He could read the next move the way he could read a song before the chorus arrived.

When Nova said a kind person sometimes shows up at the right time, Elliot felt something settle in his chest. It was not pride. It was not fear. It was relief. She had told the truth and had protected it at the same time. Few people learned how to do that. Fewer did it with kindness.

He turned the television off. The room dimmed to lamplight and the slow metronome of the clock above the mantel. The old house held sound the way it always did. He could hear the faint rush of the ocean beyond the street. He could hear the hum of the refrigerator.

He could hear the soft pulse that comes from the small space between things when they rest together.

He set the mug on the counter to dry and stood with his palms on the edge of the sink. He had done that for years when the house felt too quiet and then not quiet enough. After his wife died, silence had been a weight that pressed on his chest. He had learned over time that silence could also be a shelter. It depended on what filled it. Grief had once filled it. Then work. Then the sound of his children when they were small in memory. Now it held prayers he did not always have words for.

He whispered one for Nova. Not for charts or cameras or a segment that might get trimmed. He asked for the kind of peace she had once reached for on his porch. He asked for steadiness to meet her where the noise would not.

He stepped to the window and looked out across the dark. The ocean was a long shadow that moved with its own mind. He could not see the line where water met sky, but he knew it was there. He could hear it. He had learned to trust the things he could not always see.

On the mantel sat a photograph of Clara, taken on the beach one winter when the wind cut through their coats and they shouted with joy anyway. Elliot smiled at the memory and felt the thin ache that always came with it. Change had stolen and change had given. He thought of Nova sitting under those lights and felt a strange sense that change could be kind if it learned to be quiet.

He reached for his phone. He did not trust big words, not tonight. He sent something small.

You answered with grace.

He watched the message deliver. The house was still, but something in it felt less heavy.

A knock sounded at the door.

Elliot opened it to find Clara on the porch, jacket unzipped, phone already in her hand.

"Hey," she said.

"Hey," he answered.

She stepped inside without hurry, toes nudging the mat into place out of habit.

They moved into the kitchen the way they always did.

Clara lingered at the counter, aimlessly scrolling through her phone.

"I watched one of her interviews," she said finally.

Elliot didn't look up. "You didn't have to do that."

"I know. I wanted to." She set the phone down. "She seems ... kind. Tired. Like someone who's been performing even when she's sitting still."

He let that sit.

"I need time," she said. "Before I meet her properly. Before this becomes something I'm expected to be okay with in public."

He waited. "I've lived through one season where the world fell apart at our door," she said. "I'm not sure I can do that again without a little warning."

He nodded once. "That's fair."

Her shoulders eased at the word. "I love you," she added, quieter. "This isn't me pushing you away. It's me asking not to be pulled too fast into something I'm still learning how to hold."

Elliot reached across the counter and squeezed her hand. Not to reassure her. Just to stay present.

"Take the time you need," he said.

Clara exhaled, relief flickering across her face. "Thank you."

The ride to the hotel moved through a tunnel of glass and blue light. The city was a web of reflections. Nova sat in the back seat with Greg and her publicist. Greg talked through next steps and spoke in a tone that tried to sound like victory. He said the interview was strong. He said the audience numbers were climbing. He said the network wanted a backstage clip for their site tomorrow. He said the word narrative and then the word alignment. He said the photo had been trending again since the interview. He did not say Elliot's name. He did not have to. The publicist typed notes on her phone and nodded in a steady rhythm.

Nova answered when a question required a yes or a no. She kept her eyes on the window where a bridge rose and fell like a slow wave. She touched the pendant again. She had stopped telling herself it was silly. She had stopped telling herself anything about it. She had decided to let it mean what it meant.

When they reached the hotel, cameras flashed through the glass doors. It felt like a brief storm that came out of nowhere. She smiled because that was what you did when light found you. She moved through the lobby with a pace that looked like confidence. In the elevator she pressed the top floor and watched the numbers climb one by one. The car was mirrored on three sides. The reflection reminded her of the way a stage splits you into a thousand versions and hands them out to people you will never meet.

At the top floor she stepped into a hallway. The carpet softened each step until it felt like she was walking across a field of slow breath.

In her suite she left her shoes by the door and set her bag on the chair. The city stretched below the windows in a scatter of white and yellow. A helicopter traced a line across the dark like a slow insect with a light in its chest.

She stood at the glass and let her forehead rest against the cool pane. She whispered, "I don't think I said too much."

The words lingered. She smiled faintly at how they sounded and let it be.

She hoped Elliot had not seen the interview. She hoped he had. Both hopes felt honest. She smiled at herself for the contradiction and let it stand. Not everything had to make sense tonight.

She turned on a lamp and opened her notebook on the table by the window. The notebook had become a place where she did not have to perform. The pages held questions and half lines and prayers that did not always look like prayers. She wrote slowly.

Maybe quiet is not the absence of sound, but the presence of peace.

She stared at the line. It was simple enough to be true. She closed the notebook and left the pen across the cover like a small anchor.

She filled a glass with water and drank it in three slow swallows. She let the water sit in her hands for a moment and felt the weight of it. The room hummed with the low life of any high floor. Air moved through vents. A small light on the thermostat blinked. Somewhere down the hall an elevator door opened and closed with a soft kiss of metal.

Her phone lit up on the table. There were new messages from Greg. There were new mentions. There was a tag from the show. There were a handful of texts from friends who worked in the industry and knew how to say good job in ten words or less.

She left the phone face down.

On the table beside it sat a note that had been left at the front desk. No name. Just two lines in familiar handwriting: *Proud of you. Rest.*

Nova breathed out and smiled.

Far down the coast, Elliot stepped out onto his porch with a blanket around his shoulders. The night was clear and cool. The porch boards held a memory of sun that had faded to a whisper. He sat in the chair that faced the water and let his feet rest on the rail like he used to do when the kids were little and sleep came slow.

He could hear the ocean in a way that was more than sound. It was a rhythm that lived somewhere deeper than ears. The water came in and went out. It did not ask permission. It did not hurry. It knew its work and did it.

He thought of the way Nova had stood at his sink and laughed at the sound of gulls. He thought of the way she had turned toward the window when the kettle clicked off and had gone quiet for a full minute without speaking. He had noticed then that silence did not scare her. She respected it. She understood it could hold more than emptiness. He hoped the show lights had not burned that out of her tonight.

He prayed again. He did not use many words. He asked for what he always asked for now. Light enough for the next step. Courage to tell the truth in a way that did not bruise. Mercy for the places that still felt raw.

He asked to be careful with what he had been given. He was no longer sure careful meant the same thing it once had.

Back at the hotel, Nova turned off the lamp and let the city be the only light in the room. She lay on the couch with a blanket pulled over her legs and closed her eyes. She listened for the whirl of the air unit. She listened for the faint siren a few blocks over. She listened for her own breath. She let each sound drift by, ungripped, like small boats on still water.

She thought of Oceanside. The morning at the diner. The way sunlight made the dust look like a soft storm. The taste of coffee that had been brewed by someone who cared more about people than flavor. The walk to the car with the ocean just out of sight but close enough to pull at her chest. She thought of the look on Elliot's face when he had listened like it mattered. She felt that same calmness now and felt her shoulders drop into the couch.

She mumbled, "thank you" into the dark, no name needed. She knew.

Her phone buzzed once on the table.

Good show.

She smiled at the two words.

You watched it?

He didn't answer. He didn't have to.

On his porch, Elliot looked up and found a small cluster of stars where the sky broke free of the street lamps. He did not know their names. He did not need to. He let the night settle and he did not ask it to perform.

He stayed until the chill settled in like an old friend. He stayed until the only sound left was the ocean and the thin brush of wind in the grasses by the dune. He stayed until he knew it was time to sleep.

In her suite, Nova opened her eyes and watched a plane move like a slow spark above the skyline. She did not reach for her phone. She did not plan tomorrow.

The hotel room had gone settled, the city hum softened by distance. She cracked the window, letting the night air cool her face. Somewhere down the coast, the ocean was closer to morning.

She opened their message thread.

You awake?

A few minutes passed. Then he responded.

I'm awake. Hard to sleep tonight.

She smiled, imagining his porch light, the quiet streets of Ocean-side, the way the ocean sounded softer there.

Wish we could trade coasts for one night.

Soon. When the noise settles.

She typed, then deleted, then finally sent:

Maybe it never does.

His reply came slower this time.

Then we find peace somehow, somewhere.

She set the phone face down and whispered a prayer into the dark. “Show me how.” The wind carried the salt through the window and she knew—distance wasn’t the same as silence. Not anymore.

She turned off the lamp and let tomorrow wait.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

*I stopped running from the quiet
the night I finally let it find me.
- Nova Hart, "Low Tide," unreleased*

Three days later, Nova's flight touched down through coastal rain. Her team's text said the Wilmington show was officially canceled mid-air because of "venue complications," but she knew better. The label wanted things to cool down after the storm surrounding The Name They Fear.

She couldn't even be angry. The pause, she thought, might be mercy disguised as management.

The next concert wasn't for five days in Philadelphia. The D.C. show had already been postponed.

For once, her calendar looked blank, and it felt like an invitation.

From her luxury window seat she'd seen a long strip of coastline, gray and dampened, with islands scattered like small prayers in the surf. South of Wilmington lay Smith Island. Twenty minutes of back roads and causeway. She remembered the quiet.

When the jet touched down at the small private terminal, her driver wasn't waiting with a limo this time. Marcy had handled it quietly: a rental under Nova's middle name, keys and directions left at the desk. No entourage, no press trail.

Nova sent one short text to Marcy.

Getting pie. Cover me til tomorrow night.

Finally.

Nova smiled, slid on her sunglasses, and stepped out into the cool Carolina rain.

The road to Oceanside shimmered through fog, headlights sliding across damp asphalt and resting houses. Nova's phone lay face down in the cup holder, notifications muted, the world finally hushed around her.

She hadn't told anyone where she was going. Greg would've forbidden it. Reid would've insisted on coming. Her team would've spun it. Only Marcy knew, and only because she didn't try to stop her.

The ocean came into view as the highway curved toward the shoreline. A low hum of waves met her through the cracked window, the same sound that had haunted her dreams for weeks.

When she pulled up in front of Elliot's house, every light was off except one in the kitchen.

She hesitated with her hand on the door handle, her heart moving fast and bright, the way it did before a show. Then she knocked, once, softly.

Footsteps approached. The door opened.

Elliot stood there in a faded T shirt and jeans, eyes wide, hair rumpled like he had drifted asleep in a chair with a book in his lap.

"Nova," he breathed. "It's midnight."

"I couldn't sleep," she said. "And I didn't want to wait anymore."

He stared for a moment as if checking that she was real. Then he stepped aside, voice low. "Come in."

She crossed the threshold and pulled her jacket close, taking in the familiar scent of salt and cedar.

"I didn't mean to just show up," she murmured. "But *The Name They Fear* releases tomorrow. Not the clip. The whole song."

She looked up at him. "And I needed to see you before the world heard it."

Her phone had been silent since she'd switched it to do not disturb on the highway. She knew what the morning would bring. Tonight she chose this instead. Somewhere in the world, the countdown to midnight had already begun.

Elliot exhaled, a soft sound between disbelief and understanding. "You drove an hour in the dark for a song?"

"No," she said, meeting his eyes. "For the man who helped me believe in it."

Elliot did not answer right away. His shoulders eased, just slightly. He looked at her like he believed her.

With a gentler tone, he pointed towards the kitchen. "You want tea or coffee. Something to make this feel less unreal."

"Tea," she said. "If it buys me five more minutes of pretending I am not about to lose my mind."

He smiled and turned to the kettle. Water ran. The stove hummed. The distant waves broke in their quiet rhythm. Nova leaned against the counter and watched him, memorizing the moment.

When he slid her a mug, she did not drink from it.

Instead, she took out her phone. "I want you to hear something first. Not the new song. The one that came right after I met you. It was the first one that felt like it was actually mine again."

She hesitated before adding, "It was just for us. The label turned it into a hit, but this is how it sounded the night I wrote it."

He nodded slowly, bracing himself.

She pressed play.

The opening chords of *That Look on Your Face* drifted through the kitchen, nothing but her guitar and a voice that trembled in a way she no longer allowed herself onstage.

When the last note faded, even the air seemed to hold still.

Elliot swallowed before he spoke. "It is beautiful."

Her smile came small and unguarded. "You make it sound like it is not unreasonable that I wrote that about you."

"It is not unreasonable," he said softly. "It is honest."

She looked up at him then. Really looked. The kitchen light illuminated the subtle creases around his eyes, the way he stood without crowding her, as if space itself were a gift he could offer. His kindness was not loud or performed. It was patient and careful, the kind of goodness that could not be faked.

He stood close enough that she could feel his warmth, but he did not step toward her. He held himself with a respect she had rarely been given.

So she stepped forward.

The kiss came slow and certain, like tide meeting shore. Gentle at first. Then sure. It was not hurried or reckless, but the kind of kiss that

steadied rather than startled. He tasted of tea and warmth. His hand rose to the back of her neck, warm and steady, the peace she had been chasing for weeks.

When they finally drew apart, Nova rested her forehead against his chin.

“Why did you do that?” Elliot said.

“Because I knew you respect me too much to kiss me first,” Nova whispered. “We probably just complicated everything.”

Elliot’s smile was faint and certain. “Complicated is still better than empty.”

She let out a quiet laugh. “You and your grown up logic.”

They stayed there another moment, two people who had finally stopped pretending to be sensible, before the world crept back in.

They moved into the living room, where the lamps cast a soft amber glow across the shelves and the faint sound of the ocean drifted through the cracked window. The whole house settled, as if it had been waiting for this version of them.

They talked for an hour, voices low and unhurried, the kind of conversation that happens only when two people no longer feel the need to impress. Nothing dramatic. Nothing curated. Just ordinary pieces of life. Childhood memories. Strange tour mishaps. The sound gulls make when they chase the tide. Words that come easily when honesty is closer than performance.

Her head eventually settled onto his shoulder, around the two o’clock mark. Her tea sat untouched on the table. The ocean’s hum outside sounded like a lullaby. Elliot did not move. He simply breathed

with her, letting the quiet settle between them like a prayer he had not known he was holding.

When her head slipped a little, he adjusted the blanket around her and whispered, "You are safe here."

She believed him. That was new.

Her face, without makeup or stage light, looked young in a way fame never allowed. When her breathing eased into the slow rhythm of the sea, he leaned back and let the peace hold them both.

Nothing more happened. Nothing needed to. The stillness was enough.

Morning came gray and slow. She woke curled in the corner of the couch, the blanket still around her shoulders, the kettle cold on the stove. Elliot sat in the nearby chair, watching quietly as she stirred.

Nova blinked, rubbing her eyes. "I didn't even hear you move to the chair."

"You were out the moment your head touched my shoulder," he said with a small smile. "I figured you would sleep better if I let you have the couch."

His voice held something between relief and wonder. "You actually slept."

"I did," she whispered. "And for once, it felt real."

"Good," he said. "You needed rest more than anything."

The quiet that followed felt full, not empty, like the ocean beyond the windows.

Nova stood, stretching the sleep from her shoulders, her heart still carrying the calm of the night before. She met his eyes. "I don't wake up bracing here."

"Simpler, I hope," he said.

"Kinder," she answered, her fingertip brushing his wrist.

He looked at her, and the pull was there again. Familiar. Undeniable. But this time neither of them moved. The peace they had found did not need another test.

It simply was.

Somewhere in the kitchen, his phone buzzed with a reminder about nothing important. Morning light stretched across the floor and Nova leaned back against the counter, her shoulders easing.

"Marcy is coming this morning," she said with a small laugh. "She promised emergency coffee and concealer."

Elliot smiled. "Sounds like she knows you well."

"She does," Nova said. "But even she has no idea how good this felt."

Elliot studied her. "She knows?"

"She knows enough," Nova said. "She does not tell Greg anything unless I tell her to."

He nodded once. "That is good. For now, this stays between us. Your world is not ready for Oceanside mornings."

She smiled. "And your world is not ready for paparazzi."

"Exactly."

She watched him for a moment. "You really think we can keep this ours?"

He met her eyes. "I think we can protect it. That is not the same thing."

Nova held his gaze, then nodded. "Protected, then."

Outside, the world was already waking up without them.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

The morning was mine until it wasn't.
- Nova Hart, "Without You," unreleased

Nova's phone buzzed on the counter. She glanced down. "Marcy is here."

A moment later, Marcy knocked once and stepped inside like she owned the place, tote bag already on her shoulder, hairbrush in hand.

"If anyone asks," she said, "I'm your stylist. This is a house call."

Elliot raised an eyebrow. "Morning."

"Morning, Pie Man," Marcy said, giving him an efficient once-over. "You look exactly how I pictured."

"And here I was hoping to surprise you," he said with a half smile.

"You did," she said. "You look real. That is rare in her world."

Elliot gave a small nod and stepped back, already heading toward the kitchen.

Then she turned to Nova. "You good?"

Nova nodded. "Better than good."

Marcy's expression softened into something lighter. "Good. You finally look human again. I can work with that."

She unpacked her kit at the table while Nova poured coffee. Neither of them spoke. The clink of mugs and the soft rustle of fabric filled the space, unhurried and familiar.

When Nova went to shower, Marcy and Elliot stayed where they were. Neither of them moved right away.

Marcy broke the silence first.

"She is not built for small," Marcy said. "But she is learning. And she does not let people in like this. Ever."

"I know," Elliot said.

"So do not make me regret trusting you."

He met her eyes. "I will not."

Marcy studied him, then her mouth curved into the half-smirk she saved for truths that needed saying.

"Good," she said, slipping her brush back into her bag. "Because if you hurt her, I will pray down something biblical."

Elliot didn't smile. "I won't."

Marcy held his gaze for a moment. Then she picked up her bag. "Okay then."

Nova's voice floated down the hallway, singing the chorus of her song, unaware of the conversation.

That look on your face gave me my first smile in ages...

Marcy turned toward the sound. "There it is," she said softly. "That is the part of her nobody gets to fake."

When Nova returned, dressed and glowing with the kind of happiness that did not need an audience, Marcy gave her a knowing smile.

“Well,” Marcy said, zipping her bag, “my work here is done. I am leaving before I become the third wheel in a Nicholas Sparks montage.”

Nova laughed and hugged her. “Thank you. For everything.”

“Just do not make me pray down any more plagues,” Marcy teased as she headed for the door.

When it closed behind her, the house grew settled again. Nova turned to Elliot, hesitated, then stepped close and kissed him once more, quiet and unhurried.

“I will text when I am back at the hotel,” she said.

He brushed his thumb along her cheek. “Drive safely.”

“Soon,” she said with a soft smile.

“Soon,” he answered.

He walked her to the door. His Harbor Light Cafe sweatshirt hung over the chair in the hall. She lifted it without thinking, and he didn’t say a word.

Across the street from Elliot’s house, a tourist stood on the porch of a rental cottage, phone raised toward the water. Early light slid between the houses in thin bands, catching the rippled surface of the ocean as the sun edged up, pale and slow.

Through that narrow view, she caught more than the sea. Nova Hart crossed the drive toward her car, laughing at something Elliot Brooks said beside her. The wind lifted her hood, sunlight catching the auburn hair that made her unmistakable. He stood a step behind her, older, grounded, his hands in his pockets as if the world outside that moment did not exist.

She raised her phone without thinking. Through the lens they looked different — smaller, caught. A moment neither of them had meant to show.

The woman blinked and lowered her phone. For a heartbeat she wondered if she had imagined it. Then she zoomed in and gasped. “No way,” she whispered, hardly daring to breathe.

As the car eased down the coastal road, she glanced at the porch across the street. The house number 522 hung in weathered bronze beside the door. She snapped a second picture of it, the detail sticking in her mind like a clue.

She looked at the photo again, still stunned by her own luck.

She typed a caption before she could think better of it.

Is that Nova Hart in Oceanside? And who's the guy??

She hit post.

At the end of the street, Nova's car turned toward the highway, her phone face down in her purse.

Her screen refreshed.

One like became ten, then hundreds, climbing faster than she could follow.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

*"Some things were never meant for light.
That doesn't make them less true."*

- Nova Hart, untitled

The road to Wilmington felt open and alive. Nova rolled the window halfway down and let the salt air tangle her hair. A melody circled in her mind, new and soft, the kind that stayed long after the last note. Every mile felt like freedom—and she kept humming, unaware of what had already begun to move without her.

By the time she reached her hotel, she dropped her bag on the bed without thinking, still humming under her breath.

She caught her reflection in the mirror and paused. Her eyes were clear, her shoulders lower than they had been in weeks. Her phone buzzed. Greg.

"Hey," she said, still smiling. "You are up early."

He spoke in a clipped voice. "I have been up. Tell me, Nova, who lives at 522?"

She frowned. "What?"

"A picture," he said. "#WhoIs522. You. Oceanside. Some guy in a faded blue shirt with the Harbor Light Cafe logo. Ringing any bells."

The words hit before she could slow her breath. The edges of the room blurred, leaving only Greg's face and the sound of her own breathing.

"Greg," she whispered. "That's him."

"Go to socials," Greg said. "Search #WhoIs522. I'll wait."

Nova sat on the edge of the bed and opened the app with shaking hands. The first post filled the screen.

Elliot stood in his driveway with ocean light across his shirt. Nova's hair blew in the wind. Her eyes were fixed on him like the world had narrowed down to one steady point.

The house number was clear.

Her throat closed. "Greg, that's his house."

"Yeah," he said. "And now it is the internet's."

Nova's breath came quick. She kept staring at the comments.

People were already posting maps.

"They are going to find him," she whispered.

"That is why you need to do nothing," Greg said. "No posts. No comments. No calls. Let it die down."

"Greg, Elliot is not a headline," she said, voice rising. "He is a person."

"He is a liability right now," Greg replied. "If you want to protect him, you stay silent."

Nova's fingers hovered over Elliot's name. Every part of her wanted to call him. To warn him. To say this was not how she would have chosen it.

"Greg," she said, quieter now, "he matters to me."

The silence on the line stretched.

“That complicates things,” Greg said finally. “He is not part of this world.”

“You don’t know him,” Nova said.

“We checked,” Greg replied. “Public information. He is older. Widowed. Shows up on a church website in Oceanside.”

“And what is that supposed to mean?”

“It means he is visible,” Greg said.

“It does not make him a problem,” she said.

“It does when the internet thinks you are secretly dating him,” Greg replied. “Now we are one breath away from a faith controversy we cannot control. Sponsors will get nervous. The label will get nervous. Everyone will ask what changed you.”

Nova looked at the photo again. Her eyes looked soft. Her face looked unguarded. The photo told the truth, even if no one knew the complete story.

“This is not a game,” Greg said. “Do nothing. Let the noise burn itself out.”

Nova swallowed hard. “Okay.”

When the call ended, she bowed her head.

“Lord, please,” she whispered, “help me not make this worse.”

Marcy had left Oceanside at dawn. She slipped out after hugging Nova in the doorway. The hall was dim in the early light. The world outside was calm in the way mornings sometimes are, like it had not learned what it would carry by noon.

Marcy drove north. Coastal roads. Empty lanes. The sun rising gold over the water.

By midmorning she reached Wilmington. The hotel lobby hummed with people starting their day. She grabbed a coffee, rode the elevator up, and set her things on the desk by the window.

Then she opened her phone.

Nova was trending again.

A new tag sat on every post.

#WhoIs522

Marcy clicked the first one. The photo filled her screen. Nova and Elliot in the driveway. Sunlight cut across them both. The look between them was unmistakable.

And behind them, the house number. 522.

Marcy's stomach turned. "Lord, not today."

She called Nova twice. Straight to voicemail.

So she scrolled to Elliot's number and hit call.

He answered on the second ring. "Hello."

"Elliot Brooks."

"Yes."

"Elliot, it's Marcy. I just left your place."

A beat. "Is Nova okay?"

"She's fine," Marcy said. "But have you been online this morning?"

"No. Why?"

"There's a photo of you and Nova outside your house," Marcy said.

"The house number shows. It's spreading fast."

Silence.

"You are sure it is real," he said.

"I am looking at it right now," Marcy said. "Someone must have taken it as she left. The hashtag #WhoIs522 is now trending."

Elliot exhaled, forcing his body to stay calm. "What do I need to do?"

Marcy kept her voice firm. "Stay home. Do not answer the door. Do not talk to anyone. No statements. No posts. If someone calls pretending to be press, hang up. If someone shows up, close the door and call me."

"Understood."

"I will reach Nova once she calls me back," Marcy said. "She doesn't know I am calling you yet."

"I figured this might happen someday," Elliot said. "I just did not expect it to feel this personal."

"It always feels personal," Marcy said. "That is why we have to move carefully."

"Thank you," he said.

"You do not need to thank me," Marcy replied. "I protect her. That includes you now."

His voice softened. "I will do as you say."

Marcy's phone buzzed. Nova.

"Elliot," Marcy said, "she is calling me now. I will tell her you are safe."

"Alright," he said quietly.

Marcy switched lines and took a breath before answering. "Nova."

"Yeah," Nova said. "You talked to him."

"I did," Marcy said. "I saw the photo. I did not want him blind-sided."

Nova sighed. "Greg called me. He told me about it."

"The house number shows," Marcy said. "It is moving fast. Reporters will move in before lunch."

Nova went quiet for a moment. "Then it is real?"

"It is real," Marcy said. "But it is still manageable. I told him to stay home and stay quiet. You need to do the same. No posts. No comments. Nothing they can twist."

"I know," Nova said. "It just feels wrong not to say anything."

"I get that," Marcy replied. "But silence is your shield right now. Let me and Greg handle the noise until we know the angle."

Nova's voice dropped. "He did not sound angry."

"No," Marcy said. "He sounded grounded. He was more worried about you than himself."

"That sounds like him," Nova whispered.

Marcy softened. "Real things do not wait for perfect timing."

Nova gave a shaky laugh. "That is one way to put it."

"Stay off socials," Marcy said. "Keep your phone close. Eat something. You need a clear head."

"Okay."

Marcy paused. "You are not alone in this."

"I know," Nova said, quieter. "Thank you."

"Always," Marcy replied. "Remember who you are. They cannot rewrite that."

The call ended. Nova stared at the wall for a long moment, breathing slow.

Then she whispered, "Please ... keep him safe."

Elliot sat at the kitchen table with his phone still in his hand. The refrigerator hummed. The sea beyond the window looked calm, light glinting across the waves like nothing had changed.

He had not moved since Marcy's call.

His phone buzzed again.

Clara.

He hesitated, then answered. "Hey, sweetheart."

"Dad," Clara said, voice tight, "please tell me this is not true."

He closed his eyes. "Tell me what is not true?"

"There is a picture of you online," she said. "You and Nova Hart. It is everywhere. People are saying you are seeing her."

"So you saw it."

"Everyone has seen it," Clara said. "Someone sent it to me with a laughing emoji. I do not want strangers to turn you into a joke."

Elliot did not answer right away.

"I know," he said.

"What were you thinking?" she demanded. "She is a celebrity. And she is so much younger than you."

"She is also thoughtful and kind," he said. "And she listens. The world does not see that part."

Clara's breath hitched. "People are saying she stayed the night. Dad, the entire world thinks you slept with her."

Elliot kept his voice even. "She stayed. She fell asleep on the couch. I sat in the chair and let her rest. Nothing inappropriate happened."

"But nobody will ever believe that," Clara said, her voice catching despite her effort to steady it. "They are already making jokes."

"I know what people will assume," he said gently. "And I know what actually happened."

"This feels unreal," she whispered. "Mom would never understand this."

He spoke gently to his daughter. "Your mother trusted people slowly. She always said to look at someone's heart before the headlines."

Clara went quiet. He could hear her breathing.

"I just do not want you hurt," she said.

His voice softened. "I will not. I promise."

Clara exhaled. "I wish Mom were here."

"So do I," he said.

When the call ended, Elliot set the phone face down on the table.

Every sound felt sharper than it should.

He stood, and without thinking, he checked the locks.

Only after he finished did he realize he had moved at all.

He went to the window. The ocean rolled in its peaceful rhythm.

A car slowed in front of the house. Then another. Engines idled.

Doors opened. Voices gathered like static, rising.

One person lifted a camera. The lens caught the morning light.

Elliot stepped back from the glass.

A knock sounded at the front door, quick and insistent.

"Mr. Brooks," a voice called. "Can we get a comment?"

Elliot did not move.

The knock came again, harder this time.

"Mr. Brooks, is Nova Hart still there? Can you confirm the relationship?"

The refrigerator hummed behind him.

He closed his eyes.

"Please," he whispered. "Let me do this right."

The knock came again, louder this time.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

"The noise did not stop. I did."

- **Nova Hart, untitled**

Nova sat on the edge of the hotel bed with her phone in both hands, staring at the photo like it was a bruise that kept spreading.

Elliot in the driveway.

Her face turned toward him.

The house number in plain view.

She had seen it once. That was enough.

Now it was everywhere.

Her screen kept refreshing without her meaning to. Clips. Zoom ins. People circling the numbers. People making guesses like they were solving a game.

She forced herself to turn off the phone.

Silence did not stop the world. It only stopped her from feeding it.

Her thumb hovered over the power button again. Just to check. Just once.

She dropped it onto the mattress instead.

A soft knock sounded at the door.

"You okay?" Marcy's voice called.

Nova took a shallow breath and swallowed before she spoke.

"Come in."

Marcy stepped inside with her keys still in hand, hair pulled back as if she had been driving hard and thinking harder. She took one look at Nova's face and her shoulders dropped.

"Okay," Marcy said. "You saw it."

Nova nodded, throat tight.

Marcy crossed the room and turned the deadbolt, then checked the latch without making a show of it. She walked back to the bed and sat beside Nova like they had done a thousand times on tours when the world got loud.

"They are moving faster than usual." Marcy folded her arms. "That house number made it easy."

Nova pressed her fingertips to her forehead. "I feel sick."

"I know," Marcy said. "But listen to me. You are going to do three things and only three things right now."

Nova looked up.

Marcy held up one finger. "You are going to stay off socials."

Nova nodded.

Second finger. "You are going to let Greg and legal handle press. You do not post. You do not comment. You do not explain."

Nova's mouth tightened. "That feels wrong."

"It feels wrong because you are a person," Marcy said. "But stillness is the only shield you have for him right now."

Third finger. "You are going to eat something and drink water."

Nova gave a small, broken laugh. "That one feels impossible."

Marcy's eyes softened. "Then take two bites. Two is still something."

Nova stared at her hands. "Did you talk to him?"

Marcy hesitated, just a beat.

Nova's eyes lifted. "Marcy."

"I did," Marcy said. "I called him before I called you back. I needed him to lock down before someone knocked."

Nova's chest squeezed. "Was he angry?"

"No," Marcy said. "He was worried about you."

Nova let out a breath that loosened something in her chest.

"That sounds like him," she whispered.

Marcy leaned back and watched her. "This is real, Nova."

Nova's eyes filled. "That is the problem."

Marcy did not correct her. She just nodded, slow and careful, like she was choosing not to push.

Nova's phone buzzed again, loud against the quiet.

Marcy picked it up and glanced at the screen. "Greg."

Nova did not move.

Marcy answered, voice calm and clean. "Greg."

Nova stood without thinking and drifted toward the bathroom doorway. Greg's voice cut through the speaker, sharp and controlled, and she stopped there and did not move.

"Where is she," he asked.

"In Wilmington," Marcy said. "In the room. Safe."

"We need full lock down," Greg said. "No posts. No contact. No reaching out to him."

Marcy's jaw tightened. "That is what I told her."

"The label is calling legal," Greg continued. "Sponsors are asking questions. They are using brand safety language now."

Nova flinched at the phrase.

Marcy kept her voice even. "Let them talk. She is not posting."

"She needs to understand the stakes," Greg said. "This is not just gossip. This is escalation. Fans are posting maps. Press will show up."

Marcy glanced at Nova, like she was checking that the warning landed.

Nova's eyes dropped to the carpet.

"She is with me," Marcy said. "You handle your people."

A pause.

Then Greg's voice softened just a little. "Is she falling apart?"

Marcy looked at Nova again. Her eyes were wet, but her posture was still upright. That mattered.

"She is scared," Marcy said. "But she is here."

"Good," Greg replied. "Tell her to stay inside. No windows. No lobby. No nothing until we know what is outside the building."

Marcy's tone turned firm. "Greg, she is not a child."

"She is a target," he said.

The word hung in the air.

Nova's stomach turned.

Marcy ended the call before it could keep digging. She set the phone down and reached for Nova's hand.

"Hey," she said. "Look at me."

Nova looked up.

Marcy's voice softened. "You are not trapped. You are protected. There is a difference."

Nova swallowed hard. "It does not feel like it."

"I know," Marcy said. "But you are going to get through today without making it worse. That is the goal. Not perfect. Just steady."

Nova blinked fast. "What about him?"

Marcy squeezed her hand once. "He is staying quiet. He is not feeding the fire."

"He does not deserve this."

Marcy did not argue.

"I want him to know I am not running." Marcy nodded slowly. "Then write it. Do not send it yet. Just write it. Your brain needs a place to put the truth."

Nova grabbed her notebook from the bedside table and flipped it open.

Nova grabbed her notebook from the bedside table and flipped it open. Her pen hovered, shaking.

She wrote one line, then scratched it out.

She wrote again.

I did not choose this.

I did not choose the photo.

I did choose you.

Her chest tightened on the last sentence. It felt too big. Too close to the edge of what she had not said out loud.

She pressed the pen down harder.

Then she heard it, faint but real.

A small sound outside the room.

Not words. Not clear. Just the sense of movement in the hallway, like people passing with purpose.

Marcy's gaze shifted toward the door.

Nova's voice dropped. "Are they here?"

Marcy held up a hand. "Listen."

They both went still.

A muffled voice carried through the hall, then faded.

Marcy stood and checked the peephole. She did not open the door.

After a long moment she let out a slow breath. "Could be staff. Could be anyone. But we do not take chances."

Nova nodded, heart pounding.

Marcy stepped back from the door. "I am going to call Elliot again."

Nova's eyes widened. "Marcy, Greg said no contact."

"Greg is not the one being hunted in the driveway," Marcy said, quiet but firm. "I am not posting. I am not feeding press. I am making sure he stays safe."

Nova's voice cracked. "Please, do not say anything that makes him feel responsible."

Marcy's expression softened. "I will not."

She stepped into the bathroom and left the door mostly closed, but Nova could still hear the low murmur of her voice through the crack. Nova sat on the bed, frozen, not meaning to listen but unable to stop.

Elliot answered quickly.

"Hello."

"Elliot, it is Marcy," she said. "Are you still inside?"

"Yes," he replied. "Clara called. The door has been loud."

Marcy lowered her voice. "Good. Do not open it. Do not talk through it either. If anyone claims they just want a comment, they are fishing."

"I understand," Elliot said.

"She is safe," Marcy added. "She is under lockdown. No posts. No public contact."

Another pause.

"Is she alright?" Elliot asked.

Marcy hesitated, then spoke gently. "She is scared. And she hates that you are paying for this."

Elliot's voice stayed calm, but it sounded heavier now. "I hate that she is paying too."

Marcy's tone softened in a way that made Nova's chest tighten.

"She wanted you to know she cares," Marcy said. "More than she knows how to say."

Silence.

Then Elliot's breath, slow and controlled. "Tell her I care too. She does not have to prove anything to me."

Marcy's voice went quieter. "She cares more than she expected to."

Nova's breath caught. Her whole body went still.

Elliot did not answer fast. When he did, his voice sounded careful, like he was holding something fragile.

"I will wait," he said.

Marcy exhaled, almost relieved. "Good. That is what she needs. Steady. No pressure."

"I can do that," Elliot said. "I am praying for her."

Marcy's voice softened. "I am praying, too."

The call ended.

Nova stood in the doorway without realizing she had moved. Marcy turned and saw her there.

Marcy's eyes widened. "Nova."

"I did not mean to listen," Nova whispered. "I just ... heard."

Marcy stepped closer. "Are you mad?"

Nova shook her head, tears sliding down now. "No. I feel exposed."

Marcy nodded. "I know."

Nova wiped her face with the back of her hand. "Did he really say he would wait?"

"Yes," Marcy said. "He meant it."

Nova pressed her palm to her chest like she could keep her heart from spilling out.

"He is so steady," she whispered. "And I am not."

Marcy took her shoulders gently. "You are steadier than you think. You are just surrounded by noise."

Nova looked down at her notebook.

The words were still there.

I did choose you.

She drew a shaky breath and wrote a new line beneath it.

Maybe some things do not vanish under light. Maybe they learn to stand in it.

Marcy watched her write, then nodded as if the sentence mattered.

Nova set the pen down and folded her hands in her lap. Her lips moved before she decided.

“Lord,” she whispered, “help me be brave without being reckless. Help me protect him. Help me not hide from what is true.”

Marcy sat beside her again. No lecture. No fixing. Just presence.

Nova reached for her phone.

Marcy tensed.

Nova turned it off.

The screen went black. The low buzz she hadn’t noticed until then disappeared.

Nova exhaled. “I cannot fight the world and stay honest at the same time.”

Marcy nodded. “Then do the next right thing.”

Nova stared at the notebook and whispered, almost like she was promising herself.

“I will not post. I will not perform. I will not panic.”

Marcy gave a small smile. “That sounds like you.”

Outside, the world called it curiosity.

Inside, Nova Hart sat in quiet and let the truth stay plain.

And far away, in a small seaside house with a locked door, Elliot Brooks stayed calm.

The noise had not quieted.

He had.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

Though the walls were clear, Love stayed concealed,
A silhouette in blinding light.
I thought the quiet would help me heal,
Until the world came looking for a fight
- **Nova Hart, from “Glass House”**

The air conditioner hummed.

Nova opened her eyes to a room that felt too bright.

Mascara dried beneath her lashes, rough against her skin.

The phone buzzed. Once. Then again.

It did not stop.

For a moment she listened to the sound, slow and steady, like a heartbeat that did not belong to her. Curiosity won. She reached for the phone and looked.

She was trending number one this morning.

#NovaHart

#MysteryMan

#Oceanside

Her face filled every thumbnail. Each image caught the same look. Her head turned toward him. Her mouth was open mid-laugh. Unguarded. Years of practice undone by one moment she forgot to perform.

Names stacked on the screen. Greg. Marcy. A number marked PR Emergencies.

She turned the phone face down and closed her eyes.

The quiet she had trusted had turned against her. It was supposed to keep her safe. Now it was where the noise began.

The phone buzzed again. Louder somehow. Sharper.

Nova picked it up.

Greg did not wait for hello.

“Do not hang up.”

His voice was tight, already pulled thin. “Every outlet has the photo. Morning shows. Gossip feeds. Industry blogs. The diner picture is everywhere. Someone connected it to Oceanside. They know whose house it was. They know he was at both places.”

Nova sat up slowly, her stomach heavy. “Greg, it is not what they are saying.”

“Right now they are saying you spent the night with a man twice your age. They are saying you have been sneaking around for months.”

“I fell asleep on a couch,” she said. “That is all. I did nothing wrong.”

“I know,” Greg said. “But silence looks guilty. The label wants a statement. A tweet. Something about private friendship and creative inspiration. Keep it soft. Keep it safe.”

Her voice cracked. “They are calling me reckless. Desperate. Like I planned this. Like I wanted any of it.”

"You think I do not hear it?" Greg said. "I have been on the phone since dawn trying to keep this from piling up."

"I did not sleep with him," she said. "I fell asleep. That is it."

"I hear you," he said, his tone tightening. "But the picture tells a different story."

"The picture lies."

"The picture sells," Greg said. "That is what matters."

Nova sat straighter. "So I smile, post something vague, and pretend none of it happened."

"Yes."

Her hand shook around the phone. "You are asking me to bury the truth."

"I am asking you to survive the day."

No sound came from the line.

"You care more about the version of me they buy," she whispered.

"That is my job," Greg replied. "Your job is to make people believe it."

She laughed once, without humor. "Then maybe I am done doing my job."

"Do not say that," he warned. "You are tired."

"I mean it."

The line went dead.

Nova set the phone down. The screen glowed with messages she did not open. The room felt staged, too careful. Even the hum of the air conditioner sounded false.

She reached for her notebook. The cover was soft from travel, corners bent, pages crowded with half written lyrics. Her hand hovered over a blank page.

Nothing came.

She closed it and looked at her reflection in the dark mirror of her phone. Her face looked older. Not from age, but from being seen.

She tried again.

I am sorry this happened. I never meant for it to touch you.

She stared at the sentence until the letters blurred, then dragged the pen through them hard enough to tear the paper.

She turned to a clean corner.

You do not owe anyone an explanation. I hope you are okay.

She crossed that one out too, pressing deep enough to leave grooves in the paper beneath.

The blank space felt louder than words.

A soft knock broke the stillness. Three quick taps and one slower. Marcy.

Nova closed the notebook and went to the door.

Marcy stood in the hallway with a paper bag and two coffees. Her hair was tied back. Sunglasses hid her eyes.

"Hey," she mumbled. "You up for company?"

Nova nodded and stepped aside.

Marcy set the coffee down. "It is chaos out there. Reporters are parked by the elevators. I told them you were asleep."

"You lied."

Marcy shrugged. "I protected my client."

"You saw the photos."

"All of them."

"They look bad."

"They look real," Marcy said. "That is worse."

Nova looked down at her hands. "I did nothing wrong."

"I know," Marcy said. "But people want a story."

"I am tired of being one."

Marcy studied her face. "Then tell a better one."

"What does that mean."

"Do not let them write it for you," Marcy said. "Say something when you are ready. Not for the label. For yourself."

Nova nodded slowly, unsure if she believed she could.

Marcy slid a coffee toward her. "Drink this."

The heat grounded her.

"Greg wants a post," Nova said.

"I know," Marcy said. "He also wants a miracle."

"I am not giving him either."

"Then we start small," Marcy said. "Shower. Eat. Breathe. Write one true sentence."

"I could not even write half of one."

"You will," Marcy said. "Not for them. For you."

"They think I slept with him."

"I know."

"I did not."

"I know that too."

"He made coffee. We talked. I fell asleep."

Marcy folded the bag. "Truth and rumor never move at the same speed."

Nova looked up. "Do you think I made this worse."

"I think you were human," Marcy said. "The world is bad at that."

Nova exhaled. "I want to protect him."

"Then do not post today," Marcy said.

"He will still be in it."

“He already is,” Marcy replied. “But you can choose how much you add.”

Nova opened the notebook again. The torn page showed like a wound. She flipped past it and found a clean sheet.

I was not made for lies.

It did not fix anything. But it did not feel false.

Marcy stood. “I will run interference. If Greg calls again, I will stall him.”

“Thank you.”

“Shower,” Marcy said. “Then try again.”

Nova watched her leave.

Steam fogged the bathroom mirror. She washed her face clean. Mascara rinsed away. No makeup. No costume. She dressed in soft clothes and tied her hair back.

When she sat at the desk again, the paper did not scare her as much.

If they shout, I will not sing along.

She paused, then added another.

If mercy finds me, I will not run.

Her phone buzzed on the bed. She let it sit.

She crossed the room and stood by the window. A gull cut across the sky.

She typed two sentences to him, then stopped. Sending them felt like making something real.

She copied the words into the back of her notebook instead.

A knock sounded. Slower. Heavier.

Security stood with the hotel manager. They offered a quieter floor.

She looked around the room once. It had not become hers. None of them did anymore.

Ten minutes later she packed only what mattered. Notebook. Phone. Hoodie. She left the flowers behind.

Greg called again.

"I am moving," she said. "No press."

"You still need to post."

"No."

"The label is drafting something."

"They can send it."

A pause.

"Is he important to you?" Greg asked.

Nova breathed. "He was kind to me."

"That is not a strategy."

"It is the truth."

"I will buy you six hours," he said.

At the new room she sat at the desk again.

She rested her forehead against the desk.

The words stayed inside her.

She breathed.

Then she lifted her head.

Marcy texted things were clear. There was food in the bag. A slice of pie. The foil was still warm.

Nova smiled.

She wrote a fourth line.

I will not trade quiet for applause.

She opened the text thread with Elliot.

Still here. Are you safe?

Nova typed.

I am here. They want me to post a lie. I am not posting.

The reply came.

Good. I will stay quiet, too.

Her throat tightened.

Thank you.

As evening settled, she wrote again.

*They watched the glass and called it me.
I kept my real name out of sight.
If I am held up to the light,
Let what is honest be the thing they see.*

She underlined the last line.

When sleep came, it did not feel like escape. It felt earned.

She would not post.

She would not lie.

She would tell the truth when she was ready.

The room settled.

Nova breathed and let the day close.

CHAPTER TWENTY

*"Peace was never the absence of noise.
It was what stayed when the noise arrived."*
— **Nova Hart, untitled**

The morning smelled of rain.

Elliot waited at the counter for the kettle to sing while the first light filtered through the blinds. Outside, the sea was pale and still, the kind of calm that made you suspicious.

He poured the water over the grounds and whispered a prayer for quiet. He thanked God for the peace that still lived inside the walls of the house.

He scrolled once, then stopped.

The same photo filled every feed. The thin morning light found him and Nova near the car, her smile open, his hand still partially raised as though he hadn't finished saying something. The tag followed it everywhere. #WhoIs522.

His thumb hovered over the comments, then moved past them. He set the phone facedown on the table. The hush that followed felt temporary, like air before a shift in wind.

He opened his Bible beside the mug. The words reminded him that peace did not depend on silence.

The Lord is my refuge and strength.

He whispered the verse again until his heart steadied.

Outside, a gull crossed the gray sky. The coffee cooled on the table. He told himself he could still choose quiet even when the world shouted.

The phone buzzed once. He ignored it.

It buzzed again, longer this time.

By the third vibration, the sound of peace had changed.

A car slowed outside, its tires whispering over the damp street. He watched it pass behind the dunes and fade.

Something in him tightened. He set the mug down carefully and waited.

Then came the knock at the door.

He moved to the hallway and looked through the small window beside the frame.

Two people stood on the porch in dark jackets. The woman held a phone ready. The man carried a camera on a strap. A car idled by the curb, its headlights still on.

She said his name with practiced cheer.

“Mr. Brooks?”

Elliot did not step aside.

“Good morning. I’m Rachel Pierce with CoastNow Radio. Can we have a quick word?”

Her tone was polite, but the raised camera told the truth. They were already recording.

“About what?” he asked.

“About Nova Hart,” she said. “There’s been a lot of talk online. Are you and Nova in a relationship?”

He kept his voice even. “I don’t have anything to say.”

The man stepped closer with the camera. “Just a quick comment. Fans want to hear your side.”

Elliot pressed his thumb against the door frame, grounding himself in something solid. “Please leave my property.”

Rachel’s smile thinned. “There’s a photo of her outside a house yesterday morning. By the car. The way you’re looking at each other.”

She tilted her head. “People are saying it’s more than friendship. Do you want to clarify anything?”

His jaw set, the muscles along his neck tightening. “You should leave.”

Down the street, a neighbor’s door opened. Voices carried faintly in the cool air. The man lifted the lens higher, ready to catch anything.

“Turn that off,” Elliot said calmly.

“Just doing our job, sir,” the man replied.

“You’re on private property,” Elliot said, “I’ve asked you to leave.”

Rachel tilted her head, signaling the cameraman to keep filming. “Mr. Brooks, do you think this story could hurt Nova’s career?”

He closed the door and turned the lock. Through the glass he heard her narrate a closing line for the video.

Inside, his pulse ran hard in his ears. He stood still and counted his breaths, slow and deliberate, until the noise receded. Real life didn’t shout like this.

The phone buzzed again on the table.

Marcy was calling.

Elliot answered immediately. "Marcy?"

"Elliot, Greg is with me," she said quickly. "He needs to talk to you."

He drew a breath. "Alright. Put him on."

A beat, and then Greg's voice came through the line, clipped and controlled.

"Mr. Brooks, we need to talk."

"Call me Elliot."

"Elliot," Greg repeated. His voice carried strain. "Tell me you didn't talk to anyone."

"They came to the door. I asked them to leave."

"Did you say anything on record?"

"No. I said I had nothing to say."

Greg exhaled, sharp and relieved. "Good. Keep it that way. Reporters are everywhere. This thing is already national. The story is moving too fast to stop."

"I've seen the tag," Elliot murmured. "#WhoIs522."

"Then here's the problem," Greg said. "Some outlets are saying it's been going on for months."

"That isn't true."

"Truth stopped being the point six hours ago," Greg said flatly. "People believe whatever gets the most views." He paused. "Nova ... trusts you. More than she probably should."

Elliot stilled. "She told you that?"

"She didn't have to," Greg said, his voice losing its polish. "The way she's looking at you in the photo says everything."

He exhaled. "The label's already spinning about the age difference. A world-famous artist in her twenties. A widowed man in his forties. It's a PR minefield."

"She didn't do anything wrong."

"I know she didn't," Greg replied. "And I know you didn't either. But the truth doesn't matter right now. The story does."

He hesitated. "She's safe, but shaken. We moved her before the bigger outlets showed up. She's under lockdown. I'm trying to contain this, but it's spreading faster than I can control."

"She doesn't deserve this."

"No one does," Greg said. "Look, you seem like a decent man. But whether you meant to or not, you're part of a situation I have to manage. And right now, the safest thing you can do is stay silent. No interviews. No comments. No posts. No friends talking for you. Nothing. Let me and her team handle the fallout."

"I will," Elliot said. "I'm not looking for attention."

"Good." Greg paused. "Keep the door closed. Stay off your phone unless it's me or Marcy."

"Understood."

"I hope you mean that," Greg muttered.

The line went dead.

Elliot set the phone on the counter and listened to the distant hum of voices on the porch. He pressed his palm flat against the counter and stayed there until the urge to defend her softened into something steadier.

He turned toward the back door where softer light fell across the floor. The air smelled of salt and rain. He stayed there longer than necessary, letting the quiet finish what the conversation had begun.

His thoughts shifted to Clara. She would see the story before noon. Someone at work would mention it. She would have to decide what to say, and he could not make that easier for her.

He closed his eyes.

Lord, give me the right words when she calls.

The phone stayed quiet. He let it.

The prayer lingered in the still house.

He peeked through the curtain. Outside, reporters clustered along the walkway. Phones hovered. A man adjusted a camera with a telephoto lens, the red light faint but constant.

As soon as he moved the curtain, lenses lifted in unison.

He stepped back. A car door shut somewhere beyond the dunes. Voices grew sharper. This wasn't morning peace. It was a crowd waiting to take something.

After a moment he crossed back to the window and moved the curtain an inch. Through the glass he caught a flash of bright color near the gate. Reporters reacted instantly. Phones rose. Cameras angled. The hum of equipment swelled as they began recording before knowing what they were filming.

Mrs. Danner stepped into view.

Small but determined, vest zipped, walking shoes planted firm on the pavement. The cameras were already rolling.

"Back off the steps," she said, her voice cutting through the morning air. "This isn't a circus. It isn't your story."

She folded her arms. "I've lived through hurricanes and heartbreak. I don't have time for grown adults circling like this."

A man tried to answer, but she talked over him.

"You heard me. Off the porch. If you need to shout, do it from the sidewalk like civilized people."

Her words carried across the yard with the ease of someone who had been a grandmother longer than any reporter had held a camera.

The steps cleared just enough. The red recording lights stayed on.

She climbed the last two steps and rang the bell, still speaking loudly enough for the cameras.

Elliot opened the door.

"Morning, Mrs. Danner."

She stepped inside without hesitation, calling back over her shoulder, "Turn those cameras off. There is nothing for you here."

The door closed behind her, lowering the outside noise to a dull hum.

She held out a foil-wrapped loaf. "Banana bread. With walnuts. Still warm."

"Thank you," Elliot said.

"You holding up?" she asked softly.

"I will be."

"Good. Eat something. And if you need to get out, use my back gate. The one by the azaleas. They won't see you slip through."

"I appreciate that."

She gave a firm nod. "We take care of our own here."

He unwrapped the corner of the loaf. The sweetness drifted into the room.

"You're a good neighbor," she said. "Don't let them make you doubt that."

"Thank you."

She stepped back onto the porch. The reporter followed her with a camera. She spoke to him the whole way down the steps, and Elliot caught one final sentence before she reached the sidewalk.

"Not every story belongs to the world."

He closed the door. The house smelled of warm bread and salt air.

Outside, a voice sharpened his name. Another followed, louder.

A car door slammed. A camera motor whined as it refocused.

He carried the loaf to the counter and cut a slice. The taste steadied him. The verse in his open Bible waited on the table, reliable and unchanged.

The Lord is my refuge and strength.

The words stayed with him as the noise outside swelled.

The noise did not get the final word.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

*They can twist the story.
They cannot change what happened.*
- **Nova Hart, untitled**

The video spread because it worked.

It was funny at first. Then it cut.

A neighbor's shaky phone clip. Ten seconds of Mrs. Danner stepping onto her porch, one hand raised like a traffic cop. Her voice was sharp, Southern, unmistakable.

"Back off the steps," she said. "This is not a circus, and this is not your story."

At first, the internet ignored most of it. It took only the middle line.

Someone clipped the moment she said it. Another looped it. A third dropped a beat underneath the words.

This is... Not a circus.

This is... Not a circus.

The sound spread.

By midmorning, it was everywhere.

Hashtags stacked and multiplied.

No one could scroll past her.

People started playing along.

Teenagers filmed dances in messy bedrooms, wagging their fingers
in time with Mrs. Danner's voice.

Then the captions shifted.

Not a circus?

Then what is she doing smiling like that?

The clip cut to Nova stepping into her car at sunrise, her smile
slowed just enough to linger.

By seven in the morning, the joke had teeth.

It stopped being about Mrs. Danner.

It needed someone else to point at.

Nova woke to her phone vibrating across the nightstand, rattling
like it wanted to escape. For one disoriented second she thought it was
her alarm. Then she blinked at the screen and felt her stomach drop.

Notifications stacked like falling dominoes. Mentions. Tags. Mes-
sages multiplying faster than she could read them.

Greg's name sat at the top with five missed calls.

Her pulse stumbled. She opened her feed before she could stop
herself.

Mrs. Danner's voice blasted through the speakers, looped into a
steady beat. Nova's own face flickered behind it, caught mid smile as
she stepped off the driveway.

This is...

Not a circus.

This is...

Not a circus.

She clapped a hand over her mouth, the sound in her throat caught between a laugh and a cry.

“Oh no. No. No, no, no.”

The comments poured in.

Old guys are in!

She announced she wanted a break last month. Let her breathe.

This is so staged. Total PR.

She scrolled again, bracing herself.

Older guy energy confirmed. He looks like he owns a landline on purpose.

He seems like the type who carries coupons in a neat little folder and thinks it is edgy.

Why does he look like he says that is a want, not a need at the grocery store?

Her throat tightened. The internet had a way of turning breath into noise.

She kept scrolling.

Someone had made a side by side of her smiling in the driveway and her on stage months earlier, exhausted under hot lights.

Tell me this is the same girl.

Another comment floated up.

He looks safe. That's suspicious. ;)

Her hands shook. She locked the phone, then unlocked it again.
Then she saw comments that felt different.

Leave her alone. She finally looks happy for once.

Yall will make drama out of anything.

She is allowed to have a life.

This is the most relaxed she has looked in months.

She kept scrolling until she didn't.

One comment stayed on the screen longer than the rest.

Stop acting like she owes you a press release for being human.

Her phone buzzed again. Greg.

She pressed decline.

Nova crossed the room and closed the curtains, shutting out the pale morning light. The room smelled like hotel soap and cold coffee. Her Bible sat on the desk, the corner folded where she had underlined Psalm 31.

You are my refuge and my fortress.

She read the words, but they felt thin against the roar in her chest. All she could think about was how peaceful the night before had been. How honest. Now it was content.

Her phone buzzed again. A message from Marcy.

Saw the mash ups. People are losing their minds. Do not look if you can help it. You did nothing wrong.

Nova pressed her forehead to the edge of the desk.

“Lord,” she whispered, “please help me hold on to what is real.”

By midmorning, Greg’s office had turned into a war room.

Four screens lit the walls. TikTok. YouTube. Twitter. The label’s press dashboard. A fifth laptop streamed cable news on mute.

“Someone needs to make sure we own the sound,” one of the PR reps said.

Greg cut him off. “Own it? They already ran with it. We’re chasing it.”

He had been awake since four.

The clip had jumped from fifty thousand views to three million in under six hours. A Nashville radio station had mocked up a remix. A late night host had queued it for monologue jokes. Legal wanted takedowns. Social argued that would only feed the beast.

“Do we deny she was there?” a junior rep asked.

“No,” Greg said. “We don’t feed it.”

His inbox stacked with subject lines.

Nova Hart Love Story

Faith and Fame Collide

Is the Mystery Man a Mentor or More

Can We Get A Comment

He typed the statement himself and sent it to legal for approval.

Ms. Hart is focusing on her upcoming tour and values her privacy.

Safe. Colorless. Built to disappear.

His phone buzzed. Nova.

"Do not post," he said immediately. "Do not explain. It burns out faster if you leave it alone."

"This isn't fair."

"Nothing about this job is fair," Greg replied. "You wanted real life. This is the cost."

Her voice softened. "Is he okay?"

Greg closed his eyes. "He's not my priority. You are. Stay offline."

He hung up.

Behind him, on one of the screens, Mrs. Danner's voice bounced over a bright dance track.

This is...Not a circus.

Greg muttered, "Could have fooled me."

Elliot had just finished rinsing his plate when his phone buzzed again. Then again. Then again.

Sixteen unread messages.

Three missed calls.

Clara rattled off several texts.

Dad are you awake

Are you seeing this?

Please answer

Dad?????

He opened one of the links.

Mrs. Danner's voice exploded through the speakers.

This is ... Not a circus.

Then the video cut to him standing frozen in his doorway, caught mid blink. A caption floated above the frame.

Older guy energy confirmed.

Elliot nearly dropped the phone.

He watched the clip again.

Mrs. Danner's voice cut through the commotion, followed immediately by Nova's face, frozen mid-smile, the kind she never gave the camera.

His own image appeared only long enough to be labeled.

He looks like he owns a land line on purpose.

"That's not even..." He let the rest go.

Correcting the joke would not give anything back.

Elliot watched the clip again, then turned the volume down.

Mrs. Danner had stepped in to shield him.

Now her voice was being passed around like a toy.

He wondered if she had gone back inside afterward and finished her breakfast.

Another comment followed.

He lectures people about screen time while using reading glasses.

He pushed his glasses higher on his nose without thinking.

The phone buzzed again.



Dad please answer.

He sat down slowly, a weight pressing against his ribs.

He let the noise settle.

Then he called her back.

"Dad," she said immediately. "Why are you on my feed again?"

"I'm trying to understand that."

"They froze you mid-blink. People keep sending it to me."

"I noticed."

"And the coupon thing. You don't even clip coupons."

"I'm all right," he said gently.

"No, you're not."

"It's noise," he said. "It will pass."

After a pause, her voice softened. "Are you sure?"

"I am," he said. "But pray for Nova. She's carrying more than I am."

"Already did."

He opened the front door to get the paper.

A folded newspaper sat on the porch, weighed down by a smooth shell.

He bent to pick it up.

Cameras burst to life from the street.

"There he is."

"Sir, can you comment?"

"Is Nova Hart staying here?"

He stepped back inside and locked the door.

The paper showed a grainy photo of Nova stepping into her car. He was blurred in the doorway behind her but the headline said it all:

WHO IS 522? THE MAN BEHIND NOVA HART'S SMILE.

He folded the paper once and set it down carefully.

Then he reached for his phone and did not open the comments.

The air felt heavier in Nova's room.

Thunder rolled across the water, low and distant, and the light at the window thinned as clouds closed in.

Nova sat on the edge of the bed, phone face down. Greg had already texted twice.

On my way. Do not talk to anyone.

"They can twist the story," she whispered. "But they can't change what happened."

Greg arrived damp with rain.

"They won't let it go," he said. "We survive the storm first."

"I don't want to lie."

"You won't," he said. "But you will stay quiet."

An hour later, she turned on the television.

STATEMENT FROM SILVER LINE RECORDS:

In response to circulating content taken out of context, Ms. Hart requests privacy as she continues to focus on her work and upcoming commitments.

"Privacy," Nova whispered.

Marcy texted.

Breathe. Let God fight the battles you cannot.

“I’m trying,” Nova said to herself.

Outside, the world scrolled and speculated. Clips multiplied. Edits layered humor over cruelty, truth over noise.

Stillness held, and each of them paid for it differently.

Nova prayed.

Elliot steadied his breath.

Greg worked the problem.

The rain eased. The noise did not.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

"I did not call it ending.

I called it listening."

– Nova Hart, untitled

Elliot stepped outside just after eight, the air still cool from the night rain.

The street looked ordinary again. Damp pavement. A dog barking two houses down. The flag across the way barely stirring.

Whatever storm had passed through had already found somewhere else to land.

He had not planned to go anywhere. He only needed the mail.

On the curb, Mrs. Danner calmly sorted envelopes, accustomed to the unhurried pace of morning mail.

She looked up when she saw him and smiled, calm and unbothered.

"Well," she said. "If it is not my most famous neighbor."

His shoulders eased. "I am sorry about yesterday."

She waved a hand. "Honey, I have been mistaken for worse things than a headline."

He nodded once, then said the thing he had been carrying since he woke up. "I prayed for you."

Mrs. Danner paused, her fingers stilling on the stack of mail. Then she smiled again, softer this time.

"That explains why I slept just fine," she said. "You take care of yourself."

He watched her walk back up her drive, unhurried as ever. The street stayed quiet after she went inside.

By midmorning, the street had changed.

Somewhere between breakfast and her drive across town, the story had caught again.

Clara almost turned the car around twice. Each time she slowed at the exit, a flash went off, and she saw her father's porch on another stranger's phone screen. Reporters lined the street like gulls after a storm: telephoto lenses, umbrellas, a van with a satellite dish wobbling in the breeze. The same white house she had grown up in was now B-roll for gossip.

Her name cut through the air. Clara froze for half a second. She hadn't even turned off the ignition.

"Great," she muttered under her breath. "They have faster research skills than my students."

She pushed past them, jaw tight, shielding her face with one hand. A woman in a denim jacket tried to hand her a business card. Clara did not look at it. The smell of wet asphalt and coffee from a nearby thermos made her stomach turn.

By the time she reached the porch, her pulse was hammering. She knocked harder than she meant to.

Elliot opened the door before she could knock again.

"You should not have to go through that," he said.

"I should not have to, but here we are." She brushed past him and set her bag on the chair. "You have reporters camping in your azaleas, Dad."

"I know," he said quietly. "I told them I would not be giving statements."

"Well, they are making plenty without you."

He poured coffee into two mugs and slid one toward her. "You look tired."

"I am furious." She did not take the mug. "I told my principal I was sick just so I could come here. Now my picture will probably be online, and she will know exactly what I did."

He nodded. "I am sorry."

She stared at him. "You don't even look surprised."

"I have seen storms before," he said. "They pass."

"Not this kind," she snapped. "This one has hashtags."

He met her eyes. "If you are asking whether she was here, yes. She came by that night. We talked for hours, and she fell asleep on the couch. Nothing happened beyond that. She went home after morning."

He hesitated. "I care about her. A lot."

Clara said nothing.

The space between them shifted.

"She is very rich, Dad. The kind of wealth that does not share zip codes with grief. She lives in the public eye. You hide from it. She's in a completely different season of life than you."

The words rushed out now, fierce and unfiltered, everything she had been holding since she saw his name trending beside Nova's.

"And she's twenty-five years younger than you."

Elliot stayed still, hands folded. "I am aware of the math."

"Grace does not change the facts," she said. "Facts matter. You taught me that. Love without wisdom still hurts people. But here's the thing, Dad. You are a good man. People trust you. They sit across from you on their worst days. They tell you things they don't tell anyone else. You can't pretend that doesn't mean something."

"I am not pretending," he said.

"But she can walk away," Clara pressed. "She can disappear into a private jet and a gated house and a PR team. You cannot. You live here. You buy groceries here. When this explodes, it will land on you."

"It is already landing," he said quietly.

"That is my point. It has barely started."

She pulled out a chair and sat because her knees felt unsteady. She wrapped both hands around the seat like she could anchor herself. "How long."

"A few weeks. Less than a month."

"And it is already a national headline."

"That part was not our choice."

She laughed once, sharp and brittle. "Nothing about this is your choice anymore."

She looked up at him then. His face held the same steady grief she knew from other hard days, the look he wore when he carried something heavy and refused to set it down. It made her want to shake him and hug him at the same time.

"You need to end it," she said. "Before it destroys you. Before it takes what's left of Mom in this house."

He was quiet. Then he said, "Your mother is not a set of photos on the walls. Anyone I care about now does not threaten her. She is with the Lord. That is what we have said since the day we said goodbye. Do you still believe it?"

Clara pressed her lips together. "I do."

"Then nothing can take her place. Not anyone. Not ever."

Tears burned, sudden and angry. She wiped them fast with the heel of her hand. "It feels like a replacement. Like a bright new thing rolled in to take the ache away. And it hurts, Dad. It hurts to see them pull you into their machine and call it love."

He looked toward the window where light cut across the floor. "It is not a machine here," he said. "We drank coffee and watched the water. We prayed at my kitchen table. She asked about your mother, and I told her the truth. She was kind. Not careful. Kind."

"She is young," Clara said again.

"She is a grown woman," he said. "And I am a grown man. We have been careful. We did not cross lines. I will not give you details you do not need, but I will tell you this. She brought light back into the room. No noise. Light. It felt like the morning after a long storm."

Clara looked down at her hands. It sounded true, and she hated that it did.

"There is a power problem," she said. "You cannot keep something holy under a spotlight."

"I know," he said. "We tried to keep it private. We failed."

"So end it," she said again, softer now. "Let it be something that almost happened."

"Ending it will protect no one," he said. "It will only teach fear to call itself wisdom."

"You keep saying fear like it is a flaw," she said. "Fear keeps people alive."

"A gift does not come with headlines," she said after a beat.

"Some gifts are heavier than they look."

"Please do not talk like a pastor right now."

"Then hear me as your father," he said. "I love you. I hear your fear. But I will not call what is good evil just to make fear sit down."

She stood. "It is not evil to be cautious."

"I agree."

"Then choose me."

"I choose you," he said. "I also care for Nova. Those loves do not compete."

She walked to the sink and gripped the counter, trying to breathe. The view out the window was the same one she had watched while her mother taught her to sing harmony without chasing the melody. The horizon had not changed. She hated it for having the nerve to be steady.

"Clara," he said, "do you trust that I am listening to the Lord on this."

She said nothing.

"If you cannot trust that yet," he continued, "trust that I am not being careless. Trust that I am still your father, trying to be faithful in a hard thing."

She turned back. "Do you love her."

The words landed heavier this time.

He did not answer right away. He looked at the floor, then the window, then back at her.

"I am learning to," he said. "If the Lord allows it to grow, I will be grateful. If He asks me to let it go, I will."

Everyone will think you saved her, she almost said. Or that she saved you.

"They will make a story no matter what," she said instead.

"They already have."

"And you do not care."

"I care," he said. "I do not obey."

She picked up her bag. "I came because I love you. And because I am scared. You do not have to be a martyr for love."

"I am not trying to be a martyr," he said. "I am trying to be faithful."

"Prayer is not a plan."

"It is where I start."

At the door she stopped. "If Mom were here."

He closed his eyes for a beat. "She would ask about the fruit. Then she would hug you for saying the hard thing to my face."

"That sounds like her."

"It does."

Outside, the light made her squint.

"Are you going to stop seeing her?"

"I am going to keep listening," he said. "If the Lord says stop, I will. If He gives courage to continue, I will continue."

"I am not okay," Clara said, quieter now.

"I know."

She did not trust herself to hug him. She walked to her car, hands shaking, and did not look back until the end of the street. When she did, he stood in the doorway, far enough back that the cameras would not catch him.

He stayed there until her car turned out of sight. The quiet afterward felt like the slow drain at the end of a storm.

Back in the kitchen, he stood where she had stood at the sink.

"Lord, take care of my girl," he said. "Guard her heart. Guard mine. Tell me what to do next and I will do it."

He opened his Bible where the ribbon still marked Psalm 46. He let the words sit in the room without reading.

The kettle clicked off. Steam rose. The house did not feel empty. It felt steady.

He did not call Nova. He did not text her.

But before the afternoon was gone, he sent one message.

I am going to be quiet for a bit.

Not from you. For us. I want to listen well.

I hope you will too.

He set the phone face down on the table and did not wait for an answer. Trust meant letting the silence do its work.

Nova read the message twice.

Relief came first. Then fear. Then something steadier beneath both.

Permission.

Not to run. Not to react.

She turned the phone over and let it go dark.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

*"Some things can only be said in a room
where no one is performing."*

– **Nova Hart, untitled**

Two days had passed in near silence. They had not texted back and forth. Just one plan, set through Marcy. A neutral place. No houses. No neighbors. No stories to steal.

Marcy drove without music. The two lane road stretched between Wilmington and Oceanside, sliding past damp fields and rows of pine. A thin mist drifted across the windshield, blurring the edges of the world ahead. Nova sat curled in the passenger seat with her hands tucked between her knees, twisting the edge of her sleeve. Her stomach tightened and stayed that way. She had tried to sleep but her mind never slowed.

After a mile of silence, Marcy glanced over with a small smile.

"You know, you are different these days. Calmer. More present. I like seeing that."

Nova rubbed her thumb across her palm. "I feel like I'm becoming someone I should have been a long time ago."

Marcy nodded. "Whatever's been shifting in you lately," Marcy said, "it shows."

Nova turned toward the window. "I hate that this touches him at all."

"He sees it too," Marcy said. "That matters."

Nova's eyes stung. "I hope so."

They rode in silence for another minute as the trees thickened along the road.

Marcy slowed as the road curved under the oaks. "By the way, I know a place. It's not on anyone's radar. No phones. No curiosity. My mom made me go to summer Bible camp here. Good people. They know how to keep things quiet."

Nova let out a soft, shaky laugh. "I am glad one of us grew up with southern church connections."

Marcy snorted. "Trust me, I was not a belle. I was the kid climbing out the bathroom window to skip crafts. But I know who to call when a quiet room is needed."

Nova smiled for the first time all morning. "I needed that."

"You are welcome," Marcy said gently. "Every crisis deserves one small laugh before the tears."

They turned down a narrower road under deep branches. A small white church sat at the end, plain and unmoving. The parking lot was empty. The sky hung low and gray.

Nova took a slow breath. "Alright."

Marcy parked and nodded toward the side of the building. "Door is open. Pastor's daughter unlocked it earlier."

Nova stepped out. The air smelled like wet leaves and warm wood. She followed Marcy into a dim hallway lined with hymnals and faint lemon oil.

"I will wait right here," Marcy said. "Go on."

Nova walked into the small prayer room. Two wooden chairs faced each other. A cracked Bible sat on a side table with a child's drawing tucked inside as a bookmark. Colored light from a small stained glass window rested across the floor in soft patches. The room felt like a place where truth did not have to rush.

She sat and clasped her hands, which trembled slightly. "Lord, please meet me here," she whispered.

Footsteps approached. The door opened gently.

Elliot stepped inside.

Her breath caught—not because he was there, but because part of her had hoped he would be.

He looked worn in a way that went deeper than sleep, but his eyes were gentle when they found hers.

"Hi," Nova whispered.

"Hi," he said. "Are you alright?"

"No," she said honestly.

He did not pretend. He gave a small nod. "Neither am I."

Nova stared at him. Elliot had been the one who never rushed her, never flinched when things grew difficult. Hearing him say he was not alright made her chest tighten.

She had never seen him shaken like this, and the thought that she might have helped cause it turned her stomach.

He did not sit. He stepped toward her slowly, as if checking she would not pull back.

Nova stood without thinking. He waited—just long enough. Then she moved into him, and he pulled her into his arms.

The hug lasted a while. It carried fear and relief and love all woven together. Nova pressed her forehead to his shoulder. His hands trembled once at her back. The steady rise and fall of his breathing soothed and broke her at the same time.

Neither spoke.

When they slowly eased apart, the room felt steadier.

They sat down.

Elliot folded his hands. Nova rested hers in her lap, though her fingers still trembled.

After a moment he said, "Clara came this morning."

Nova's eyes widened. "She came to your house."

He nodded. "She walked through the reporters to reach the door."

"She came through that crowd for you. This isn't just about us anymore."

Elliot shook his head. "This noise would have found me either way. You did not create it."

Nova wiped her cheek. "I am scared for you. For your life here. For the quiet you have built."

Elliot let out a slow breath. "I have been asking the Lord what to do next. Clara said things I needed to hear. Honest things. Hard things. None of it changed what is true."

Nova hesitated. "Does she think I am trying to take her mom's place?"

His expression softened. "No. No one could take Sarah's place. Clara's hurt comes from missing her mother, not from judging you."

Nova swallowed. "The world will say it's wrong."

"The world says many things," he replied. "But love is measured by fruit. And you have shown me kindness, truth, and light."

Nova looked down at her hands. "I do not want to lose you."

"You will not," he said softly. "Not unless the Lord sends us down different roads. And if He does, He will make the path clear and kind."

Nova nodded, and a small ache tightened in her chest. She understood what he meant. She believed it even. She just did not want a road that took her away from him.

Her voice wavered slightly. "I think we should pray. I do not know how to hold this on my own. And I do not think you should have to either."

Elliot's shoulders softened. "Yes. I would like that."

They bowed their heads. Their knees brushed.

His voice was low and steady. "Lord, help us hear You. Guard her heart. Guard mine. Give us courage for the truth and patience. Make us faithful in all things."

Nova's tears slipped down her cheeks. She let them fall.

When he finished, they stayed still for several breaths. The silence was warm, not empty.

Nova slowly rose. Elliot stood with her.

"The world does not get to decide what this is," he said. "We do."

She tried to speak but could not. Emotion filled the space between them.

He stepped close, lifted one hand, and cupped the side of her face. His thumb caught a tear she had missed.

Nova leaned into him.

Their foreheads touched.

Not a kiss. Not a goodbye. A steady, trembling meeting of two hearts in a room where God felt near.

Elliot whispered, "I am not walking away from what is good."

"Then we move forward," she said. "Slowly. But forward."

They stepped apart gently.

"I will wait," she said.

"I will listen," he said.

Her voice trembled. "Will I see you again soon?"

"We don't rush what's holy," he said quietly. "But we don't abandon it either."

Nova nodded, though her chest ached. "Alright."

He opened the door. Light spilled in.

Nova stepped into it. Marcy waited down the hall with soft, worried eyes.

Nova turned once more. Elliot stood framed by the colors of the stained glass. He looked like a man holding both hope and sorrow and refusing to set either one down.

She lifted her fingers for a small wave.

He nodded.

Then the door closed.

Outside, sunlight touched the wet pavement. Marcy unlocked the car.

"You alright?" she asked.

"No," Nova said. "But I am held."

Marcy nodded once. "That's enough for today."

They pulled back onto the road. The pines blurred past, darker now under the low sky. Nova rested her head against the window, the imprint of stained glass still warm behind her eyes.

"Do you want to talk," Marcy asked, "or sit with it?"

"Talk," Nova said. "If I sit too long, I spiral."

Marcy glanced over. "Then talk."

Nova pressed her palm to her chest. "I feel exposed. But not unsure."

"That's what truth does," Marcy said. "It costs something."

Nova turned her phone over in her hands. The screen lit up with missed calls and a flood of notifications.

"Anything urgent?" Marcy asked.

"Greg. Twice."

Marcy's mouth tightened. "He wants control."

"He isn't wrong that this is a mess."

"No," Marcy said. "But mess isn't the same as mistake."

Nova looked back out at the trees. "His world is quiet. Mine isn't."
"Then meet in the middle," Marcy said. "Quiet doesn't mean hiding. Loud doesn't mean reckless."

Nova let the phone go dark again.

"I don't know what happens next," she said.

"Good," Marcy replied. "That means you're not pretending."

Nova nodded slowly. "One step at a time."

"That's all we get."

The car rolled on through the narrowing road.

They would not see each other for a while.

But distance is not the same thing as doubt.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

I wish this feeling would stay with me a little longer.

Maybe then I could stand just a little stronger.

- Nova Hart, from “Morning, Stay With Me”

Unreleased

Nova stepped into the hotel room and let the door close behind her. The drive back from the church had been quiet. Now the quiet had a different weight — like a reminder that the world she had tried to escape was still waiting.

The room smelled of linen spray and stale air. A small gap in the mostly closed curtains let sunlight streak the carpet. Filled with the air conditioner’s hum, the hush was steady and impersonal.

She stood still for a moment, letting her eyes adjust. Her body felt heavy, as if she had been holding her breath for hours. Maybe she had. The peace she found in Elliot’s kitchen and in the prayer room still clung to her, but now it felt fragile, as if the wrong step would break it.

Her backpack slid off her shoulder and dropped beside the bed. She sat on the edge of the mattress and folded her hands in her lap. Her fingers trembled. She curled them into her palms.

She had slipped out before dawn. She had not told Reid or Greg. She had not even taken her phone.

She kept rubbing her palms against her jeans, as if trying to warm them.

Marcy didn't ask questions. She just said, "Let's go," and drove.

Now the sun was up. Everything she had meant to do had missed its moment.

Her eyes drifted to the nightstand. Her phone sat exactly where she had left it. The screen was dark. Silent. Waiting.

She looked away.

She did not want to pick it up yet. Instead, she rose and crossed to the small desk by the window. She needed to pour out the ache inside her before she faced anyone else.

Nova pulled her journal from her backpack and opened it to a blank page. Her pen hovered for a long moment before the words finally pushed through.

I wish this feeling would stay with me a little longer.

Maybe then I could stand just a little stronger.

My space keeps falling under constant attack.

I cannot take the weight that settles on my back.

The words blurred as tears filled her eyes. One fell and darkened the page.

"God," she whispered, "I do not know what to do with all of this."

She wrote again, slower this time, like her heart was speaking one small truth at a time.

You were there in the kitchen when I could breathe.

You were there on the porch when I could not stop shaking.

If You did not leave me there,

Please do not leave me here.

Alone.

Her shoulders shook. She pressed her hand over her mouth. The tears came freely, neither hurried nor concealed. This room did not ask her to hold herself together.

When the wave passed, she rested her forehead against the edge of the desk. She let the silence wash over her for a brief time. Her breathing softened. Her heartbeat slowed.

When she lifted her head, her gaze drifted again to the nightstand.

Her phone still sat there.

She rose slowly, as if moving through water, and crossed the room. When she picked the phone up, her fingers shook. Missed alerts filled the screen as it lit up, each row a time stamp from the hours she was gone.

Missed Call — REID, 6:18 AM

A series of missed texts from Greg

Nova, please answer your phone.

You left the hotel alone.

I cannot manage this if you disappear on me.

Please. Just one text so I know you are breathing.

Missed Call — REID, 6:38 AM

And 2 alerts from the front desk:

Departure alert sent [5:54AM]

Re-entry logged [7:42AM]

Reid finally just texted.

The front desk told me you are back in the building.

When you feel able, please call.

Greg's messages kept coming, one after another, each line making it harder to breathe.

This wasn't just happening around her. It was happening because of her.

She set the phone down hard and pressed her palm against it.

Her heartbeat thudded in her ears. Every message landed heavy, sinking low.

Everyone else was paying for it now—lost sleep, frantic calls, explanations already forming without her.

She turned the screen dark.

"I just needed air," she whispered.

Her voice shook on the last word.

She lowered her hands and stared at her journal. The ink glistened in a few places where tears had fallen. The lines looked honest. Raw. Like something she had not planned, but needed.

Her gaze drifted to the guitar case leaning against the wall. She stood, crossed the room, and opened the lid. The guitar felt solid and familiar in her hands. She carried it back to the desk and sat down.

She strummed a soft chord. The sound filled the room and wrapped around her like warmth.

The melody that had circled her all morning finally settled into place and she sang.

I wish this feeling would stay with me a little longer.

Her voice thinned but did not break.

She shifted chords and let the next line come only halfway before it dissolved into breath.

If You did not leave me there...

The words lingered, unfinished.

She bowed her head over the guitar.

“Is this what You want from me?” she whispered. “Just honesty?”

Silence answered, but it did not feel empty.

She wrote the chord shapes in the margin of her journal and added a small note beneath them.

For You and for me. Not for the world.

Her phone buzzed once. A new message preview slid across the top. It was Reid.

When you have a moment, please call. No rush. Just touching base.

Nova let out a slow breath. Reid's messages were calm, not emotional. Professional, but not cold.

She set the phone down and crossed to the window. She pulled the curtains open an inch.

Cars moved in and out of the lot. A man carried a box of pastries. Two girls leaned against a car, laughing over something on a phone.

Nova watched them longer than she meant to. No cameras. No commentary. No headlines. Just girls laughing at something small and unimportant.

For a second she wanted that kind of life, the kind where joy did not need permission.

The girls laughed again, shoulders touching. Nova let the curtain fall.

She thought of Elliot's kitchen. The morning light on the table. The gentle way he had prayed for her, with hands folded, voice soft. The steadiness in his eyes that made her feel safe in a way she had not felt in a long time.

"This is why it hurts," she murmured, "because it was real."

She returned to the bed and sat with her guitar beside her. Her fingers traced the wood, grounding her.

She closed her eyes for a moment.

No words came this time.

She let the quiet sit where the prayer usually would.

Her stomach rumbled.

She set the guitar on the bed and walked to the small coffee station. She made a cup of tea and let the steam warm her face. She stood there longer than necessary, breathing it in.

Then she went to the bathroom and washed her face, rinsing away dried tears. When she looked up at her reflection, she did not look away.

Back in bed, she took a slow sip of tea, then reached for her phone and tapped Reid's name.

The call rang twice.

"Nova?" Reid answered. His voice was steady, worn thin at the edges. "Are you safe?"

"I am back at the hotel," she said. "I am safe. I am sorry I worried everyone."

"Thank you for letting me know," Reid replied. "We can talk through the details later. Right now, the important thing is that you rest."

"I should not have left without telling anyone."

"It made the morning complicated," he said. "There are people asking questions I can't answer without you. Next time, just answer your phone or leave a note. It will help all of us keep you protected."

A small, tired laugh escaped her.

"I understand."

"Eat something," Reid added. "Get some rest. Call me when you are ready to go over the schedule. We can't afford surprises right now."

"I will," she whispered.

"Talk to you soon," he said, then ended the call.

Nova set the phone back on the nightstand. She lay down with her guitar beside her and her journal still open on the desk. The room held steady around her.

Sleep pulled at her gently. Nova did not fight it. The hum of the air conditioner filled the room, and her unfinished verse lingered in the stillness.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

Not calm. Not peaceful.
Steady enough to stand in.
- Nova Hart, untitled

Nova woke to a soft ache behind her eyes, the residue of too little sleep. She stayed still, knowing that once she moved, everything would start asking things of her.

The curtains were closed, but a narrow slice of late morning light slipped through the center seam, brushing against the carpet. The room was still enough to hear the faint hum of the air conditioner.

She blinked up at the ceiling, trying to gather her thoughts. She must have drifted off soon after coming back. The sleep had not been deep or peaceful, only enough to take the sharpest edge off her weariness.

Her body felt heavy, as if something inside her had not fully set back into place.

Her journal sat on the desk, the ink of her new verse dried into soft strokes. For a moment she allowed herself to look at it, remembering

the softness of Elliot's kitchen, the warm light across the table, the steadiness of the prayer room. The peace had been real. Almost sacred.

She tried to hold on to the feeling, but it slipped away. Hotel rooms never kept peace. Silence here felt borrowed.

Her stomach tightened, not from fear, but from knowing she couldn't stay here much longer.

Maybe she should check her phone.

Nova hesitated before reaching for it on the nightstand. A knot formed in her chest as she flipped it over. Missed calls. Messages stacked like a wall.

She knew what waited on the other side of the glass. Not yet.

She lowered the phone to the bed.

The room had the faint smell of stale coffee from the cup Marcy left on the desk earlier. Nova pushed herself up, feet touching the cool carpet, and walked to the bathroom sink. She splashed water on her face, letting it run over her hands, listening to the soft patter against the porcelain. She looked up at the mirror. Her reflection looked tired, not just from sleep, but from everything building inside her.

"Help me hold on," she murmured, the words slipping out without much thought.

Her voice barely carried.

She turned off the water and grabbed a towel. Before she could dry her hands, a firm knock hit the door.

Nova froze.

Another knock. Firmer this time.

Her heart quickened.

"Nova."

Greg's voice. Controlled, fraying at the edges.

She closed her eyes for one breath, then walked to the door. Her hand paused on the handle. She took a slow breath, the kind she had learned to take when life pressed in too close.

She opened the door.

Greg stood there with a coffee in one hand, his tablet tucked under his arm. His shirt was wrinkled, and he looked like he had run his fingers through his hair more than a few times. His expression carried exhaustion, worry, and something else she could not quite name.

"Hey," he said. "Can we talk?"

Nova stepped aside. Greg walked in and set the coffee down on the small table. He did not sit. He paced once, then turned back to her.

"You scared me," he said.

The words were soft, vulnerable. Nova went still.

"You left the hotel before dawn. No phone. No message. No contact. When the front desk alert came through, we thought something had happened."

Nova looked down at her hands. "I should have told someone."

"Yes," Greg said. "You should have."

"I told Marcy," Nova said quickly. "She came with me."

Greg exhaled, tired but controlled. "Marcy was trying to help you. I am not upset with her. I just need the team to communicate. If we know what is happening, we can protect you better."

Nova nodded. The guilt settled heavier.

Greg picked up his tablet and turned the screen toward her.

"I wish I could tell you things calmed down overnight," he said. "They did not. That neighbor yelling 'This is not a circus' is everywhere. People are looping it, remixing it, breaking it down frame by frame."

Her stomach clenched.

"They think the older man theory makes sense," he continued. "They are using every angle to prove it. When you do not say anything, the internet fills in the blanks."

Nova pressed a hand to her lips.

"The label called me twice this morning," Greg said. "Brand partners want reassurance. They want to know you are stable. That this is not the start of some meltdown."

"I am not spiraling," Nova said, her voice tight.

"I know," Greg said. "But they want proof of that."

She swallowed. "I just did not have it in me to speak yesterday."

Greg nodded slowly. "I understand that. More than you know."

He paused, then his voice firmed.

"But disappearing without a trace cannot happen again. Not now. Not when eyes are already looking for reasons to stir things up."

Nova lifted her eyes.

"Silence is gasoline," Greg said. "I cannot protect you if I am guessing. I need you with me."

She nodded. "I will."

"That is all I am asking," he said.

The silence between them was thick, but not sharp.

Greg sat down at last, rubbing his forehead. "The good news is this morning did not add to the problem. Nobody saw you leave. Nobody followed you. You did not make it worse."

Her shoulders dropped before she could stop them.

"You look exhausted," he said.

"I am."

"I am doing everything I can to keep things steady," Greg said. "You deserve peace. You do not have to hold all of this alone. Let us help you carry it."

He stood and picked up his coffee, hesitating before he reached the door.

"Whatever peace you found this morning," he said softly, "hold on to it. You are going to need it."

Nova nodded, her throat too tight to answer.

Greg gave her one last tired, kind smile, then stepped out and let the door close behind him.

The room felt heavier now. Different. More aware.

A softer knock sounded.

"Nova?" Marcy's voice. Gentle. "Can I come in?"

Nova opened the door. Marcy stood there with two granola bars, a bottle of water, and a warm muffin wrapped in a paper napkin.

"Are you alright?" Marcy whispered.

Nova nodded, though tears gathered again.

Marcy slipped inside and sat beside her on the bed. "Eat something."

Nova opened the muffin and took a small bite. Cinnamon and warmth settled in a way she hadn't expected.

A small, tired smile touched her mouth. "You are so good to me."

Marcy's expression softened. "I care about you. That's all."

Marcy leaned her shoulder against Nova's. "Greg's a lot right now, but he loves you like family. So do I."

A tear slid down Nova's cheek. "Thank you."

They sat together until Nova finished most of the muffin. Marcy stayed until Nova's breathing steadied again.

After she left, the room fell silent. Nova crossed to her journal and opened to the page from the morning. Her lyric waited there, fragile and honest.

She traced the first line with her fingertip.

I wish this feeling would stay with me a little longer.

Her throat thickened.

She closed her eyes and whispered, "Lord ... please steady me."

The room settled around her again. Not calm. Not peaceful.

But steady enough to stand in.

For now.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

*I did not text him.
That was its own kind of love.*

- Nova Hart, untitled

Nova sat at the small table by the window and picked at the edge of the muffin wrapper.

The room felt different now. Less like a hiding place. More like a waiting room.

She stayed still, listening for what would come next.

Outside, the sounds of Wilmington drifted up through the glass, car horns blurring in the distance, a siren threading faintly through it, the low hum of the hotel's air system pressing beneath it all. It was the same noise as always, but every sound felt sharper.

She took another small bite of the muffin Marcy had left earlier. It was not as warm as before, but the cinnamon still tasted mild and comforting. She focused on that. One good thing. A small piece of comfort that did not belong to the internet.

She swallowed and let her shoulders drop.

Elliot's table came back to her.

The warm light. Steam rising from his mug. The quiet steadiness settled into the corners of the house, as if it belonged there.

It did not stay as easily as she wanted.

The phone sat on the table. The screen was black. It might as well have been a stone. Heavy. Waiting.

She sipped the bottle of water Marcy had left. Her throat still felt dry.

“You have to look at it at some point,” she whispered.

The sound of her own voice startled her. She hadn’t uttered a word lately. Not since Marcy left to “walk the hallway,” as she called it. That meant checking on people. Checking on staff. Make sure no one who did not belong on this floor found a way here.

Nova picked up the phone. It felt cold in her hand.

She did not open her messages. Not yet. The wall of notifications could wait.

She tapped a single app instead. The one she knew would tell her what she needed to know. Not everything. Just enough.

Her social feed lit up in a rush of color and motion.

The first image wasn’t her own face.

Elliot’s neighborhood video filled the screen, an older woman caught in a zoomed clip, her mouth moving in a loop as someone slowed the audio.

“This is not a circus. This is not a circus. This is not a circus.”

The clip had captions layered over it in bright letters. Edits. Emojis. Dramatic sound effects. People turned it into something meant to be funny and something meant to be frightening all at once.

Nova's chest tightened.

She scrolled a little farther. People had clipped the video into dance trends. Reaction memes. Conspiracy threads. Some comments made light of it. Some were harsh. Some spoke as if they knew every detail of her heart.

They did not.

"She is hiding something."

"She looks guilty."

"She is a mess."

"She is protecting him."

Her thumb hovered over the screen.

She saw the familiar tag at the top of the feed.

#WhoIs522

And under it, the other one.

#ThisIsNotACircus

She could not read more. She tapped the screen and closed the app.

The sudden blankness felt almost as loud as the noise had.

Her heart was beating against her ribs, steady but hard. She placed the phone back on the table and wrapped both hands around her water bottle.

"Okay," she murmured. "You knew it would still be there."

She drew in a breath and let it out slow. She thought of the verse she had whispered that morning at Elliot's sink. The one about God being her refuge. Her strength. A present help when things felt like trouble.

He did not stop trouble. He sat in it with her.

She wanted the truth to be enough. She prayed it would hold.

The phone buzzed.

Nova flinched. For a second she thought about letting it ring out. If she did not pick up, the day could not move forward. It would stay right here, in this quiet, where nothing new could hurt.

The buzzing stopped. Then it began again.

She checked the screen.

Greg.

She stared at his name for a count of three, then slid her thumb across to answer.

"Hey," she murmured.

"You sound tired," Greg said. His voice was gentler than it had been that morning. "Do you have a minute?"

"Yeah," she said. "I do."

He blew out a breath. She could almost see him rubbing his forehead. "Okay. I will keep it simple. No hard talks. Just an update."

She braced herself anyway. "All right."

"The clip is still out there," Greg said. "The neighbor one. People are still cutting it into things. It is everywhere, but not in a way that has set off alarms. Loud, but not catastrophic. Not yet."

Nova pressed the heel of her hand against her thigh. "I saw some of it."

"Okay," Greg said. "Then you know the general tone. It is loud. It is messy. It is what we expected."

"Is it worse?" she asked.

There was a pause.

"Worse is the wrong word," he said. "It is more of the same. Same theories. Same idea that you were with some mysterious older man. Same strangers acting like they have you figured out from five seconds of grainy footage. But nothing new got added today. No fresh photos. No new angles. No one is closer than they were this morning."

She nodded once. "Okay."

"The label is watching," Greg went on. "They called me again. They are trying to make sure you are alright. They feel nervous. However, they aren't panicking. Yet. They are not calling for statements or damage control yet."

"That is something," Nova said.

"It is," he said. "I told them you were exhausted and resting. That you needed a day to breathe. Which is true. Which is allowed. You are not a machine."

Her eyes burned. "Thank you."

"I meant what I said earlier," Greg told her. "I am doing my very best to keep the fire from getting any hotter. Right now we are watching the same flames move around the same room."

She knew he meant Elliot's world. The beautiful house. The gentle life that had wrapped around her like a blanket.

"Has anyone tried?" she asked. "Has anyone gone out there?"

"To where you were this morning?" Greg asked.

"Yes."

"They've found the house," Greg said, "but they haven't figured out who he is yet. They're circling the footage, looping the neighbor clip, hoping it leads somewhere real. So far, it hasn't."

Nova hesitated. "The house is not even under his name," she mumbled. "It is owned by his company, Harbor Light Cybersecurity, I think. That is the only reason no one has connected the dots yet. But it feels like a matter of time."

"You're probably right, but not yet," Greg said. "Not today."

Nova felt some of the tension in her shoulders ease. "Okay."

Greg paused. "Listen to me. This didn't get worse because of you."

She closed her eyes. "I don't know how to tell where the damage actually is."

"You don't have to," he said. "That's my job."

She pressed her fingers to her eyes. "I'll try."

"Good," Greg said. "Rest. Eat something real. Let Marcy hover. She lives for that."

A small laugh slipped out of her. "She does."

"I will call again later if something changes," he said. "If it does not, I will let you breathe."

She hesitated. "Greg?"

"Yeah?"

"Thank you for telling them I needed space," she said. "And not just... making me perform my way out of this."

He was quiet for a moment. When he spoke again, his voice carried a tired kind of warmth.

"You are more than your posts," he said. "More than their noise too. Do not forget it."

He hung up before she could answer.

She stared at the phone until it felt like it might stare back.

She stretched out on the bed and turned her face toward the ceiling. The light that slipped through the curtains had shifted. It was softer now. Afternoon light, lazy and slow.

She thought of Elliot again. The way he had watched her breath in that private kitchen. Not like she was fragile. Like she was important. Like she was someone worth steadying.

She closed her eyes and pictured his hands wrapped around his mug. The way he had prayed under his breath. Not loud. Not for show. Real.

There was a pull inside her to reach for her phone again. To open their thread. To type something simple. She opened their thread. His last message waited there, and her reply beneath it.

Are you okay?

I'm ok. I miss the quiet.

The words formed themselves in her mind before she stopped them.

If she texted him, she would pull him back into the shape of this day. Not the morning. This day. The one where strangers turned a neighbor's frustration into a chant.

She imagined a reporter scrolling through his contacts. A fan hacking a cloud account. A headline built from one private message taken out of context. A single line chained to a story she never meant to tell.

Her fingers curled into the blanket.

"I cannot drag you into this," she whispered. "Not yet." The words stung as soon as they left her mouth, like she had spoken something she was not ready to face.

She rolled onto her side and pulled the pillow closer. For a moment, she let herself feel it instead of pushing it down.

The ache settled deep and would not move. Loving something gentle in a world that was not gentle at all.

She breathed in slowly. Once. Twice. Three times.

When the tears came, they slipped out fast, warm and unsteady, impossible to hold back.

"Lord," she whispered, "please keep him hidden. Keep him safe. Keep his little house covered. I don't care what they say about me. Just ... not him."

The prayer sat in the air for a moment. Simple. Raw. It fixed nothing, but it felt like placing a heavy stone in someone else's hands.

There was a soft knock at the door.

"Nova?" Marcy's voice floated through. "It is just me again."

Nova wiped her face with the corner of the pillowcase. "Come in."

The door opened. Marcy stepped inside with a single cup of tea. Nothing else. She did not comment on Nova's puffy eyes. She did not fuss. She just sat down and folded her hands in her lap.

"You are hovering," Nova said, her voice low.

Marcy closed the door with her hip. "I am," she said. "You can file a complaint."

"How is the outside world?" she asked.

"Noisy," Nova said. "Same clip. Same noise. Greg says nothing new has leaked. Yet."

Marcy nodded. "That tracks with what I am seeing."

"Are they outside?" Nova asked. "Here?"

"A couple of photographers are in the lobby," Marcy said. "They are pretending to be interested in the decor. They are not very good at it. Security is keeping them away from the elevators. No one is getting to this floor without a key card."

Nova nodded. "Thank you for sitting in the hallway."

Marcy shrugged one shoulder. "It gave me an excuse to tell a reporter that if he scared you, I poured his coffee on his shoes. It was very healing for me."

A small smile tugged at Nova's mouth. "I wish I'd had seen that."

"I am glad you didn't," Marcy said. "You needed to rest."

She reached over and nudged the cup closer. "Drink some tea. It will not fix your life, but it is hot, and it does not come with a comment section."

Nova laughed once. It came out strained but real. "That might be my new requirement for everything."

They sat together while Nova took small sips. The tea was mild and sweet. It warmed the back of her throat. Marcy did not fill the air with chatter. She told one short story about a housekeeper who had tried to bring fresh towels and seen Marcy sitting in the hall like a guard dog.

"I think she is telling her friends there is a security risk on this floor," Marcy said. "She is not wrong."

Nova smiled. "You are very scary with granola bars."

"I do my best," Marcy replied.

Silence settled again. This time it felt a little less sharp. Not comfortable, but not cutting.

"Do you think I was wrong to go there?" Nova asked quietly.

Marcy looked over at her. "To the house?"

"Yes."

Marcy took a breath. "No," she said. "I think you were a tired human who needed a safe kitchen and some honest air. I think you found it for a few hours. I refuse to call that wrong."

"People didn't just come for me," Nova said.

"The internet was going to find something to chew on either way," Marcy answered. "You are allowed one morning of peace in the middle of that. The world does not get to decide that was a mistake."

Nova swallowed. "I feel like I am the one putting him in danger."

"You are not the only person in this story," Marcy said. "The neighbor chose to film. The internet chose to twist. We chose to stay mostly quiet. Everyone is adding their piece."

She leaned forward slightly. "I know you want to protect him. I am glad you do."

Marcy continued. "Just remember that protecting someone does not mean erasing every good thing you shared."

The words settled over Nova slowly. She did not know what to do with them yet, but she knew they were true.

"Thank you," she whispered.

Marcy patted her knee once, then stood. "I am going to go resume my life as hallway dragon," she said. "Text me if you need anything. Or just open the door and wave. I am not fast, but I am determined."

"I know," Nova said. "That helps."

When the door clicked shut and she was alone again, her phone buzzed on the table.

Nova looked at it. For a moment she considered ignoring it, but something in her gut told her to check.

A text from Greg.

When you feel up to it, call me. Nothing urgent.

Just something small that crossed my desk.

Something small could mean nothing. Or it could be the beginning of a conversation she was not ready to have. Something that might shift the day in a direction she was not ready to face.

She set the phone down without answering.

"Not yet," she whispered. The words felt heavier this time, almost like a line she was drawing with her own hand.

She crossed the room and opened her journal instead. The morning's verse waited for her on the page.

I wish this feeling would stay with me a little longer ...

She traced the line with her fingertip. It steadied her more than the room did.

She closed her eyes.

The words hovered at the edge of her mouth and then dissolved.

Instead, she straightened her shoulders.

When she opened her eyes again, she did not look away.

For now, it was enough.

Barely. But enough.

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

The quiet I trusted most was always the kind just before everything changed.

– Nova Hart, untitled

The morning light over Oceanside crept in soft and pale, brushing a thin line across the kitchen tiles. Elliot stood at the counter with a mug of coffee cooling between his hands, brewed and poured but left untouched.

The house was calm. It had always been his refuge. Today, it felt like it was holding its breath.

He opened his Bible to the same passage he had read every morning for years. The words didn't hold. He tried again and let the passage sit without forcing it.

He let out a slow breath and whispered, "Lord, show me what to do."

His phone buzzed on the table. Then buzzed again. He did not reach for it. The screen showed links and messages, as people asked if

he was okay, tried to defend him, and wanted answers he could not give.

He rubbed at the ache behind his eyes. He had walked through hard seasons before. Grief. Illness. But this felt different. This storm reached beyond his own life, into places he had never meant to expose.

A car eased into the driveway. Slow. Familiar.

Elliot glanced out the window and saw Pastor Lyle's sedan come to a stop beneath the trees.

He set the mug down and opened the door before the knock.

"Morning," Elliot said.

"Morning," the pastor replied, offering a tired smile. "You have room for company?"

"Always," Elliot said. "Coffee is fresh. I just have not had the courage to drink it."

"We will face it together," the pastor laughed.

They sat at the small table by the window. The quiet between them carried the weight of many years and many prayers.

Pastor Lyle studied Elliot's face. "You look worn," he said gently. "More than usual."

"It has been a lot," Elliot admitted. The words sounded thin even to him.

"I know you have tried to walk through this with grace," the pastor said. "But grace does not mean you carry it alone."

Elliot nodded, his gaze fixed on the table.

"There is something you need to understand," the pastor continued. "Not to blame you. Just so you can see what is happening around you."

Elliot's chest tightened. "Alright."

"The video of Mrs. Danner on your porch spread faster than anyone expected," the pastor said. "The internet turned it into a joke within hours. Loops. Captions. Remixes."

Elliot closed his eyes. "She was trying to protect this house."

"I know," the pastor said. "And the people here saw it that way too. They respected her for it. Her family experienced overwhelming emotions. Strangers are messaging them. Asking questions. Tagging them in things they never asked to see."

Elliot's jaw tightened. "I never wanted her pulled into this."

"No one believes you did," the pastor said.

He paused, then added, "But, son, it really is a circus-and the people who love you are standing right in the middle of the ring."

The words landed heavily and unmistakably.

Elliot swallowed. His hands curled against the table.

"The diner has been dealing with reporters stopping in," the pastor went on. "The regulars go quiet when it happens. Not because they blame you. Because they do not want trouble to follow them home. People care about you. That is why this is hard."

Elliot pressed his thumb into the wood until it stung. "I never asked for this attention."

"I know," the pastor said softly.

"I did not want this for her," Elliot said. "Or for anyone here."

"I know that too."

Silence settled between them, deeper now.

The pastor spoke again, slower. "I need to ask you something. And I want you to answer honestly. Is this becoming too heavy for you to carry alone?"

Elliot tried to speak, but his throat tightened. When the words finally came, they trembled.

"I do not know how to protect her," he said. "I do not know how to protect anyone caught in this. She did nothing wrong. But she is the one being torn apart. And now people here are feeling it too. All because of one picture."

He stared at his hands. "I know what public pressure does to people. I cannot ask someone I care about to stand in that kind of fire with me."

The pastor's eyes softened. "You care for her."

Elliot nodded once. "More than I meant to."

"Then pray for clarity," the pastor said. "Not for escape. Clarity will tell you what love requires. Fear will only tell you how to run."

Elliot nodded, though his chest still ached.

They stood together at the door when it was time for the pastor to leave. Pastor Lyle rested a hand on Elliot's shoulder.

"God is not surprised by this," he said. "He sees her. He sees you. He sees this town. Ask Him how to walk through it, one step at a time."

"I will try," Elliot said.

"That is all any of us can do," the pastor replied.

When the car disappeared down the drive, the house fell still again. The hush felt heavier now, as if it carried every word they had spoken.

Elliot tried to move through the rest of the day as if it were any other. He answered emails from clients. Returned calls from people who needed help with accounts or software issues. Sent updates to his small team and reviewed a security report waiting in his inbox. At any other time, these tasks would have grounded him.

Today each one took more out of him than it gave back. Every conversation left a faint hollow behind, a reminder of how stretched thin his spirit felt.

By midafternoon, he sat at his desk with his elbows on the wood and his hands pressed over his eyes. He had built a career on iden-

tifying threats early and responding without panic. He had steadied companies when everything felt exposed. Yet now, his own heart felt divided.

Half of it sat in this house, with these people, in this town.

The other half was with a woman in motion. A woman who had stepped into his life like a song and pulled light into all his quiet corners. A woman he could not stop thinking about, no matter how he tried to steady himself.

He reached for his Bible again and let it fall open. His eyes landed on a verse he had underlined long ago.

Carry one another's burdens, and so fulfill the law of Christ.

He stared at the words. He had taught them, prayed for them, tried to live for them. Right now they felt like a question he could not answer.

He wanted to carry her burden. He wanted to lift every weight off her shoulders. To stand between her and the things that clawed at her peace.

But another truth pressed into his mind, clear and cold.

What if I am adding weight without meaning to?

The thought cut through him. Fame had already wrapped around her life like a net. His presence had not loosened it. It had made the knots tighter.

He folded his arms on the desk and rested his forehead against them. 'Lord,' he whispered softly, 'help me love her in a way that does no harm. Help me love her without panic. Help me not make fear sound like wisdom.'

The house held the prayer. Outside, the wind moved through the trees, soft and steady, as if the world did not know his heart was tearing in two.

By the time the prayer loosened its grip, miles already lay between them.

The trip from Wilmington to Philadelphia was short.

Nova noticed immediately that Philadelphia moved at a different speed. Cars constantly hummed past the hotel below Nova's window. People talked and laughed on the sidewalks, their voices rising and falling in waves. Inside her room, the noise was only a faint murmur. It made her feel like she was watching life from very far away.

Her boutique room was pretty in a way that made her ache. Warm light. A soft rug. A small sofa pushed under the window with pillows arranged neatly, like the room expected someone calmer than she was to sit there and enjoy the view. It felt like a set. A place where someone like her stayed for a night and then disappeared.

Nova sat tucked into the corner of the sofa with her knees pulled up and Elliot's sweatshirt bunched in her lap. She had grabbed it when she left Oceanside without even thinking, stuffing it into her bag between outfits and notebooks.

Now it was the only thing in the room that felt like it belonged to her real life.

Her phone lay on the cushion beside her. She had opened a message to Elliot more than once. Each time, the words had felt too small or too much. She would type, then backspace until the screen was blank again.

She woke the phone and stared at his name at the top of her messages.

Her thumb hovered. She typed, Are you okay?, stared at it, then erased it. She typed, I miss you, and erased that too. Everything she thought of sounded either needy or fake. She did not want to sound like either.

A notification banner slid across the top of the screen before she could try again.

Clip of pop star leaving Oceanside man's home resurfaces with new edits. #WhoIs522 climbs again.

Her chest tightened. She locked the phone without opening the link. She knew better than to look. Every time she thought the storm might slow, someone found a new way to spin it. Every angle sharpened the story she was trying so hard not to make worse.

There was a soft knock on the adjoining wall.

"You good?" Marcy's voice floated through, a little weary, a little kind.

Nova cleared her throat. "Yeah. Just resting."

"Rehearsal block is still on for four," Marcy called. "Greg is waiting on security updates. Keep your phone close."

"Okay," Nova said.

"Text me if you need anything."

"Will do."

Footsteps moved away. The room settled again.

Nova tightened her grip on the sweatshirt and pressed her face into the fabric for a second. It still smelled like him. Soap and cedar and the sea.

There were many people in her world. A crew. A manager. A label. Fans. Commenters. Voices that rose and fell in swells around her every day.

There was only one person who made her feel like she could breathe. One person who felt steady in a life built on noise.

Her phone buzzed against her leg.

Elliot. Calling.

Her heart jumped. She grabbed it so fast it nearly slipped from her hand.

“Hi,” she said. Her voice came out softer than she meant.

There was a brief pause on the other end, just long enough to tighten something in her chest.

“Hi,” he answered. He sounded warm. He also sounded tired in a way that felt stretched thin.

“You’re home,” she said. “Back in Oceanside.”

“I am.”

“How is it?” she asked, trying to keep her tone light. “The house. The street.”

“It’s calm today,” he said. “At least on the outside.”

Something in the way he said it made her throat tighten.

“I miss it there,” she said. “I miss... the quiet.”

He didn’t answer right away.

“How are you holding up?” he asked instead.

She let out a breath she hadn’t realized she’d been holding. “I’m trying,” she said. “They moved the schedule again. More meetings. More calls. Everyone keeps saying they’re protecting me, but it feels like I’m being moved around. Like a piece on a board.”

“I’m sorry,” he said. The ache in his voice made her chest hurt.

“Are you okay?” she asked quickly. “Not polite okay. Really okay?”

“I’m trying to be,” he said.

Fear slid under her ribs. That wasn’t his usual answer.

“What happened?” she asked. “Please tell me.”

He drew in a breath. “I talked with Pastor Lyle this morning. About everything. About the town. About you.”

Her fingers tightened around the phone.

Elliot was quiet for a moment. "It's heavier than I expected."

"I'm so sorry," Nova whispered. "I never meant for any of that—"

"No," he said quickly. "You didn't do this. You didn't ask for it. You're not the problem."

"Then why does it feel like everything around us is cracking?" she asked.

He was quiet for a beat. "Because the world is loud," he said. "And loud things don't know how to treat what's gentle."

Her eyes burned.

"Elliot," she said softly, the fear slipping through now, bare and unguarded. "Are we okay?"

The question hung between them, fragile but real.

"I don't want to be a complication in your life," he said. "Not because I don't care. Because I care more than I meant to."

Her breath caught.

"I care enough that I don't want fear making choices for us," he went on. "Or for the people around me. That matters to me. You matter to me."

"Then don't pull away," she said. "Please."

"I'm not," he said quietly. "I just need to be careful not to mistake panic for wisdom."

She closed her eyes.

"I'm not ending this," he said. "And I'm not asking you to give anything up for me. I just need one night to pray and listen before I decide what the next step should be."

Her chest rose and fell. "And tomorrow?"

"I'll call you tomorrow," he said. "And I'm not disappearing. If you text, I'll answer. I just need to think before I speak."

Tomorrow still felt heavy, but it no longer felt hollow.

"I know," she said quietly.

There was a pause.

"I wish I had more to give you tonight."

"You already did," she said.

"Goodnight, Nova."

She closed her eyes at the sound of her name. "Goodnight."

The call ended.

Nova stared at her reflection in the dark glass. Her eyes were wet. Her shoulders were tense. She did not look like a pop star. She looked like someone trying not to let fear write the story.

She sank back onto the sofa and pulled his sweatshirt over her head. It swallowed her, soft and familiar. She curled into the corner of the cushions and let the tears come, quieter now, less sharp.

Across the coast, Elliot sat on the edge of his bed with his head bowed, his hands clasped together.

"Lord," he whispered, steady but worn, "help me love her without panic. Show me the next step."

Two different rooms.

Two different cities.

One woman holding a sweatshirt.

One man holding a prayer.

Elliot's phone buzzed on the nightstand.

He didn't reach for it at first. The prayer still hung in the room, and for a moment he let himself believe that quiet could stretch a little longer.

The phone buzzed again.

He opened his eyes and looked.

A notification from a site he didn't recognize.

Harbor Light Cybersecurity CEO Linked to Pop Star "522" Mystery

His breath went still.

He tapped the screen.

A screenshot of his company's website.

A cropped image of his front porch.

A map pin near Oceanside City.

And beneath it, the sentence that turned his life into a headline:

"His name is Elliot Brooks."

The room did not change.

The walls did not shake.

But the quiet was gone.

Elliot set the phone down carefully, as if the weight of it might crack the wood.

He closed his eyes once more.

"Alright," he whispered.

If they were going to say his name, he would not let them say it like he was something to hide.

Not to the phone.

Not to the internet.

To God.

And this time, the next step would not wait until morning.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

*You're not the noise. You're the quiet
I keep reaching for when everything gets loud.*

- Nova Hart, untitled

Nova sat on the edge of the hotel bed with her knees pulled up, the sweatshirt bunched tight across her shoulders. Her fingers clenched until her knuckles ached.

The curtains were half-closed, letting in a faint slice of pale morning light. She had been staring at that same line of brightness for almost an hour, waiting for her thoughts to settle into something that made sense.

They didn't.

Her phone buzzed again.

And again.

And again.

She didn't even check anymore. She already knew what she would see. A flood of messages from fans, strangers, and acquaintances. Even

people she had not spoken to since ninth grade were suddenly in her inbox.

Some of them felt panicked.

Others were angry.

A few were joking, like it was all a game.

And underneath all the noise, tucked somewhere in the chaos, were the only messages that mattered.

The three texts from Elliot:

I saw it. I'm here. Breathe.

Tell me you're OK?

Please answer.

She wanted to answer. She needed to hear his voice. But her own voice felt broken, like if she spoke even one word, the whole shape of her life would crack.

A soft knock came on the door.

"Nova?" Marcy's voice. Steady. Familiar. "I'm coming in."

Nova didn't lift her head as Marcy entered the room carrying two coffees and a brown paper bag. She set them on the small table by the window.

"Cinnamon latte," she said gently. "And a bagel. I'm not leaving until you eat something."

Nova didn't move.

Marcy sighed and sat beside her on the bed. "Okay. Talk to me. Where are you right now?"

Nova swallowed, lifting her head just enough to let her eyes meet Marcy's.

"Everywhere," she whispered.

"That's not a place."

"It feels like one."

Marcy nodded, waiting. She knew better than to fill the silence too soon.

Finally, Nova spoke, her voice thin. "I didn't know it would be like this."

"Like what?"

"This loud." Her throat tightened. "One picture shouldn't be able to do this."

Marcy inhaled slowly. "It wasn't just a picture."

Nova wiped her cheek with the heel of her hand. "It's a blurry photo of me walking down a driveway."

"Walking down his driveway," Marcy corrected softly. "At sunrise. Wearing yesterday's clothes. And definitely not looking like you were dropping off muffins."

Nova closed her eyes.

The truth was simple: the nearby neighbor had snapped a picture at dawn, posted it with a cheeky caption:

Guess the mystery man isn't just a myth #522Watch

And the internet did what it always did.

It invented its own story.

It moved faster than she did. It swallowed the truth whole.

"I didn't do anything wrong," Nova whispered.

"No, you didn't."

"But it doesn't matter."

"No," Marcy admitted, "it doesn't."

Nova drew her knees tighter. "The comments are awful."

"I know."

"They're calling him names. And me worse ones. They're posting his age," she whispered. "Circling it like it's evidence. Calling him calculated. Calling me naïve."

"I know."

"They think he..." She couldn't finish it.

"Took advantage of you," Marcy sighed.

Nova tried to answer, but nothing came out. She looked away instead.

Marcy brushed a tear off her cheek with her thumb. "You know that isn't true."

"I know." Nova took a shaky breath. "But the world doesn't."

Marcy didn't deny it.

Nova grabbed her phone off the blankets. The screen lit up with dozens of new notifications. She didn't open any of them. She stared only at Elliot's three unanswered messages.

"I want to talk to him," she whispered.

"Then do."

"I can't." Her voice cracked. "I'll fall apart."

"Then fall apart," Marcy said gently. "He'll hold you."

Nova shook her head, hair falling into her face. "Not when this is my fault."

Marcy's eyes softened. "You didn't tell the neighbor to take that picture."

"But I was there," Nova whispered. "I put him in this position. Reporters are outside his house. They're tagging his company page. Posting screenshots. Leaving reviews that aren't even about his work."

Her throat tightened. "I didn't just touch his peace. I touched his name."

"Nova." Marcy slid closer. "You didn't do this to him. Fame is what barged in without knocking."

A tear rolled down Nova's cheek.

Marcy reached for her hand. "You love him."

Nova blinked hard. "I think so."

"And he loves you," Marcy said. "Anyone who looks at that photo and sees something ugly doesn't know either of you."

A hot tear slipped down her face.

Her phone buzzed again. Another notification she could not face.

She finally picked it up and just held it, unable to open the screen, unable to answer anything at all.

She closed her eyes and let the moment settle, heavy in her hands.

Elliot stood in his small kitchen, looking down at his silent phone like it was a breach alert.

Clara sat at the kitchen table wearing the hoodie she'd thrown on when she rushed over after a friend from church sent her the link to the photo.

She hadn't touched her coffee.

She hadn't opened her book bag.

She just kept watching him.

"Dad," she finally said, voice soft. "You need to eat something."

"I'm fine."

She gave him a look that said she did not believe him.

He set the phone down and pressed his palms to the counter.

He had been turning the same prayer over and over. How to love her without adding weight.

How to stay without becoming another fire.

Clara leaned forward. "She will respond."

He didn't answer.

"She will," Clara repeated. "She probably just needs space."

He nodded, but his jaw tightened.

"I'm not worried about me," he breathed. "I'm worried about her."

"You shouldn't be the one people blame," she said.

He gave a small, sad smile. "People see what they want to see."

"Do you think she regrets being with you?"

"No," he said without hesitation.

"Then don't act like she does."

He exhaled slowly. "This is a lot for her."

"It's a lot for both of you," Clara said, twisting her sleeve between her fingers. "Dad... they know your name now. Everyone does."

Elliot didn't flinch. "I know."

Clara swallowed. "And I know you wouldn't hurt her."

He met her eyes, something steady setting in his face. "Then we won't hide," he said, calm but firm. "We'll answer it."

His phone buzzed.

Clara stiffened. "Is it her?"

He checked the screen. It was Nova.

For the first time all morning, he let out a full breath.

He answered.

Later, back at the hotel, Nova's phone trembled in her hand as she finally found the courage to call.

The line rang once. Then twice. Then he answered.

"Nova." His voice was quiet.

Her voice caught. "I'm here."

A beat of silence, stretched and fragile.

"Are you safe?"

"Yes."

"Are you alone?"

"Yes."

He didn't fill the quiet. He never did. He let it sit between them, unhurried, patient, a steady place to land even when she wasn't sure she deserved one.

"I saw the picture," he said, voice low.

Her throat tightened. "Elliot... I am so sorry."

He didn't answer right away. She heard him inhale, slow and careful, and the pause stretched between them.

"Nova," he whispered. "You do not owe me an apology."

"You do not," he repeated, and then softer, "but I know why you feel that way."

Her breath shook. "I never wanted this to touch you. Or your life. Or your town."

"I know," he said. "And I believe you."

Silence settled again. This time it felt thinner. Less safe.

"This is your world," he said after a moment. "And I don't always know where I fit inside it."

"You fit," she said quickly, fear leaking into her voice. "You're not the noise. You're the quiet I keep reaching for when everything gets loud."

He didn't answer for a second.

He exhaled, long and slow. "That's what scares me."

Her chest tightened. "Scares you how?"

"Because quiet things get crushed when the world turns loud," he said. "And I don't trust myself to know how to protect you from that."

"I don't need you to protect me," she said. "I just need you with me."

The silence held longer this time.

"I want to be," he said honestly. "I just don't want my presence to become another weight you have to carry."

She swallowed. "You're not."

"I don't know that yet," he admitted. "And I don't want to pretend I do."

Her fingers curled into the blanket. "So what does that mean?"

He hesitated, and the hesitation said more than any answer.

"It means I care too much to rush this," he said. "And tonight, I don't trust myself to choose the right words."

Her voice dropped. "So we don't decide anything."

"No," he said. "We don't decide anything tonight."

The air between them shifted. Not relief. Not loss. Just uncertainty.

"I'm glad you called," he said. "I needed to hear your voice."

"I needed to hear yours too."

They stayed on the line another second longer than necessary.

Then he said quietly, "Try to rest. Even if sleep doesn't come."

"I'll try."

"Goodnight, Nova."

"Goodnight."

The line clicked.

Nova lowered the phone and stared at the screen as if something should still be there, something she could hold on to.

There wasn't.

She stared at the screen until it dimmed, then went dark. Her hands still did not move.

A sharp knock sounded at the door. Marcy opened it to find Greg already in the hallway, hair messy and eyes already working the problem. He held his phone in one hand and a folder in the other.

"Tell me you have not been reading the comments," he said as he stepped inside.

"You talked to him," Greg said.

Nova nodded.

"And?"

"And I'm not denying him," she said, voice firm.

Greg exhaled. "Then we write a statement that reflects that without giving them ammunition."

"I want it to protect him."

"Then we'll try to protect him. But, Nova, no promises. The press will do what the press will do. Truth or not."

"I won't lie."

"No one's asking you to."

Nova took a seat. "Then I'll write it."

Later that evening, Nova stepped into the hallway and closed the door behind her. The hotel carpet muffled her steps as she moved toward the window at the end of the corridor.

She called him.

He answered on the second ring.

"Nova."

"I'm writing the statement," she said.

"I figured."

She swallowed. "I'm not hiding you."

Silence. Not shocked. Not afraid. Just listening.

"I'm using your name," she said.

Another pause. She could hear him breathe.

"Then use it," he said, steady. "If they're going to say my name, I'd rather it come from you."

Her eyes burned.

"Once I post it," she said, "there's no taking it back."

"I know," he replied. "I'm not going anywhere."

The words settled into her like weight and anchor at the same time.

"Okay," she whispered.

"Okay."

She ended the call before she could second-guess herself.

Nova wrote for nearly an hour.

Every sentence felt like glass. Too sharp and it would cut him. Too soft and it would sound like fear.

She deleted more than she kept.

Finally, she typed the line and stopped.

Elliot Brooks is not a headline. He is someone I care about.

Her thumb hovered over his name.

Once it went out into the world, it would never belong to just them again.

She imagined his street.

The diner with strangers pretending to order coffee.

Mrs. Danner's name dragged into comment threads she never asked to see.

She had always known fame was loud.

She had never understood how easily it could make someone else small.

She pressed post.

The world would have his name before she could take her next breath.

That night, in the hotel's tiny chapel, Nova prayed.

Just honesty.

"Help us," she whispered. "Help me walk this without hate. And keep him safe."

Her phone buzzed beside her on the pew.

She looked at the screen.

Elliot.

She did not open the message.

Not because she didn't want to read it.

Because tonight, she did not trust herself to be both strong and gentle.

She turned the phone face down and pressed her forehead against the cool wood of the pew.

"Please," she whispered. "Hold us both."

CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

I don't know what I'm allowed to say right now.

But I don't regret you.

– **Nova Hart, untitled**

Nova woke. Her phone vibrated on the bedside table.

Not buzzing now. Vibrating.

It had stopped shouting. Now it just shook.

She turned her head and blinked at the screen.

Twenty-seven missed calls, one hundred twelve unread texts, notifications stacked so high the numbers stopped mattering.

Her throat stayed open this time. No hands. No panic.

She had said what she needed to say.

Her hands didn't shake. The hollow was still there, though, like she'd pulled a tooth without numbing first. It hurt. But it had been hers to give.

Her hotel room door rattled with a quick, urgent knock.

"Nova," Greg called. "We need you awake."

Nova pushed herself up, rubbing her face. "Come in."

Greg stepped in already holding two phones and a tablet covered in open tabs. Dark circles bruised the skin beneath his eyes, and his shoulders sagged as if the weight of the room had landed on him first.

"You are trending at number two worldwide," he said. "Right under the lunar eclipse and right above a weather guy who got caught singing 'Before the Noise' on a hot mic."

Nova blinked. The absurdity of her own song becoming background noise to someone else's worst moment was not lost on her.

"Is that good or bad?"

"Both," Greg said flatly.

Marcy slipped in behind him. "Worse than both. People have opinions."

Greg flipped one of his phones around so she could see.

Nova Hart Statement Sparks Debate

Someone Who Cared for Me.

Nova Hart Words Raise New Questions About the Mystery Man

Secret Love. Fans Speculate About the Man in Nova Hart Viral Photo

Is Nova Hart Honesty Brave or Reckless.

Public Reacts to Her Protective Statement

Nova exhaled, "Of course."

"There is more," Marcy said.

Greg swiped again.

Tags streamed across the screen.

#NovaHartLies

#WhoIs522

#ProtectNova

#CancelNova

#TeamElliot

#BadInfluence522

Nova flinched at the last one.

Marcy raised a brow. "Don't glare at me. The internet named him."

"It's not his name," Nova whispered. "And they put his house number in it."

"It's his name now," Greg said quietly. "Online, the story moves faster than the facts."

The phone in his hand started ringing again. Her publicist, calling his phone. He sent it to voicemail without looking.

"Okay," Nova said. "Tell me everything."

Greg nodded, his jaw tight.

"Your statement was honest. Beautiful. Mature. But the label public relations team is not thrilled."

"Why?" she asked.

"Because honesty is harder to spin," Greg said. "You did not apologize. You did not deny. You did not distance yourself. You basically told people to be decent."

"Is that bad?" she asked.

"For your heart," Marcy said, "no. For the machine, absolutely yes."

The word machine made her stomach turn. Marcy was usually the calm one. Hearing her say it that way made everything feel heavier.

Greg checked another alert. "We need to get you back to Los Angeles."

Nova stiffened. "Why?"

"Damage control meetings. Interviews pulled. Sponsors are asking for clarity. The label wants to speak to you in person."

"So punishment?" Nova asked.

"No," Greg said. "Not yet. But they want to control the narrative."

“And I will not lie,” Nova said.

“That,” Greg answered, “is the problem.”

Elliot’s morning felt like walking into a storm he already knew was coming.

By seven, two neighbors had left voicemails asking if the new rumors were real.

By eight, someone slid a note under his door that said only, We trusted you.

By nine, two reporters tried to talk to Clara outside the school. Clara texted Elliot at 9:10.

Dad. A reporter asked if you are dating her. I told him to stop.

I am fine. I am teaching math right now.

He stared at the text. Pride rose first. Then the sober, steady ache of a father who wished he could stand between her and the world.

At nine thirty, Ed, Elliot’s cybersecurity operations manager, sent a message.

Good morning Elliot. A few of our local clients want to talk today about the rumors online.

They have questions. No pressure. Just looking for clarity.

He stared at the word.

Clarity.

The kind that demanded answers he wasn't willing to trade for peace.

None of it felt simple.

He whispered a prayer and walked to the kitchen for coffee.

Across the street, three reporters had already returned. Nova's statement had set off another wave. Now they wanted answers from the man behind the five two two photo.

Cameras lifted as soon as he moved past the front window.

The storm was no longer digital.

Marcy pulled the hotel curtain back a few inches.

"Reporters everywhere," she said. "They came back after your statement. Someone leaked your room number."

Nova grabbed her bag.

Greg rested a hand on her shoulder. "Stay behind me. Do not talk."

Marcy opened the door.

Light exploded in her face. Voices rose in a sharp wall. Cameras lunged forward.

"Nova, do you regret it?"

"Who is he?"

"Is he the man in the photo?"

"Are you pregnant?"

"Did he take advantage of you?"

"Is the statement really true?"

"Did you write it yourself?"

Nova kept her head down.

Her heart didn't sprint. It just hurt.

Marcy guided her into the waiting SUV and yanked the door closed.

The noise shut off as if someone had hit a switch.

Nova exhaled hard.

“Welcome to ‘Day Two’,” Greg said. “Let us get you out of here.”

Hours later, the private jet moved with a low, steady hum beneath her. They were already in the air, heading toward Los Angeles.

Marcy slept light in the seat beside her.

Greg typed through a list of calls and meetings that waited on the ground.

Nova leaned her forehead against the cold window. Clouds smeared past in soft gray lines.

She opened her notes app.

She wrote:

Elliot,

They are taking me back to Los Angeles.

I don't know what's waiting for me.

But I'm not ashamed of knowing you.

I don't regret what was real.

I wish things were different.

I hope you know that.

She closed the app without sending it. She was not ready.

Not yet.

By the time the wheels touched down, Nova felt like she'd lived three days in one.

The small conference room at the church felt quieter than usual.

Pastor Lyle folded his hands on the table. "We need to understand the situation clearly, Elliot. People are asking questions."

Elliot nodded. "I understand."

Mr. Kim spoke next, his tone careful. "The concern isn't curiosity. It's trust. Families want to know whether anything inappropriate occurred."

Elliot met their eyes, one by one. He didn't rush the answer.

"She was afraid," he said simply. "She needed a safe place. That's what she had. Nothing more."

Silence settled over the table.

Mr. Landry exhaled slowly. "Thank you for saying that."

Pastor Lyle nodded. "That helps. We'll let people know you were honest with us."

He knew what he believed. Standing behind it would be the hard part.

"On Sunday," Pastor Lyle added, "we may ask you to say a few words."

Elliot's stomach dropped. "There are cameras outside my house," he said.

"I know," the pastor replied. "That's why we won't let you stand alone."

Elliot nodded again, though the thought of it pressed hard against his chest.

He would speak plainly. But the thought of standing in front of everyone while cameras still sat outside his house pressed hard against his chest.

Public relations staff waited by the elevator when Nova arrived at the label.

Her representative, Diane, walked toward them with a clipboard. Her smile was tight and practiced. It did not reach her eyes.

She led them down the hall. Her heels clicked against the polished floor. Greg walked beside Nova, scrolling through his phone with quick sharp movements. Marcy stayed close at her shoulder.

They stepped into the main conference room. The lights dimmed as the screen on the wall flickered awake.

"We need to review your statement," Diane said, taking the front of the room. "Then we will plan controlled messaging for the next seventy-two hours."

"I am not lying," Nova said quietly.

"No one is asking you to lie," Diane countered, though her tone hinted they would not mind if the truth softened. "We just need to guide perception."

"I told the truth," Nova said.

"And now we need to manage it," Diane replied.

Greg stepped forward. His tone was steady and professional, but tired. "She posted what she posted. We do not have the luxury of rewriting it. Let us handle what comes next."

Diane pursed her lips. "Then we need to prepare for more fallout." She tapped her tablet. Slides appeared on the wall.

Headlines. Tweets. Fan edits. Accusations. Posts of support. Confusion.

A brand partner pause notice.

A venue asking for clarification.

An upcoming talk show quietly withdrew its invitation.

"This is the current landscape," Diane stated. "Your statement shifted public attention from rumors to you. That helped in some ways and complicated others."

"Several partners are waiting to see how today goes. No cancellations yet. They just want updated guidance."

She clicked again. The same hashtags Greg had shown her that morning filled the screen in huge letters.

Nova's stomach clenched.

"There is no clear narrative," Diane said. "Support and backlash are rising at the same pace. That is why we need a defined message for the next few days."

Greg exhaled through his nose but stayed silent.

Marcy's hand brushed Nova's back.

"We recommend a follow-up statement," Diane said. "Something like, I value privacy and ask that people respect the boundaries of everyone involved."

"I will not pretend he does not matter," Nova said.

Diane sighed. "This is not about him. It is about your career."

"If I have to lie to keep it," Nova said, "then it is not my career anymore."

The room went still.

Greg looked at her with a mix of pride and worry.

Diane reset her expression. "Then the work will be harder. But the machine will still move."

Clara came home from school with her shoulders tight.

“A reporter cornered one mom outside the school and started asking about you,” she said as soon as she walked into the kitchen. “A reporter told Jenna’s mother that you broke some law. Jenna’s mother told him to get off school grounds.”

Elliot’s heart burned. “I am so sorry.”

Clara dropped her bag near the table. “You did nothing wrong.”

He pulled her into a hug. Relief and ache pressed together until he couldn’t tell them apart.

Outside, a camera flashed.

He flinched.

Nova finally reached her condo.

Door closed. Curtains drawn.

Quiet.

She slid down to sit on the floor by the window and pulled out her phone.

She opened the message she had written on the plane.

She read it twice.

She did not send it.

Instead, she typed one line.

I don't know what I'm allowed to say right now. But I don't regret you.

She stared at the screen until her eyes burned.
She did not hit send.

Across the country, Elliot stood at his kitchen sink and watched the street through the blinds.

A camera flash popped. Sharp. Brief.

He closed his eyes and whispered, "God, help us."

Nova set the phone down.

Elliot did the same.

Different cities.

Different storms.

No answers yet.

CHAPTER THIRTY

*"I couldn't hold you and the machine at the same time
without breaking something."*

- Nova Hart, untitled

Nova opened her main social app, and her face filled the screen.

Clips from her statement played beside photos from the cafe in Oceanside, the side of Elliot's house, and grainy stills pulled from too far away.

Her words scrolled beneath other people's voices. Creators had stitched her video and layered their commentary around the edges.

Trending tags climbed the page.

#NovaStatement

#WhoIs522

#ProtectNova

#BadInfluence522

She watched for less than ten seconds before locking the screen and setting the phone face down on the table.

Silence filled the room. Not peaceful. Pressurized.

She crossed the condo, bare feet brushing the polished floor, and rested her forehead against the cool glass. Los Angeles stretched beneath her in light and haze and constant motion. Late afternoon light slid across the walls, clean and impersonal. Cars streamed through the streets in endless loops.

Everything here demanded momentum.

She thought of Elliot.

Not the headlines.

Not the theories.

Just him.

The way his voice slowed when things mattered. The way his hands had never rushed her, even when the world had.

Longing hit hard and clean.

Her phone chimed.

Video Call.

Greg. Label. Public Relations.

She swallowed and accepted.

The screen filled with familiar boxes. Greg. Diane. Mara. Faces that carried decisions before words ever formed.

"Morning, Nova," Greg said, already tired.

"Good morning," she replied.

Diane leaned forward. "We need to talk about the next steps."

Nova nodded. "Okay."

Mara spoke first. "Your statement shifted attention. That helped. It also made people dig harder."

Diane clicked through the slides. Headlines. Commentary. Fan edits. Speculation.

"They are tracking your travel," Diane said. "Wilmington. Ocean-side. Twice in one month. They are connecting dots."

"I haven't said anything," Nova replied.

"That's part of the problem," Mara said. "Silence reads as avoidance."

"It reads as boundaries," Nova said quietly.

Mara held her gaze. "The machine doesn't recognize boundaries unless we teach it how."

The word machine sat heavy in the room.

Greg stepped in. "We're recommending Nova stays in Los Angeles for the next few weeks. No unplanned travel. No spontaneous appearances."

Nova fixed her eyes on the edge of the table.

"So I stop going to him?" she asked.

No one corrected her.

Mara softened her tone. "We need stability. Distance calms speculation."

Nova leaned back in her chair. The condo felt smaller, the quiet pressing in where music usually lived.

"If I don't agree?" she asked.

Mara didn't hesitate. "Then the story gets written without you."

Silence stretched.

Nova nodded once. "Fine. I'll stay."

Relief flickered across the screen.

Schedules filled themselves in. Appearances shifted.

The silence after the call was more intense than before.

Nova crossed the room and opened her guitar case. She strummed a single chord.

It sounded thin.

She set the guitar aside.

Her phone lay on the table.

She picked it up.

Elliot's name sat there, steady and unchanged.

She stared at it longer than she meant to.

Then she pressed call.

The ring stretched just long enough to hurt.

"Hey," he said.

Just that. Gentle. Familiar.

Her chest tightened. "Hey."

"You sound tired," he said.

"I am," she admitted. "Are you okay to talk?"

"For you? Always."

She told him everything. The meeting. The pressure. The decision to stay in Los Angeles. The way the walls were closing in with no one touching her.

"They think distance is safer," she mumbled.

He didn't speak right away.

"So I'm part of the risk," he said gently.

"No," she blurted. "You're not the problem. The noise is."

"I don't want to be something you have to give up to survive," he said.

Her voice almost failed her.

"You aren't."

But even as she said it, something in her chest tightened, like she had shifted the truth just enough to survive it.

"I don't know how to carry this," she said. "Everything feels like it's pulling me apart."

He exhaled. She could hear the care in it.

"Nova," he said, "you don't owe me endurance."

The words undid her.

She pressed her fingers to her forehead. "I think ... I think I need to step back."

Silence.

Not sharp. Just full.

"I don't want to," she rushed on. "This isn't about love disappearing. It's about weight. I can't hold you and the machine at the same time without breaking something."

He made no sound.

"I don't want to keep asking you to stand in the blast radius," she said. "And I don't want to turn you into a secret or a problem to manage."

A soft sound escaped him. Not quite a sigh.

"So this is space," he said.

"Yes," she whispered. "Real space. Not disappearing. Not punishment. Just ... a pause where we're not trying to hold everything at once."

Another silence.

"I will respect that," he said finally. "Even if it hurts."

Her eyes filled. "I'm so sorry."

"I know," he said. "And I believe you."

A faint knock sounded on his end. Clara's voice followed.

"Dad? Can I come in?"

"I should go," he said.

"Of course."

"I'm not angry with you," he whispered.

"I know," she said. "That's why this is so hard."

The call ended.

Nova gently placed the phone down, as if it were fragile.

The day surged forward around her. Marcy arrived with schedules. A stylist followed. Emails stacked. The machine reclaimed its space.

Nova moved through it all like someone underwater.

That night, alone again, she sat on the edge of her bed and opened her messages.

She typed.

I miss you.

Deleted.

This really hurts.

Deleted.

Please don't forget me.

Deleted.

Nothing felt right.

Nova set the phone down and did not pick it up again.

For the first time since she met Elliot, the distance was not accidental.

She had chosen it.

The city moved around her, loud and restless, already asking more than she could give.

Somewhere far away, his life would now go on without her.

She lay back on the bed and stared at the ceiling, letting the ache exist without fixing it.

It wasn't the end.

But it was the first time she chose the distance.

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

Stepping back felt like protection. Later I understood it was just fear
with better posture.

- **Nova Hart, untitled**

Three weeks had passed since he and Nova stopped talking, and September had brought the first cool mornings.

The quiet of his life struck Elliot. Not silent. Just missing something.

The online storm had faded. The church had settled. Clara no longer watched him the way she did in August, with worry tucked behind every glance. Life had found its rhythm again.

The feeling stayed.

It appeared in ordinary moments: while making coffee, the laughter from the diner, the cry of seagulls at the window.

At night, the house still felt larger than it should.

He told himself they had stepped back because it was right for both of them. The reasons came easily: her world too loud, her life already heavy, love demanding restraint instead of presence.

Some days that felt true.

Other days, he wondered if stepping back had less to do with wisdom and more to do with fear.

He knew what losing felt like. Some mornings he still half-listened for his wife's voice in the kitchen before remembering.

He believed God was good. He also knew good did not mean safe. Maybe too careful.

He did not want to break again. And he did not want Clara to watch him break.

He tried to believe the stillness was healing. That space was wisdom. But in the quiet that remained, he began to hear something else.

A longing he could not reason away.

A question he could not silence.

What if stepping back had protected his heart but wounded something he was meant to hold?

Saturday at the church was quiet. People had finished most of the food drive work early. The halls carried a scent of lemon cleaner, and the air conditioner hummed.

Elliot carried a stack of service flyers to the bulletin board. He lingered, pinning them up and lining the corners with thumbtacks. His movements were steady, but they felt heavier than usual, like each small task required more focus than it should.

"You know, these boards never look the same without your handwriting," a voice said behind him.

Elliot turned.

Mr. Avery maintained a few feet of distance, leaning on his cane and watching. He had a way of seeing people without crowding them.

"Morning," Elliot said.

"Morning," the elder replied. "You have been harder to find these days."

Elliot lifted a shoulder. "Just busy."

"Busy can be true," Mr. Avery said. "But it is rarely the whole truth."

Elliot almost smiled. "You always read me like a book."

"I only read what is there," Mr. Avery said. "Walk with me."

They stepped outside. The courtyard was bright with sunlight, and the first hints of fall brushed the air. A few dry leaves skittered across the concrete as if they had given up holding on.

They sat on the bench beneath the oak. The wood felt cool beneath Elliot as he settled, the kind of steady surface he wished he felt inside.

Mr. Avery rested both hands on his cane. "You have been quiet, son. I want to understand why."

"It is about someone I care for," Elliot said quietly. "She asked for space. I gave it."

"Was it right?" the elder asked.

"I thought so," Elliot said. "Now I am not sure."

"What happened?"

Elliot drew a slow breath. "Her world was spinning. Too loud. Too much pressure. Too many opinions and cameras and strangers. When she said she needed space, I tried to honor that. I did not want to add weight to what she was already carrying."

"That sounds thoughtful," Mr. Avery said.

"It did not feel thoughtful," Elliot replied. "It felt like fear pretending to be wisdom."

The elder watched a leaf fall and land between his shoes. "Sometimes loving someone means stepping toward them."

"What if stepping toward her makes her life harder?" Elliot asked. "What if loving me hurts her career or pulls her into trouble she does not need?"

"Then you learn to walk with her," Mr. Avery said. "Not ahead. Not behind. With."

The word settled in Elliot's chest.

"But I know something else," Mr. Avery added. "Sometimes people tell themselves they are protecting others when really they are trying to protect their own hearts."

Elliot looked at him.

"You lost your wife," the elder said softly. "That loss shaped you. It taught you to protect others, even when it cost you. It also taught you to fear losing again. Fear can sound wise if you listen to it long enough."

Elliot closed his eyes for a moment. Hospital lights came back to him. Casserole dishes. Clara sitting on the floor of her bedroom with a blanket wrapped around her shoulders. At night, he could still see himself standing in the hallway, waiting for a voice that never came.

"I did not want to hurt her," he said. "I did not want to bring pain into her life. And I did not want Clara to go through another loss."

"That may be love," Mr. Avery said. "But love still needs air. And you don't get to make that kind of decision by yourself. Did she ask you to step away?"

"No," Elliot whispered. "She never did."

"Then be honest," Mr. Avery said. "Did you step away for her sake or for yours?"

Elliot let the question sit. "I think it was both. But maybe it was more mine."

Mr. Avery nodded. "That sounds like truth."

He placed a gentle hand on Elliot's shoulder. "Do not close a door just because you fear the shadows behind it. Fear is loud, Elliot. God rarely is. He leads you by faith and a willing heart."

The elder stood and walked back toward the church, slow and steady.

Elliot remained on the bench, letting the words settle into the places that hurt most.

His phone buzzed.

It was Clara.

He answered. "Hey."

"Hi," she said. "Do you have a minute?"

"For you, always."

"You are going to be proud of me," she said. "Really proud."

"Tell me."

"My classroom literacy grant got approved," she said, and he could hear the brightness in her voice. "We are getting an entire set of new reading books. Proper books. Not the old ones with torn covers. I was so happy I almost screamed in class."

Warmth rose in his chest. "Clara, that is incredible. I know how much that meant to you."

"I already have a plan for how the shelves should look," she said. "Mom used to rearrange our books every time she brought home a new one. I want the same feeling for my kids."

His heart softened. "Your mom would be so proud of you. She would probably buy out the bookstore and bring in even more books you did not ask for."

Clara laughed. "She would."

A pause followed, softer than before.

"Can I say something that might be awkward?" she asked.

"Always," he said. "Go ahead."

"I am relieved Nova is taking a break."

He remained silent.

"Not because I thought she was wrong for you," Clara added quickly. "I never knew what to think. But I could see what she did to you. You haven't looked at anyone like that since Mom."

Elliot had been bracing for judgment. Instead, the ground shifted under him.

"I was scared, Dad," she continued. "About the age difference. Not because I thought it was wrong. Just because it's real. She's still building her life. You've already lived the whole marriage-and-family chapter. That's a big gap."

She hesitated. "She moves fast. You don't. You've built your life around quiet and faith and steadiness. I didn't know if her world would ever slow down enough to meet yours."

"And her lifestyle," Clara went on. "The traveling. The noise. The interviews. The cameras. None of that is bad. It's just... big."

She paused. "You live quietly, Dad. You can sit in a house for hours and feel at peace. I worried you would change yourself to fit her world. Not because she would expect you to — but because you always try to protect the people you love."

Elliot's throat tightened.

"And when the videos and memes exploded," Clara said, "I saw how much it shook you. That look in your eyes reminded me of when Mom died. I couldn't handle seeing you hurt like that again."

He swallowed hard.

"I want you to find love again someday," Clara said. "I really do. But I want someone who fits your world. Someone who lives beside you — not a life on magazine covers and planes."

She hesitated. "When everything with Nova ended, I didn't want to feel relieved. But I did. You looked steadier. Safer. More like the dad I know."

The kitchen went quiet enough that he could hear the refrigerator hum.

"I hear you," he said quietly.

"I know you do," she said. "Thank you."

Another small pause.

"I should get the room ready before my kids come back from gym," she said. "If they walk in and see me tearing up over the book list again, they will never let it go."

He smiled. "Send me a picture when they arrive."

"Deal. Love you."

"Love you, too."

He ended the call and exhaled. The kitchen felt open again, not empty.

Even if it hurt, Clara had made something clear for him.

Now he had to decide what to do with it.

That evening he sat at his kitchen table with his Bible open. He read slowly. Verses about courage. Verses about perfect love casting out fear. Verses about God staying close to those who hurt.

He closed the book and picked up his phone.

He did not call Nova. He did not text her.

He simply held the phone and let the truth settle in him.

He missed her.

He cared for her.

He was afraid of hurting Clara.

He was afraid of losing again.

But he was tired of letting fear take the lead.

He was not ready to reach for Nova. Not yet.

But he was no longer stepping away. He had asked God to tell him what to do next. Maybe this was the first part of the answer.

He was tired of being careful with things God had not asked him to surrender.

CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

*I know the quiet places down by the ocean reach,
Where your steady heart still lingers just beyond my reach.
And though my world keeps pulling me farther day by day,
I carry what you gave me even though I walked away.
I wish I could have seen that look on your face.*

- Nova Hart, new verse from "That Look on Your Face," unreleased

Nova woke to the sound of her own breathing.

For a moment she did not know where she was. The ceiling was high. The molding ornate. The room carried the careful quiet of a place where people whispered even in the hall.

Paris. Confirmed by the key card on the table.

The room looked like every other room on tour. Dim light. Thick carpet. A low hum from the air unit. A water bottle on the nightstand. An open suitcase by the wall, filled and folded by someone else's hands.

Her phone lit up before she touched it.

Alarm. Snooze.

Alarm again. Ignored.

Press alerts she did not want to open.

Three missed calls from Marcy.

She answered on the next vibration.

"You slept through everything," Marcy said. "And by everything, I mean three alarms and all three of my attempts at a wake up call."

Nova groaned softly. "What time is it."

"Eleven fifteen," Marcy said. "Greg is two seconds from a meltdown."

Nova pushed herself upright. "Tell him I will be there in twenty minutes. He can survive that long."

"I will tell him you are alive," Marcy replied. "That is the full scope of my loyalty."

Nova smiled despite herself.

They hung up.

She set her phone down before her thumb could drift to the one thread her heart still reached for on instinct.

She had not opened that conversation in weeks. Not since she asked for space. Not since he gave it to her.

"Work now," she whispered to the empty room. "Feel things later."

Not because she was avoiding them, but because she needed something she could control.

She repeated it until she stood.

Her stadium pass lay on the table, clipped to a lanyard. She picked it up. The laminate caught the light.

Nova Hart. Sound check access. Paris.

A sold out venue waited for her. A crew. A band. A crowd that did not know she was still learning how to breathe without him.

She pulled on a hoodie, tied her hair back, and headed for the elevators.

Work now. Rehearsal first. The rest could wait.

The entryway behind the stage smelled like coffee and cables.

Crew members rolled cases across the floor. A tech tested a keyboard. Someone adjusted lights overhead. Voices blended into a low, steady buzz.

Nova sipped a second coffee Marcy handed her. It burned. She welcomed the sting. It made her feel awake in a way sleep had not.

Greg paced near the wall, tablet in hand, the way he always did when he needed her to be a version of herself she did not quite feel.

"There she is," he said, smiling with a mix of pride and relief.

"Good morning," Nova said. "I am told you were close to crisis mode."

"I was not," Greg said. "But I did rehearse a very dramatic collapse just in case."

Marcy smirked behind her cup.

"Quick things," Greg said, tapping the tablet. "Streams are up. Tonight is sold out. Standing room only. Yesterday's interview is still trending. Most remaining dates are near sold out, so the label is thrilled. We added a radio stop tomorrow morning before you fly out."

"Of course you did," Nova said.

"You will be great," he said, stepping past her tone. "The momentum is unreal."

"Anything out there I need to know about," she asked.

Greg hesitated, then shook his head. "Nothing that needs your attention. Fans arguing about nonsense. Normal noise."

Her chest loosened.

No new deep dives on 522.

No fresh headlines dragging his house back into the light.

She needed that.

“Good,” she said.

“You good,” Greg asked, watching her more closely.

“I am here,” Nova answered.

“Good enough,” he said. “Warm up. The band is ready.”

She followed Marcy toward the ballroom doors. Instruments thudded faintly through the wall like a heartbeat.

Right before she stepped inside, she checked her phone one more time.

Nothing from him.

She was the one who had asked for space.

She had no right to want anything else.

Still, the screen stayed empty.

Back in Oceanside, the house felt quieter than it had in a long time.

Morning light slid across the kitchen counter in thin gold lines. The coffee maker gurgled in a slow, steady rhythm. A small stack of plates from last night sat beside the sink.

Elliot poured coffee and leaned against the counter.

For years his mornings had followed a simple pattern. Prayer. Coffee. Reading. The calm peace that came from knowing what came next.

Today that peace felt thin, like a shirt worn at the seams.

He opened his Bible to the passage he planned to teach Wednesday night. He read the first verse twice before realizing he had not taken in a single word.

He closed the book gently.

The mug she had used that last night still sat in the drying rack. Faded blue paint. A small chip along the rim.

He had not moved it.

He told himself it was because he was busy.

He knew better.

It was a small sign of her presence he was not ready to tuck away.

He stepped onto the front porch.

The air smelled of salt and dew. A few cars passed. Somewhere a dog barked.

On other mornings those sounds grounded him.

Today they underlined the space where she was not.

His phone vibrated.

"Hey kiddo," he said when he answered.

"You are not allowed to call me that forever," Clara said.

"That is exactly how long I plan to call you that," he said.

She laughed.

"You at home," she asked.

"Yeah," he said. "Just started the coffee."

"You sound tired," she said. "Like you slept but your brain did not."

He rubbed the back of his neck. "Maybe. It is a slow morning."

Slow was not the word. He did not know the right one.

"Well," he said lightly, "at least the elders will sleep better. I told them I would try to keep my life simple."

Clara did not laugh.

"That does not sound like you," she said.

He smiled. "It did not sound like me when I said it either."

She let that rest.

“Dad,” she said quietly, “you know you do not have to pretend everything is fine with me.”

His throat tightened.

“I miss her,” he said. “And I am trying to let her go at the same time. I do not know how to hold both.”

“That sounds hard,” she said.

“It is.”

“But do you think you made the wrong choice,” she asked.

He thought of Nova in his kitchen. The exhaustion in her eyes. The way her fingers curled around the mug like she needed something steady. The way her voice shook when she said she could not keep running to him even though she did not want to stop.

“No,” he said. “I think I did the right thing by respecting what she asked for. Even if it hurts.”

Clara exhaled. “Just don’t decide something permanent while you’re still hurting.”

He smiled. “You becoming a poet now.”

“Side effect of reading sad books,” she said.

They talked a little longer. Ordinary things. Good things.

When the call ended, the house felt quiet again.

Not because it was empty.

Because he now knew which spaces felt empty without her.

He washed the plates one by one.

Routine. Steady. Enough for today.

Nova stood at the edge of the stage with her hands wrapped around a water bottle.

Sound check was mechanical. Notes. Light cues. Small corrections. The tech team spoke in short signals and hand waves.

Her body remembered even when her mind wandered.

That night the arena filled to the top rows. Another crowd. Another ocean of noise. The same ache she carried from city to city.

When it was time for *That Look on Your Face*, the lights washed the stage in soft gold.

The cheers rolled toward her.

She lifted the mic.

"Thank you," she said. "You are loud tonight."

They roared.

She smiled, a little crooked and real.

"I had a speech planned for this part," she said. "Something about holding on to dreams and letting go of fear. It was written like a poem. But life is not always fond of poems. And I am far too tired to make anything rhyme without help."

Laughter rippled through the seats.

Her face shifted. Humor faded. Something unguarded took its place.

"What I really want to say is that sometimes the dream costs you things you never expected," she said. "Sometimes saying yes to one part of your life means saying no to another, even when both are good."

A hush settled over the arena.

"I added a new verse to this song," she said. "I want to sing it before we play the rest."

From the wings, Marcy lifted her head. Greg turned sharply.

"Tell me she is not doing what I think she is doing," he whispered.

Marcy did not answer.

The band traded quick glances. Only they knew.
The intro started slow and aching. Softer than usual. Heavier.
Nova strummed a final chord and let it hang until the room stilled.
She closed her eyes and sang from the place she had guarded for weeks.

I know the quiet places down by the ocean reach,
Where your steady heart still lingers just beyond my reach.
And though my world keeps pulling me farther day by day,
I carry what you gave me even though I walked away.
I wish I could have seen that look on your face.

The arena held its breath.

Then it erupted.

The roar crashed over her. Phones lifted. Lights flickered. Something inside her broke open. Not pain. Release.

She pressed a hand to her chest. A wordless prayer rose.

Marcy covered her mouth, eyes shining. Greg lowered his gaze, then looked back up with something like surrender.

They heard the turn in her voice.

They knew it meant something.

Nova turned to the band.

They nodded.

Lights burst alive as the main beat hit. The quiet shattered. The song surged full and fierce, like it had found its heartbeat again.

The crowd shouted the chorus with such force the floor trembled.

Nova sang every line as if she needed the song to steady her own breath.

When the final chord faded and the lights settled into warm gold, she let the noise wash over her.

For a moment, something larger than applause held her. Something steady that touched the ache without erasing it.

She let the feeling sit where it was and stepped forward.

From the wings, Marcy watched in quiet awe. Greg lowered his tablet. The tension in his shoulders eased.

Somewhere far away, in a small house with chipped mugs and slow mornings, a man she loved was breathing through the same ache.

She wondered if God was holding him too.

The distance between them stayed wide.

And for the first time, she was not afraid of crossing it.

CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

"I looked off. Even to myself."

- Nova Hart, untitled

Nova woke before her alarm, long before she needed to.

She did not move.

Her eyes opened to the ceiling, and she stayed there, counting the seconds it took for the room to come into focus. The sheets were twisted around her waist, one shoulder pressed tight against the mattress.

She drew a breath and held it without meaning to. Let it out. Tried again.

The room held the pale gray of early morning, the kind that flattened distance and color. She lay there, waiting for something to hit.

Nothing did.

Her phone buzzed on the nightstand.

She did not look. Not yet.

She crossed to the desk and opened her laptop. The blank document from the night before blinked back at her, the cursor steady and patient.

She was neither.

She typed three random words. Deleted them. Typed a line. Deleted that too. Her hands hovered over the keyboard, uncertain, like they no longer quite belonged to her.

A knock sounded at the door.

Nova froze. Then she shut the laptop, a little too quickly, as if she had been caught doing something she could not explain.

"Nova?" Marcy called. "If you died in there, I swear you better haunt me with compliments."

Nova forced her voice to sound normal. "Come in."

Marcy stepped inside carrying two coffees, a bag of food, and the expression of someone quietly preparing to panic.

"You did not answer the three texts I sent," Marcy said. "Or the missed call. Or the knock you probably did not hear at first."

Nova swallowed. "Sorry. I was... I did not see it."

Marcy lifted an eyebrow. "You did not see your phone that was sitting six inches from you."

"I am fine," Nova said.

Marcy sighed and set the food on the desk. "Right. And I am the Queen of England."

Nova tried to laugh. Her throat refused to cooperate.

"Hazelnut," Marcy said, handing her a cup. "Drink. Please."

Nova took a long sip. The warmth softened the chill in her hands but only loosened the knot in her chest a little.

"You sleep?" Marcy asked.

Nova hesitated. "Sort of."

"That means no."

"I got some rest."

"That also means no."

Nova did not answer again.

Marcy did not push. Instead, she nudged the bagel closer. "Eat something before you pass out on Greg. He already thinks we are chaos."

Nova took a bite. It tasted like nothing. She chewed anyway. When she tried to swallow, the food stuck, like her body had not agreed to the day yet.

Marcy watched without judgment. "If you need to talk..."

"I do not," Nova said too quickly.

Marcy's face softened. "Okay."

The quiet stretched between them.

"Rehearsal in twenty minutes," Marcy said. "I will meet you in the hall."

Nova nodded, gathered her things, and followed a minute later.

The rehearsal hall smelled faintly of sawdust, sweat, and warm stage lights.

On most days the energy hit her like a current, familiar and alive. Today it felt like stepping into a room where every sound had been turned up too loud.

People moved in every direction. Sneakers scuffed the floor as dancers stretched. Cables scraped softly as techs pulled them into place. A guitar climbed a scale and fell back again, joined by a keyboard testing its range. The room thrummed with unfinished sound.

The moment Nova walked inside, something in her went slightly off balance.

Greg spotted her and waved her over. "Morning."

"Morning."

"You good?"

"Yes."

He studied her just long enough to see the truth she was trying to hide. "Alright," he said quietly. "Just ease in. No need to push."

Across the room, the vocal director lifted a hand. "Positions, everyone. We will start from the top."

Nova walked to her mark and tugged at the hem of her shirt. She swallowed, tried to steady herself, and lifted the mic.

The music began.

Her first line came out breathy. She caught it and pushed through. The second line was better. The third almost normal.

The bridge approached.

She opened her mouth.

Nothing came out.

She tried again. A thin, late note slipped free, like her voice had fallen behind her body.

"Hold," the vocal director called.

Everything stopped.

Dancers froze.

The drummer lowered his sticks.

The room went still in a way that felt too exposed.

Greg watched from the side, his expression shifting as pieces fell into place he wished were not there. He stepped closer, careful not to draw attention.

"Nova," he said gently, "talk to me. What is happening?"

"I am tired."

"That was not tired," he said softly, close enough that only she could hear. "That was you disappearing mid line."

They ran the bridge again. She made it through by forcing herself past every warning signal. Her throat tightened. Her breath thinned.

During a dance combination she landed one step off center. Lara, one of the lead dancers, noticed without breaking form. As they passed on the next count, Lara tilted her head just enough.

"You okay?" she whispered.

"Fine," Nova said, pulse spiking. "Sorry."

Lara did not reply, but her eyes flicked toward Nova more than once through the next run.

Half an hour later her foot caught on a pattern she had practiced for months. Her ankle rolled just enough to throw the line.

Heat rushed up her neck.

The choreographer clapped once. "Take five. Water and air."

Nova hated that the call felt like mercy.

She moved to the side of the room, sat on the floor, and leaned against the wall. Her chest fluttered with the same anxious rhythm she could not slow. She pressed a cold water bottle to her forehead.

Her hands shook.

She told herself it was exhaustion.

A long week.

Stress.

But deep inside, something whispered that it was more.

When break ended she worked harder, but her edges stayed frayed. The last hour stretched like a slow storm. By the time rehearsal was dismissed, Nova felt drained and hollow, as if something inside her had been scraped thin.

Marcy did not speak when Nova joined her at the door. She simply walked beside her in quiet as they headed back to the hotel.

Nova shut the door and locked it. The quiet hit her like a wave she could not brace for. She leaned back against the door and swallowed hard.

Her bag dropped to the floor. She sat on the edge of the bed. Her hands trembled again. She pressed them between her knees, trying to steady them, but the shaking only softened, never stopped.

Her mind replayed the day in fragments.

The slip in the bridge.

Greg's face.

Lara's quiet concern.

The break she did not want.

The almost fall.

The girl in the mirror that morning who already looked worn.

She turned on the shower. Steam fogged the mirror until it disappeared. She stepped under the water, hoping it would wash something clean.

It did not.

She stayed until the water turned too hot. Then too cold. Her heart kept racing anyway.

When she stepped out, she wiped a circle in the mirror and froze.

She looked off.

Eyes slightly hollow. Jaw held too tense. Shoulders curled inward like she was guarding something fragile.

Like she was carrying weight she no longer knew how to set down.

"Come on," she whispered. "Get it together."

Her voice wavered.

She dressed in soft clothes and returned to the bedroom. She sat on the edge of the bed and opened her laptop.

Blank page.

Blinking cursor.

Silence that felt pointed.

She tried humming a melody. The tune fractured halfway through, as if her voice no longer trusted her.

Her chest tightened. She pressed a hand over her sternum without thinking.

Her thoughts circled one truth she could not quiet.

She missed Elliot.

She missed the steadiness in his voice. The way he listened without trying to fix her. The way he saw her without the noise or the performance.

She told herself space was good. Necessary. Adult.

Her phone buzzed.

She did not reach for it.

Wanting him did not mean she was ready to lean on him.

She stayed where she was, letting the ache exist without turning it into action.

But she could not.

Not when she could not even quiet her own heartbeat.

She slid down to the floor, back against the window, knees pulled tight to her chest. She wrapped her arms around them and rested her chin on top.

Her breathing came in shaky waves.

She tried to anchor herself.

Her eyes scanned the room for something that felt steady. The lamp. The desk. The edge of the window frame. None of it held.

Her fingers tingled, restless, as if even her body could not decide where to land.

She squeezed her eyes shut.

Her phone buzzed on the bed.

She did not move. She did not even look. She did not trust herself to.

She curled smaller, breath thin, tears drying in uneven tracks on her cheeks.

"I am fine," she whispered into the quiet.

The words sounded hollow. Like habit, not belief.

The room felt too big.

The silence too deep.

Her thoughts too loud.

She stayed there, back against the glass, until her legs went numb and her breathing steadied only because she no longer had the energy to fall apart.

When she finally climbed onto the bed, she pulled the covers around her and stared at the ceiling.

She did not sleep. She did not move.

And without meaning to, she whispered a quiet plea into the dark, asking God to hold her steady when she could not hold herself.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

*"Letting go was not something I was doing.
It was something I had been postponing."*

- Nova Hart, untitled

Today the quiet felt wrong.

Elliot stood at the sink rinsing a plate he had not eaten from. The faucet ran steady, louder than it should have been. Or maybe his own thoughts had gone too quiet. He set the plate in the drying rack and braced his hands on the counter.

The house felt hollow.

Sound carried too far.

He had slept, but rest had come thin. His dreams had broken apart before he could hold them. Her voice. Her laugh stopping before it finished. He woke with a weight that had nothing to do with fatigue and everything to do with distance.

The phone buzzed on the table.

Elliot's eyes went to it before he caught himself. He closed them instead.

"Give me steadiness today," he said quietly.

When he finally checked the screen, notifications stacked faster than he could read them. Articles. Missed calls. Messages from people he had not heard from in years. A few names he expected. A few he did not.

He set the phone face down, then left the room before he could turn back.

A knock sounded at the door.

Elliot wiped his hands on a dish towel and opened it.

Clara stood on the porch with her backpack slung over one shoulder, hair pulled back, her expression tighter than usual.

"Morning," she said.

"Morning."

She stepped inside only a little, hovering like she had not decided whether she should stay. "Are you okay?"

He could have said yes. He could have said fine. He had done that for years.

"I am managing," he said instead.

Her shoulders eased just a fraction. "I wanted to check on you before work."

"I appreciate that."

She studied him, really studied him, then nodded. She did not push.

"I will walk you out," he said.

"You do not have to."

"I want to."

Outside, the air was cool and damp, the ocean carried faintly on the breeze. She opened her car door, then paused.

"I can come back later," she said. "If you want someone around."

"You do not need to take care of me."

"Sometimes I like to," she said softly.

Elliot looked down at his hands and realized he had gone still.

"I will be okay," he promised.

She believed him enough to leave. Not enough to stop worrying.

Elliot stood there until her car disappeared down the street.

Inside, the quiet pressed closer.

He tried routine. Laundry. Sweeping sand by the back door. Safe motions. Familiar motions.

None of it steadied him.

His thoughts kept drifting to Nova. Her voice on the last call. The way she had tried to sound strong. The silence that had followed.

His hand brushed the couch cushion where she had fallen asleep the night she stayed.

Something white peeked out between the cushion and the armrest.

He reached for it.

A torn scrap of paper.

Her handwriting.

Three words, rushed and slanted.

Work now, feel later.

His breath caught.

Not a lyric. Not a message. Just a thought she had written and left behind.

He pictured her sitting right there, hoodie sleeves pushed up, pen tapping against her lip, eyes distant but soft. Trusting him enough to sleep in his house. To breathe his air.

He folded the paper and slipped it into his wallet, tucking it behind an old photo of Clara at seven years old.

The truth settled in.

Letting go was not something he was doing.

It was something he had been postponing.

And something inside him was done postponing.

His phone buzzed again on the table.

He picked up the phone.

This time, he opened the video.

He watched her sing the new verse.

He saw it.

Not the smile.

Not the lights.

The second where her breath caught.

The way her shoulders stayed tight even after the song ended.

The pause before she spoke again.

It was small.

But it was not nothing.

His jaw tightened.

“Lord,” he whispered.

He lowered the phone slowly.

The quiet no longer rested easily around him.

It pressed.

He whispered her name once.

Not a plea.

Not a promise.

Just truth.

“Nova.”

And for the first time, the quiet did not feel like patience.

It felt like a countdown.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

*"Thank you. Help me. I am sorry. Please.
None of it came out right. So I said it anyway."*
- **Nova Hart, untitled**

Nova spent most of the afternoon pretending to be fine.

It was almost like a game now. Smile for the photos. Laugh at the right moments. Give short, sweet answers that sounded like someone else had written them far away from how she really felt.

They were at a small studio across town, not for rehearsal but for light content. Behind-the-scenes clips. Short interview soundbites. A few quick videos for social media.

"Nothing heavy," the producer had said. "Just fun stuff. Give the fans a peek at your day. Low-pressure."

Low-pressure. Right.

Nova sat on a tall stool under bright lights while a tiny camera on a tripod stared her down. There were only three people in the room besides Marcy, but it still felt like a crowd.

"Okay, Nova," the producer said. "We will roll a few quick questions. You are a pro. You got this."

She nodded. She did know how to do this. She had done it a hundred times.

The first questions were easy.

"What is one thing you always have in your bag?" the producer asked.

"Snacks," Nova said easily. "Emergency ones. And headphones, because the snacks are for after."

"Where is your favorite place to write?"

She talked about hotel rooms and late nights.

"What would you tell younger you?"

She gave the usual answer about kindness and patience and not giving up.

Her mouth moved. Her mind drifted somewhere else.

"Last one," the producer said. "What is something that scares you?"

The question caught her off guard.

Something that scares you.

She blinked at the camera. For a moment the room felt too still. Even the soft hum of the lights seemed to fade.

Something that scares you.

Losing control. Losing herself. Hurting the people she cared about. Standing on a stage and finding out her voice would not come when she called for it.

Her pulse thudded in her ears.

"Uh," she started, gripping the edge of the stool. "I think... I think I get scared of not measuring up. To what people expect. Or maybe to what I expect of myself."

The answer came out slower than it should have. Her voice wobbled on the last word. She added a quick laugh, trying to smooth it over, but it sounded thin even to her.

The producer smiled anyway. "That is great. Very honest. Love it."

He was already turning to someone behind the camera. "We will get these cut and to the label tonight."

The camera light clicked off.

Nova rolled her shoulders once, the tension easing enough to notice.

Marcy was beside her in a second. "You good?" she asked softly.

Nova slid off the stool. Her legs felt shaky. "Yeah. Just thirsty."

"Okay. The car is waiting. We will get you back to the hotel. Early night."

Early night sounded good. A room with a door she could close sounded even better.

The hallway outside the studio was narrow and full of wires that ran along the walls. A makeup artist called, "Bye, honey!" as Nova passed. Someone from the label waved and said, "You crushed it."

Reid walked a few steps ahead, clearing the path. He glanced back once, just long enough for his eyes to check her face. Something in his expression tightened, like he noticed the strain she was trying to hide.

A security guard joined him at the door and opened it, guiding them down a ramp toward the parking area.

Phones were out. People were moving fast. Voices bounced off the concrete.

It all blurred together like one long smear of noise and color.

Nova kept her head down, her hood up, and followed Marcy while Reid stayed close enough to reach her if anything shifted.

They reached the black SUV waiting near the exit. The driver stepped out and opened the back door.

"Here we go," Marcy said. "Home base."

Hotel did not feel like home, but it was close enough.

Nova climbed inside and slid across the leather seat. Marcy got in on the other side. Reid closed the door gently behind them before taking

the front passenger seat. A moment later, they pulled away from the curb.

The city rolled past in streaks of gray and glass.

At first, Nova thought she was just tired. Her body sank into the seat. Her shoulders dropped. She let her head rest against the cool glass and watched buildings flicker by.

It was quiet in the car.

The kind of quiet that should feel peaceful but somehow made her skin itch.

The air smelled faintly of whatever cleaner they used on the seats, mixed with a hint of coffee from someone's travel mug. The vents hummed. A soft playlist played low on the radio, some song she usually liked.

A small thought slid across her mind.

What if I never feel normal again.

Her chest tightened.

She straightened a little and took a breath. The breath caught halfway down, as if her lungs had decided they were not interested in doing their job.

Her heartbeat sped up. Too fast.

Another breath. It came out shallow, choppy.

Her fingers tingled. She wiggled them. The sensation did not fade.

You are okay, she told herself. You are in a car. You are safe. You are fine.

The words did not match what her body believed.

The windows felt like they were moving closer, turning the space into a box. The seat belt felt like a strap across her chest, pulling tighter and tighter.

Her thoughts began to race.

What if this is forever.

What if I mess up tomorrow.

What if I cannot sing.

What if everyone sees I am not okay.

What if Elliot saw that video.

What if he is relieved he does not have to deal with her anymore.

“Hey,” Marcy said beside her, voice low. “Nova.”

Nova did not answer. She could not. Her tongue felt heavy. Her mouth was dry. She tried to swallow and it hurt.

“Nova,” Marcy said again. “Look at me.”

Nova turned her head a little, but her eyes did not seem to want to focus. Everything inside her buzzed, like electricity under her skin.

“I cannot breathe,” she whispered.

Marcy’s posture shifted in an instant.

“Okay,” she said, calm and steady. “You are having a panic thing. It is alright. You are breathing. I promise.”

“It feels like I am not,” Nova said. The words broke apart on her tongue.

She pressed a hand to her chest, trying to feel the rise and fall, but all she felt was pounding.

From the front seat, Reid glanced back once, quiet but alert, concern moving across his face before he looked forward again, ready for whatever came next.

“Hey, can you pull over for a second?” Marcy called to the driver.

He glanced at her in the mirror. “Everything all right?”

“Just pull over, please.”

He switched on the signal and eased the car to the side of the road. The motion made Nova’s stomach flip. For a moment she wondered if she was going to be sick.

Marcy shifted so she was angled toward Nova, one knee on the seat.

"Okay, listen to me," she said. "We have been here before, remember? On the last tour, before that late night show in Chicago?"

Nova remembered. She wished she didn't.

"It passed," Marcy said. "And this will too. You are not dying. Your body is on high alert. That is all. It is a fire alarm going off when there is no fire. We just have to wait it out."

Tears slid down Nova's cheeks without warning. She hated crying in front of people, even Marcy. But she could not stop it.

"I cannot do this," she whispered.

"Yes, you can," Marcy said. "You are doing it right now."

"It feels like the car is shrinking."

"That is your brain playing tricks. The car is the same size." Marcy took a slow, exaggerated breath in through her nose and out through her mouth. "Copy me, okay? In for four, out for six."

Nova tried. Her first inhale hit a wall halfway through and turned into a shaky gasp.

"It is okay," Marcy said. "Try again."

They sat there breathing together. In. Out. Again.

The driver turned the music down even lower and pretended to be very focused on his phone, giving them privacy. In the front seat, Reid shifted slightly, not turning around, but alert in a way that said he was listening for anything he needed to handle.

Nova clutched a handful of her sweatshirt so tight her knuckles went white. Sweat gathered at the back of her neck. Her heart still raced.

Her mind jumped around, wild.

You are weak. Don't fall apart. Be grateful.

Somewhere under all that noise, a small memory surfaced. Something Elliot had said once, quiet and certain. That feelings were not failures. That they were signals. That she could bring them to God.

She tried to remember what it felt like to do that. To pray. To trust. To believe someone was holding all of this with her.

Right now it felt like she was holding everything alone.

Her lungs burned. She forced herself to whisper, so quiet she was not sure even Marcy could hear.

“God... please. Please. Please.”

The words felt clumsy, but she said them anyway.

A single breath came a little easier.

Then another.

It did not stop all at once. It was not a movie scene where everything snapped back to normal.

Instead, the panic faded in pieces.

Her heart slowed from pounding to thudding. Her hands went from shaking to trembling. The air in the car felt less sharp, less heavy.

She still felt raw and out of sync.

But she could breathe.

Marcy studied her, eyes soft. “Better?” she asked.

“A little,” Nova said.

“Do you want water?”

Nova nodded. Her throat felt scraped out.

Marcy handed her a bottle from the floor. Nova took a sip and almost choked, then tried again slower.

Outside the window, cars slid past. People walked on the sidewalk. No one had any idea that in this one black SUV, a girl who looked fine on every poster in town had just come close to coming apart.

“Do you want me to call someone from the label?” Marcy asked.

The question hit like cold water.

"No," Nova said quickly. Too quickly. "Please do not."

"Okay."

"I do not want this on some file somewhere," Nova said. "I do not want to be the she-might-break girl."

"You are not that girl," Marcy said.

"Feels like it."

"You are human," Marcy said quietly. "That is not a flaw."

Nova looked down at her hands. The worst of the shaking had stopped. Her fingers still looked like they belonged to someone else.

Marcy's phone buzzed. She glanced at it, then gave Nova an apologetic look.

"It is Greg," she said. "Checking in about the schedule tomorrow. I told him we would hop on a quick call after you finished at the studio."

Nova's stomach clenched.

"I cannot," she said.

"It can be two minutes."

"I cannot," Nova repeated, her voice smaller this time.

Marcy nodded and typed something back, fast.

A few seconds later, her phone buzzed again.

"He says it is important," Marcy said gently. "They want to adjust the set for the streaming thing. New arrangement. He wanted your take."

Nova felt the weight of it. The responsibility. The expectation that she would be sharp and steady on command.

The thought of having to sound focused on a call made her chest tighten again.

"Tell him I fell asleep," she said.

"Nova..."

"Please."

Marcy hesitated, then set her jaw and started typing.

“Okay,” she said. “You are officially asleep. I told him you did great today and crashed the moment we hit the car.”

“Liar,” Nova muttered.

“Professional liar,” Marcy said. “It is part of the job description.”

A weak smile tugged at the corner of Nova’s mouth, even as guilt washed over her.

It was a small thing. One call. One quick change she was skipping.

But it felt like the first time she had let something fall on purpose.

She wondered what Greg would think. If he would start to see her as a problem to manage instead of a person he believed in.

From the front seat, Reid shifted slightly, sensing the tension behind him, but stayed silent. This was not his moment to fix. It was hers to survive.

“I will have something later,” Nova said, though none of them believed it.

For a few still seconds, the car moved forward gently, giving her space to settle.

Reid glanced at her in the mirror. “We are almost there,” he said softly.

Nova nodded.

The hum of the tires and the muted city outside blended into something she could lean against without needing to explain anything.

When the hotel came into view, the driver eased the SUV toward the curb. The familiar awning and warm lights felt both close and impossibly far.

Reid stepped out first and scanned the sidewalk.

Then Nova followed.

“You want food?” Marcy asked as they walked inside. “Room service. Something easy.”

“I am not hungry.”

"You have barely eaten."

Nova shook her head. "Not right now."

Reid stayed a few steps behind, giving her space but watching with quiet concern.

Marcy walked beside her through the lobby. Fans were not allowed here. Security made sure of that. The quiet should have felt safe.

It did not.

At the elevator, Marcy reached out and squeezed Nova's arm.

"I am in the room next door," she said. "If you need me, knock. Or text. Or throw something at the wall. I will hear it."

Nova nodded.

"Say it out loud," Marcy added gently. "So your brain believes it."

Nova swallowed. "If I need you," she whispered, "I will call."

"Good," Marcy said. "Because you are allowed to need somebody, you know."

The elevator arrived with a soft chime. Reid stepped in first, checking corners out of habit, then held the door while Nova and Marcy stepped inside.

Nova stood near the back wall. Her reflection stared back from the mirrored panels.

Just a girl in a hoodie trying to look steady while two people stood guard around her.

Reid pressed the button for their floor. He stayed near the panel, quiet and alert. Marcy stood close enough to her side that Nova could feel the warmth of her presence.

The elevator rose, humming under their feet. Nova watched the lights above the door blink from one number to the next. The movement felt slow and fast at the same time, as if her body had not decided how to feel about stillness yet.

When they reached her floor, Reid stepped out first. He scanned the hallway, then nodded.

“Clear,” he said.

Marcy touched her elbow gently. “Almost there.”

They walked down the carpeted hallway together. Reid kept a respectful distance behind them, but he did not drift far. When they reached her door, he unlocked it with her key card, then stepped aside so she could enter.

“You are good from here?” he asked, voice low.

Nova nodded. “Thank you.”

Reid gave a small nod back. “I am right down the hall if you need anything.”

Nova stepped inside. The door clicked shut behind her.

In her room, the silence felt huge.

She set her phone on the nightstand and did not pick it up again. She did not turn on the TV. She did not put on music.

She sat on the edge of the bed, elbows on her knees, fingers laced so tight they hurt.

She tried to pray again, for more than a breath and a word. But everything felt tangled.

Thank you. Help me. I am sorry. Please.

None of it came out right.

So she said nothing at all.

Outside the window, somewhere below, the city moved and hummed and sparkled.

Somewhere else, Elliot was probably doing ordinary things. Making dinner. Folding laundry. Standing in a church hallway, talking to someone who did not know her name.

She wondered if he could feel it somehow. This invisible thread stretching between them, thin and frayed.

Nova lay back on the bed and stared at the ceiling.

Today had given her a new kind of fear. Not of the internet. Not of the stage.

Fear that her own body and mind had a limit she was closer to than anyone realized.

Fear that if one car ride could knock her off balance like this, the big things still ahead might scatter her completely.

She pulled the blanket over herself, even though she was not cold, and listened to the sound of her heartbeat slowly, slowly settling into something that almost felt steady again.

Today had not broken her.

But it had shown her how close she was to the edge.

And as she closed her eyes, she knew something clear and sharp.

Whatever came next, fine was not going to be enough anymore.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

"I kept waiting for it to break. It didn't."

- Nova Hart, untitled

The roar of the Berlin crowd still lingered in Nova's bones long after the last chord faded. It clung to her skin like stage glitter, impossible to shake off completely. When she stepped backstage, the corridor felt too narrow, the lights too bright, and the congratulations from crew members too loud to take in.

"Great show, Nova."

"Crushed it tonight."

"You looked incredible out there."

She nodded at each comment, offering a soft smile, but the words slid off her like water. Her ears still rang with adrenaline. Her breath stayed shallow, refusing to deepen. Her steps wavered on the polished concrete as she moved toward her dressing room.

Someone handed her a bouquet of roses from a sponsor. She took them, thanked the assistant, and kept walking. The petals brushed her arm, cool and delicate. She shifted the bouquet higher against her chest, suddenly aware of its weight.

A small meet area off the hall held a few fans who had been escorted in. They clutched posters and vinyl, smiling nervously, eyes bright with hope.

Normally she would stop. She would push through the exhaustion, pose for photos, and offer a smile that rarely reached her eyes.

Tonight, she could not do it.

She leaned toward the assistant managing the line. "Tell them I will send each of them a personalized video tomorrow and sign everything they brought," Nova murmured. "I just need a moment to breathe."

He nodded, sympathetic. "Of course."

She slipped away before anyone else could stop her.

Inside her dressing room, she closed the door, leaned back against it, and let the silence catch her. The air smelled like makeup wipes, fresh hairspray, and the faint sweetness of the roses she set on the counter.

Her entire body sagged. The energy she poured onto the stage was gone, spent somewhere between the last chorus and the final bow. Her hands trembled as she unclipped the microphone pack at her waist.

The mirror showed her in pieces.

Mascara smudged faintly beneath her eyes. The glitter on her cheeks had dulled, catching the light unevenly. The sequined costume still sparkled, but her face did not keep up with it.

She did not recognize how quickly the night had settled into her skin.

Nova sank onto the vanity stool and pulled the elastic from her hair. It fell in loose, tangled waves. Strands clung to her temple. Her pulse thudded in her throat.

She inhaled slowly.

Exhaled.

Nothing eased.

Her mind replayed every mistake. A missed harmony. A small stumble. A line that went blank for half a beat before she grabbed it again. She had covered everything, but each moment felt like a fracture in a wall already thinning.

She rubbed her arms, trying to ground herself.

Her phone sat on the table, face down.

She knew who lived on the other end of her silence.

She reached for it, then let her hand fall.

“Not tonight,” she whispered.

But her chest ached anyway.

A soft knock came at the door.

“Yeah?” Nova said, flat.

Marcy stepped inside, headphones around her neck, clipboard tucked under one arm. Her eyes darted across Nova’s face.

“You good?” Marcy asked.

Nova shook her head. “I honestly do not know.”

Marcy closed the door and crossed the room. She set the clipboard down and slid off her heels with a soft thud.

“You look like everything is turned up too loud,” Marcy said gently.

“That is exactly how I feel.”

Marcy dragged a chair closer and sat. “Talk to me. What is going on?”

Nova wrapped her arms around herself. “I can’t find any quiet inside it. Even with the door closed.”

“Show nights can do that.”

“No,” Nova said quietly. “This is different.”

Marcy studied her. “How long has this been happening?”

“Since before Paris. Maybe longer.” Nova rubbed her forehead. “I keep telling myself it is part of the job. Or stress. Or exhaustion. But I feel like I am falling out of my own life.”

"Nova, that is not normal."

"I know."

"You should have said something sooner."

"I did not want to be dramatic."

"You are not dramatic. You are overwhelmed." Marcy nodded toward Nova's hands. "And you are shaking."

Nova looked down.

She was.

She pressed her palms against her thighs until the tremor softened.

Marcy leaned forward. "Is this about the show? Or the pressure? Or something else?"

Nova hesitated.

Then she reached for her phone without turning it over.

Marcy's gaze softened. "You are thinking about him again."

Nova did not answer. She did not need to.

Marcy exhaled slowly. "You have been carrying too much alone. And you finally hit the point where you cannot pretend anymore."

Nova looked at her reflection. The makeup smudged beneath her eyes. "I miss him," she whispered.

"I know."

"I miss how calm he was. How normal he made everything feel."

"I know."

"I miss the way he talked to me like a person and not a product."

Marcy nodded, quiet.

"And I hate that I let it fall apart," Nova said. "I hate that I stopped talking to him. I hate that I disappeared and acted like I was okay."

"You disappeared because you were scared," Marcy said. "And because too much was happening at once."

"I should have explained."

"You were drowning. No one explains while they are drowning."

Nova stared down at her hands. "I want to reach out. But I do not know what to say."

"That usually means you already know exactly what you need to say."

Nova let out a short, broken laugh. "Reaching out feels like a bad idea."

"Why?"

"Because if he answers, I will fall apart."

"And if he does not answer."

Nova winced. "I do not know which would hurt more."

Nova looked at her phone again.

"I keep thinking about what comes next," Nova said quietly.

Marcy watched her. "What do you mean?"

"Every show. Every city. Every expectation. People think I should feel honored and grateful and thrilled. But all I feel is trapped. Like I am being squeezed from every side."

"You are allowed to feel that," Marcy said gently.

"Tonight I kept wondering what it would be like to step away for a little while," Nova whispered. "Not quit. Just breathe."

"That is not weakness," Marcy said. "That is survival."

Nova swallowed hard. "But if I take a break, people will say I am unstable."

"People will say anything to fill their own time," Marcy said. "Let them talk."

"It is not that simple."

"I know it is not. But none of this is simple. Not your work. Not your heart. Not the things you carry."

Nova pressed her palms against her eyes. "I feel like everyone has a piece of me. Fans. Labels. Media. My aunt. Even strangers online. But the parts I need for myself feel so thin."

"And who do you think sees those parts," Marcy asked gently.

Nova lowered her hands. "Elliot."

"And that is why he scares you," Marcy said. "Because he sees the real you."

Nova nodded.

"And that is why you want to talk to him," Marcy continued.

"I am tired of giving the world the version of me that is polished and packaged. He is the only one who gets the version that is real."

Nova took a shaky breath.

"This is not about romance or declarations," Marcy said. "This is about honesty. About connection. That is allowed."

Nova traced the edge of her phone. "He probably moved on."

"No," Marcy said. "He has not."

"You do not know that."

"I know Elliot," Marcy said. "And I know how he looked at you. That kind of thing does not disappear."

Nova's throat tightened.

"I do not want to pull him into chaos," she whispered.

"You are not pulling him into anything," Marcy said. "You are inviting him into a moment that is real."

If she did not speak soon, she felt like she might lose the chance entirely.

Marcy watched her for a long moment. "You don't have to decide anything tonight," she said quietly. "You just have to stop pretending this doesn't matter."

Nova stared at the ceiling. Then the floor. Then the phone.

"I still don't know what to say."

"That is okay," Marcy said. "Sometimes knowing why you want to speak has to come before knowing how."

Nova hesitated, the words backing up behind her teeth. “The truth is... I’m lonely.”

Marcy nodded. “Then that’s something to be honest about. Even if only with yourself for now.”

Nova swallowed. The phone felt warm in her hand, heavier than before. She didn’t unlock it.

“What if I say the wrong thing?” she whispered.

Marcy stood. “Then you will. And you will survive that too.”

Nova leaned back against the mirror and closed her eyes. The roar of the Berlin crowd finally began to fade, leaving behind something quieter and more unsettling.

The night waited.

So did the truth.

She opened her phone.

The thread was still there.

Unbroken.

Waiting.

Her thumb hovered over his name.

For a long moment, she did nothing.

Then she typed.

Three words.

Are you awake?

She stared at them.

Breath shallow.

And pressed send.

The message whooshed upward.

And something shifted above it.

A time stamp.

Earlier.

From him.

Her pulse stuttered.

She hadn't seen it.

Four words.

Are you actually okay?

The room tilted slightly.

He had already chosen.

CHAPTER THIRTY-SEVEN

"You are not a souvenir."

- **Nova Hart, untitled**

The message showed as delivered.

Nova stared at the screen like it might explode.

Are you awake?

Three small dots appeared almost immediately.

Her pulse jumped.

Yes.

That was it.

Not a paragraph. Not a question. Just steady presence.

Her throat tightened. She hadn't realized how much she'd braced for silence until it didn't come.

Her thumbs hovered over the screen.

I didn't mean to text that late.

She erased it.

I'm sorry.

She erased that too.

The phone buzzed in her hand.

Incoming call.

Elliot.

For a split second, panic flared. This was too fast. Too real. Hearing his voice would undo the thin control she had been holding together all night.

She let it ring once.

Twice.

Then she answered.

"Hi," she said, and hated how small it sounded.

"Hi," he replied.

His voice was the same. Low. Calm. Not surprised. Not accusing.

Just there.

They were quiet for a second, both listening to the other breathe.

"I wasn't sure you would answer," she admitted.

"I wasn't sure you would text," he said gently.

That almost made her laugh. Almost.

"I'm sorry," she said.

"For what?"

"For disappearing. For asking for space and then ... actually taking it."

He didn't rush to fill the silence. He never did.

"You said you needed space," he said. "I tried to honor that."

"I know."

Her free hand pressed against her chest without thinking.

"I thought I could manage everything if I just worked harder," she said. "If I stayed focused. If I didn't ... feel so much."

"And did that work?" he asked.

She let out a thin breath. "No."

There it was. The crack.

"I had a panic episode in the car tonight," she said, the words tumbling before she could stop them. "I couldn't breathe. I thought I was losing my mind. And all I could think about was how calm you always are. And how much I miss that."

She closed her eyes, embarrassed by how raw it sounded.

"I miss who I am when I talk to you," she whispered.

The line hung between them.

On the other end, Elliot exhaled.

"I miss you too," he said.

He didn't dress it up. He didn't soften it.

Just truth.

Tears burned behind her eyes, but they didn't spill over.

"I didn't reach out because I didn't want to pull you into chaos," she said. "Everything feels loud. Complicated. I didn't want to hurt you."

"You don't get to decide that by yourself," he said quietly.

The words weren't sharp. Just steady.

"You don't get to decide what I'm strong enough to walk through."

Her throat tightened.

"I'm not steady right now," she admitted.

"You don't have to be," he said. "You just have to be honest."

She let the silence stretch again, but this time it felt different. Not empty. Held.

"I don't know what this looks like," she said. "Us. With everything the way it is."

"Neither do I," he answered. "But I know stepping away didn't make it easier."

"No."

"And I know fear isn't a good reason to stay silent."

She swallowed.

"I'm scared," she said.

"I know."

"I'm tired of pretending I'm fine."

"I know you are."

She let out a shaky breath that almost turned into a laugh.

"You always say that."

"Because it's usually true."

The sound of him smiling loosened something she had been holding for weeks.

"I don't need you to fix this," she said carefully. "I just ... didn't want to feel alone tonight."

"You're not," he said.

Three simple words.

They landed heavier than applause.

He was quiet more than he spoke. She could hear the faint clink of a mug once. A door closing somewhere in his house. They drifted from the panic in the car to Berlin to the scared girl in the crowd.

Then to Clara.

Then to nothing in particular at all.

The kind of nothing that only exists when neither person is trying to impress the other.

She leaned back against the pillows, letting the tension drain from her shoulders.

“Thank you for picking up,” she said.

“I told you before,” he replied. “If you reach, I’ll answer.”

Her chest tightened at that.

They didn’t make promises. They didn’t solve logistics. They didn’t talk about headlines or tour schedules or what anyone else would say.

They just stayed.

When the call finally began to wind down, it was because her breathing had steadied, not because either of them had run out of words.

There was a pause.

“Nova,” he said gently.

“Yeah?”

“I’m here. I just can’t do this in pieces.”

She swallowed.

“Okay,” she said quietly.

“I should try to sleep.”

“Are you ... okay?” she asked.

There was a slight pause.

“I’m working on it,” he said honestly.

She nodded, even though he couldn’t see it.

“Goodnight, Elliot.”

“Goodnight, Nova.”

She ended the call slowly, staring at the dark screen in her hand.

The silence felt different.

She set the phone on the nightstand and lay back against the pillows.

The room was still quiet.

She closed her eyes. They were okay. He had stayed.
But the line replayed anyway.

I just can't do this in pieces.

Her brow tightened slightly.

Pieces.

The word lingered longer than it should have.
She turned onto her side, staring at the dark window.
He hadn't sounded angry. He hadn't sounded wounded.
He had sounded steady.
And suddenly she understood something she hadn't before.
He wasn't asking for rescue.
He wasn't offering to disappear.
He was refusing to be optional.
Her throat tightened.
She had reached for him when she was lonely. Gone silent when
the world got loud. Stepped back when it required courage.
The realization didn't feel dramatic.
It felt quiet.
Embarrassingly clear.
She swallowed.
A line surfaced before she could stop it.

You are not a souvenir.

She stared at the ceiling.
The word *souvenir* settled heavy in her chest.

Not something shiny.

Not something she picked up when she was passing through.

Her pulse steadied.

This wasn't about panic.

It wasn't about Berlin.

It was about choosing.

And for the first time, she knew she couldn't keep choosing him
halfway.

The night pressed in around her.

Wide awake.

So was she.

CHAPTER THIRTY-EIGHT

You are not a souvenir that I pick up when I am dashing through town,
Not something shiny to make me forget the people I am around.

If I am a novelty, then why do you look at me that way?

Like I'm someone you try to let go, but can't quite push away.

- Nova Hart, from the chorus of "Novelty"

Unreleased draft

Nova woke before her alarm, the thin gray light of early morning pressing through the narrow gap in the curtains. For a moment she stayed still, listening to the muted sounds of the hotel. Pipes clicking. An elevator humming somewhere down the hall. A distant siren dissolving into the city.

They had talked too long for sleep.

Not about solutions. Not about fixing anything. Just about staying.

She sat up slowly and reached for her notebook, pulling it from the bag where she had shoved it the night before. The pages fell open easily, like they had been waiting for her. She read the chorus again, the words

written in a hand that slanted where she had been tired and steadied where she had been honest.

It did not feel finished.

It did not feel solved.

But it felt true.

She pressed the notebook flat against her stomach and shifted, easing the tightness enough to notice it had been there. The room did not feel peaceful. It felt quiet in a way that could tip either direction if she moved too fast.

"I'm still here," she whispered, mostly to herself.

She stood, stretched the stiffness from her shoulders, and dressed without ceremony. Joggers. Sneakers. A hoodie that did not belong to the show or the label or the night before. She did not look at her phone. Not yet. She did not want the world deciding the shape of her morning.

Downstairs, the venue buzzed with familiar chaos. Cables crisscrossed the concrete. Someone cursed softly about a missing adapter. A drum mic screeched and then cut out.

It all pressed in at once, loud and sharp and alive.

Sound check came and went. Her voice held. Her hands shook once and then steadied. A guitarist missed a cue and she laughed instead of apologizing for existing. Greg watched her like he was trying to solve a puzzle without touching it.

Marcy was already moving toward her before the last note faded.

"You wrote," she murmured as they crossed paths near the monitors.

Nova did not deny it. She just shrugged, a small, private movement.

Marcy smiled. "Good. That usually means you're listening again."

Backstage before the show, Nova sat instead of pacing. The crowd's murmur seeped through the walls, a living thing waiting to rise. Ener-

gy gathered low in her body, restless but contained, the kind that could tip either direction if she rushed it.

But it did not knock her flat.

When they called five minutes, she stood easily. When they called one, she breathed instead of bracing.

When she stepped into the lights, the arena erupted.

The sound hit her full in the chest. Cheers. Screams. The shimmer of movement and noise and expectation. For a split second, the familiar vertigo flickered at the edges of her vision.

Then she planted her feet.

She did not rush.

She did not shrink.

She sang.

The music carried her instead of swallowing her. She let the spaces between lines exist. Let the crowd fill them. Let herself be seen without gripping so tightly.

A glittery sign rose from the crowd midway through the set.

MARRY ME NOVA.

She laughed, genuinely, and the crowd roared back. For a brief moment, an image surfaced uninvited. Elliot's quiet smile. The way he would have lifted an eyebrow and said something dry about proposals requiring coffee first.

The thought passed.

It did not unravel her.

Then she saw the girl.

Pressed against the barrier. Too young for the noise. Hands shaking as she held up a sign made of crooked letters and marker hearts.

THIS IS MY FIRST CONCERT. I AM SCARED.

Nova did not hesitate.

She moved to the edge of the stage and waved security forward. The arena hushed as the girl was lifted carefully up. Nova knelt, slow and deliberate, keeping her movements gentle so nothing startled her.

The stage lights softened.

Nova took the girl's hands. They were cold.

"You're okay," Nova said, her mic still live. "I've got you."

The fear did not disappear.

It loosened its grip just long enough for her to breathe.

They were not new words. They were borrowed. Carried from a place inside her that still ached when she touched it.

She felt it — the echo of him — and let it be there without pulling away.

They sang just four lines together. The girl's voice trembled, then steadied. The crowd swayed with them, thousands of people holding the same breath.

When it ended, Nova pressed her forehead briefly to the girl's hair.

"Thank you for being brave," she whispered.

The roar that followed shook the stage.

Backstage, Nova trembled — not from panic, but from release she did not fully understand yet.

"You stayed," Marcy said quietly, arms tight around her.

Nova exhaled. She hadn't known how close she'd come to not doing that.

Later, alone in her room, the adrenaline faded into a deep, bone-heavy exhaustion. She showered. She sat on the edge of the bed with her notebook open again, staring at the lines she had written earlier.

Her phone lay beside her.

She picked it up.

The thread was no longer empty.

Are you awake?

Yes

Below it, the missed call marker from earlier. The timestamp. The evidence that she had not imagined any of it.

She didn't open the thread.

She didn't need to.

They had talked.

Not about the future. Not about promises. Just about staying steady in the moment.

She held the phone in her hand longer than she meant to.

Not afraid.

Not rushing.

Just aware.

He had said he couldn't do this in pieces.

And she finally understood that meant something for her too.

She had reached for him when she was unraveling.

Called when she was lonely.

Fallen quiet when the noise returned.

He hadn't asked her to fix everything.

He hadn't asked her to promise forever.

He had asked her not to make him convenient.

Her throat tightened.

She unlocked the phone.

The thread opened easily.

Her thumbs hovered.

Not shaking this time.

Not desperate.

She typed slowly.

I don't want to do this in pieces.

She read it once.

Then again.

She didn't erase it.

But she didn't send it either.

Not tonight.

Not from adrenaline.

Not from fear.

She set the phone beside her.

The message waited.

So did he.

The night pressed in around her.

Wide awake.

So was she.

CHAPTER THIRTY-NINE

"I don't want you in pieces either."

– **Nova Hart, untitled**

Time moved in tour rhythm after that night.

Two more cities. Three more shows. Hotel rooms that blurred together. Soundchecks that began to feel like punctuation marks instead of beginnings. Nova stayed busy. She kept writing when the world finally quieted enough to hear herself think. She did not reach out. She did not undo what she had chosen.

Elliot did the same.

Morning settled softly along the coast. The light outside his bedroom window came in gray and pale, the kind that did not ask anything from him. He lay still longer than usual, one hand resting on his chest, listening to the ocean through the open window.

In.

Out.

The tide moved the way it always had. Steady. Unbothered by human hesitation.

He hesitated. Then he opened the news alert he had been ignoring since last night. Nova's latest post sat at the top. A clip from Berlin. A single spotlight. Her name in white letters over black.

He could scroll past it.

He didn't.

He tapped the video.

The footage was shaky, filmed from somewhere deep in the crowd. The sound wavered as the person holding the phone adjusted their grip. Lights flared, then settled.

Nova stood alone under a warm circle of light, guitar resting against her hip. She did not smile right away. She took a breath that looked careful, gathered.

"This song is for anyone who keeps saying they're fine," she said softly, "even when they're not."

Her voice entered the space like a confession.

You are not a souvenir that I pick up when I am dashing through town,

Not something shiny to make me forget the people I am around.

Recognition moved through him before the second line finished.

If I'm a novelty, then why do you look at me that way,

Like I'm someone you try to let go, but can't quite push away.

The audio crackled. Someone nearby sniffed. The crowd noise faded beneath her voice, like the room itself was leaning in.

Nova did not move much as she sang. No choreography. No performance polish. Just stillness and sound and something unguarded in her eyes.

The song ended without flourish. She exhaled once, lowered her gaze, and stepped back from the microphone.

The video cut off.

Elliot set the phone down and stared at the ceiling.

Something tight pressed behind his ribs.

Truth.

He had not stepped away because it was wise. Not entirely.

He had stepped away because fear had learned how to speak in careful language.

He whispered into the quiet, barely louder than the tide.

"God ... help me stop calling fear faith."

The words stripped away a lie he had been leaning on and left everything else exposed.

He made coffee and stepped onto the porch. The morning air was cool and clean. The ocean stretched out in soft gray bands, patient as ever.

He thought about Clara.

By the time she answered, the school day had already begun.

"Hey, Dad," she said. "Everything okay?"

"I watched her new song," he said.

There was a pause. "And?"

"It unsettled me," he admitted. "In a way I think matters."

Clara exhaled. "Dad—"

"I know," he said gently. "I'm not saying anything needs to happen. I just... realized I haven't been as brave as I told myself I was."

She leaned back in her chair, the prep room quiet around her between periods. "Being careful is not the same as being afraid."

"Sometimes it is," he said quietly.

Clara's jaw tightened. "You came apart last time. I saw it. You cannot pretend that didn't happen."

"I'm not pretending."

"Then why does it sound like you're trying to talk yourself back into something that hurt you?"

Elliot didn't answer right away.

"Because pretending I don't want it is hurting too," he said finally.

Clara closed her eyes for a moment. When she opened them, the worry was still there.

"She lives in chaos," Clara said. "And you live in quiet. That didn't magically stop being true."

"No," he agreed. "It didn't."

"And she's still in the middle of it," Clara continued. "Tours. Cameras. Opinions. You can't fix that by wanting something enough."

"I know."

Clara studied him. "Then what do you want, exactly?"

He thought about the song. About the stillness onstage. About the ache that had been easier to ignore when he called it wisdom.

"I want to stop hiding," he said. "That's all I know right now."

Clara didn't soften. Not fully.

"That's not a plan," she said. "That's a feeling."

"I'm not asking you to agree," he replied. "I just didn't want to lie to you."

She nodded once, tight. "I need time," she said. "This doesn't feel settled to me."

"It isn't," he said.

When the call ended, Elliot stood on the porch for a long time. The ocean moved. The sky lightened. Nothing rushed him.

Later, he opened a note he had started days ago and never finished. Typed carefully. Deleted nothing this time.

I don't want you in pieces either.

He stared at the words.

They felt exposed. Unpolished. True.

He did not send them.

But he did not erase them.

He saved the note and slipped the phone into his pocket.

Not retreat.

Not performance.

Just honesty, waiting.

He walked toward the water. The tide met his ankles, cold and grounding.

“I want to be brave,” he murmured into the wind.

The ocean answered the only way it ever did.

In.

Out.

And for the first time, he wasn't hiding behind it.

CHAPTER FORTY

I walked through your door in that seaside town
Not knowing one glance would pull my whole guard down
Your arm on my back made every nerve feel warm
A truth the camera caught before I faced the storm
- Nova Hart, from "Novelty," unreleased draft

The dressing room settled into its usual after-show hush.

A smear of glitter on the counter. A single false eyelash clinging to the sink. Makeup sponges tossed aside without ceremony. The quiet that always arrived after the noise had burned itself out.

Nova sat in front of the mirror with her knees pulled to her chest. Her eyeliner had smudged at the corners, softening her face. She looked tired. Grounded. Like someone who had given something real and did not yet know the cost.

The room still held the warmth of stage lights. The air conditioner buzzed faintly. Her heartbeat sounded louder than everything.

Her phone rested beside her water bottle, screen down.

She did not want the world yet.

The lock clicked and Marcy slipped inside.

"You lived," Marcy said, tossing her a towel. "Basic goal achieved."

Nova smiled faintly. "Was it that obvious I was surviving out there?"

"No," Marcy said. "It was obvious you meant it. Those are different things."

Nova pressed the towel to the back of her neck. "I feel like I ran something long and uphill."

"You did," Marcy said. "Emotionally. Spiritually. Vocally. Pick a lane."

Nova laughed under her breath and rolled her shoulders, trying to loosen the ache.

Marcy studied her reflection in the mirror.

"You okay?" she asked.

Nova considered it. Then shook her head once. "Not okay. But steady."

Marcy's brow lifted. "That one's new."

Nova glanced at her phone, still untouched. "I don't feel like I'm hiding anymore."

Marcy nodded slowly. "That's different."

Nova turned the phone face up.

Notifications crowded the screen. Clips already circulating. Messages she would not read yet.

One name sat alone at the top.

Elliot.

No emojis. No qualifiers. Just one message, sent an hour earlier.

I heard the song.

Nova's breath caught.

Her thumb hovered, instinct rising fast — to explain, to soften, to reach.

She stopped herself.

Marcy said nothing. She didn't need to.

Nova set the phone down again, face up this time, like she wasn't afraid of it anymore. Just cautious.

Another message appeared.

And I prayed for you tonight.

Nova closed her eyes.

Just truth.

Her throat tightened. She pressed her palm flat against her chest, feeling the steadiness she had fought for all night.

A third message came.

I'm not asking anything. I just wanted you to know I saw you.

That was all.

No questions. No plans. No leaning forward.

The restraint landed heavy — and holy.

Nova looked at Marcy. "He didn't run."

Marcy nodded. "Neither did you."

Nova picked up the phone again, holding it carefully, like something alive.

She typed. Deleted. Typed again. Paused.

Then:

Thank you for seeing me. I'm tired. But tonight felt honest.

She stared at it for a long moment.

Then sent it.

The reply did not come immediately.

When it did, it was simple.

Honest usually costs something. I'm glad you paid it.

Nova let out a slow breath. Not relief. Recognition.

She did not write back.

Not because she didn't want to.

Because she was learning the difference between reaching and grasping.

Across the country, Elliot sat at his kitchen table with his Bible still open where he had left it.

The house was quiet. Not empty. Waiting.

He stared at the phone in his hand, the message thread glowing softly.

He had typed and erased three different versions before sending anything at all.

He had prayed first. Not for her response, for his restraint.

God, don't let me turn longing into urgency.

When her message arrived, he closed his eyes.

Not relief.

Alignment.

He typed his reply slowly, deliberately, then set the phone face down on the table.

He did not reach for it again.

Outside, the ocean moved in its steady rhythm. The tide did not rush itself.

Neither would he.

Back in the dressing room, Nova showered quickly and changed into soft clothes. Her body still hummed with the echo of the crowd, but her mind felt quieter than it had in weeks.

She lay back on the bed and stared at the ceiling.

She had not fixed anything.

She had not chosen anything.

But she had stopped pretending she didn't want something real.

That felt like the beginning of courage.

She closed her eyes, the melody of "Novelty" still moving through her like something that already knew its answer.

Not yet.

But soon.

And for tonight, that was enough.

CHAPTER FORTY-ONE

"For the first time, the ocean did not steady him."

– **Nova Hart, untitled**

Morning light leaked through the gap in the hotel curtains and settled against the edge of Nova's bed. She woke without the familiar jolt of panic, stayed still, and let the quiet prove itself real.

Her chest rose and fell, steady and unhurried, with no tremor or rush of icy fear. Just breath.

She reached for her phone on the nightstand. The screen lit with Elliot's messages from the night before.

I heard the song.

And I prayed for you tonight.

I'm not asking anything. I just wanted you to know I saw you.

Her throat tightened. She held the phone to her heart.

"Lead this," she whispered. "Not fear. No performance. Just You."

The phone buzzed in her hand.

Elliot Brooks.

Nova sat up fast, as if sitting could steady her courage. She answered before doubt could catch up.

"Hi," she said, breath soft.

"Hi," Elliot replied. His voice was warm, careful, as if he was holding something breakable. "I didn't know if you'd be awake."

"I am awake," she said. "More than I expected."

He chuckled softly. "Good."

A gentle pause settled between them, long enough for her shoulders to ease.

"How are you this morning?" he asked.

"Tired," she said. "But calm. And that feels ... new."

"It's new," he said. "And I'm grateful for it."

"What about you?" she asked.

"I feel hopeful," he said. "And nervous. I'm letting both be true."

Nova suppressed a smile. "You can do that," she said.

He paused, then spoke with soft sincerity. "Nova, your bravery last night was very meaningful to me."

Her eyes stung. "Thank you."

"I want us to be careful," he said. "Not because we're afraid. Because this matters."

"Slow," she said. "Steady."

"We rebuild first."

"Yes."

Silence settled again, careful in the way both of them held it.

"I miss you," she said finally.

He exhaled. "I've felt the quiet without you."

Another pause.

"After tomorrow's performance," he said, "we decide what comes next."

Nova's shoulders loosened, then stilled, as if her body had expected more and did not know what to do with the quiet instead.

"Okay," she said.

"Okay," he echoed.

She ended the call and pressed the phone to her forehead, breathing until the tightness in her chest eased enough to stand.

Marcy slipped into the room. "You look like someone just exhaled for the first time all week," she said.

Nova let out a breath that sounded almost like a laugh. "I talked to him."

Marcy grinned softly. "And you look steadier. That is a good sign."

A few minutes later, Greg appeared in the doorway with a coffee in hand, hair still messy from too little sleep. "Morning, star child. Scale of one to ten, how emotionally fragile are we today?"

Nova lifted her chin. "Actually... I am okay."

Greg stared at her like she had announced she was moving to the moon. "Interesting. Suspicious. But interesting."

Nova took a slow breath. "Greg... during my break, I might want to go somewhere quiet," she said carefully. "Not to escape. Just ... to stay honest."

Greg raised one eyebrow. "Let me guess. Oceanside. And some old guy you once described in a way that made Marcy spit out her coffee. With a daughter who made it very clear she was watching. Am I following?"

Nova covered her face with her hand. "Greg."

"What? I am only using the material you gave me," he said. "I take notes. It is a survival tactic."

Marcy snorted. "He really does."

Nova lowered her hand. "Greg... I want to see him intentionally. Slowly. Not like before."

Greg studied her for a long moment. "If you go to Oceanside," he said quietly, "it won't stay private."

Nova nodded. "I know."

"Then we won't hide it," he said.

She held his gaze. "I'm not hiding anymore."

Greg exhaled. "Then go with your eyes open."

Nova let out a short laugh and shook her head. "Thank you."

"Do not thank me yet," Greg said. "Thank me when this man is worth the circus I am about to walk into for you."

Marcy lifted her coffee cup. "This is not a circus."

Nova gave her a flat look. "Too soon."

Greg nodded approvingly. "Thank you. My point exactly."

Nova laughed, surprised by the sound of it.

"You look clearer today," Greg said.

Nova nodded. "I am."

Elliot ended the call and remained seated at the kitchen table, phone still in his hand.

Hope felt lighter than it had in weeks. Fragile. Real.

The phone buzzed again.

Clara.

He stared at her name longer than he should have.

Then answered.

"I saw it," she said.

No greeting. No softness.

Elliot leaned back in his chair. "The headline?"

"Yes."

Silence stretched between them, tighter than the one he had just left.

"I told you this would not stay private," she said. Not angry. Controlled. Which was worse.

"I know."

"Do you?" Her voice thinned. "Because this is exactly what I was afraid of."

He closed his eyes briefly. "Clara—"

"You said you were being careful," she continued. "You said you were protecting your peace. This doesn't look careful."

"It wasn't planned."

"That doesn't make it safer."

The words landed.

"I'm not trying to be reckless," he said quietly.

"No," she replied. "You're trying to be brave."

He swallowed hard.

"And sometimes," she said, voice cracking despite her effort, "your bravery costs me."

"I don't want you hurt," he said.

"I already was," she answered. "Last time."

Silence again.

Not gentle. Not calm.

Honest.

"I need to know this isn't just hope you're calling faith."

He opened his mouth.

Closed it again.

The ocean moved outside the open window.

In.

Out.

For the first time, the ocean did not steady him.

CHAPTER FORTY-TWO

"I already lose something every time
I erase someone else to protect myself."

– **Nova Hart, untitled**

The call came before noon.

Nova was still near the window when Marcy's phone rang again. Marcy answered without looking away from her.

"Yes," she said. "I understand."

She listened a moment longer, jaw tightening, then added, "Give us thirty minutes."

After ending the call, she faced Nova directly.

"That was your label," she said. "They're done waiting."

Nova crossed her arms. "For what?"

"For alignment," Marcy said. She folded her hands, precise. "They need to feel confident about what comes next."

Nova let out a quick breath. "I think that already happened."

Marcy did not smile. "They want cooperation."

There it was.

Not truth.

Not care.

Cooperation.

“What does that look like?” Nova asked.

“A statement drafted by legal,” Marcy said. “Careful language. No names. No confirmations. No denials that can be proven false. Just enough distance to slow the cycle.”

“And if I don’t?”

Marcy hesitated.

“They move without you,” she said. “They can suspend promotion. Freeze interviews. Quietly cool support.”

Nova turned back to the window. The crowd outside had thickened, bodies pressing shoulder to shoulder. Phones hovered above heads, their screens glowing white. Camera lenses caught the light and flashed as security waved people back, radios crackling over the noise.

Waiting had calmed nothing. It had focused it.

Her phone buzzed.

Elliot.

Any movement

She typed back.

Yes.

They are closing in.

On both of us.

At his kitchen table, Elliot stared at his phone. He had not moved since sitting down.

The group text from church leadership was still open. Two elders. The senior pastor. Another message sat unread from the youth ministry coordinator.

Elliot responded.

What are they asking of you?

They don't want answers.

They want quiet.

The kind that looks obedient on a screen.

Elliot exhaled slowly and typed.

I'm getting the same request

Different voices. Same meaning.

From who?

Church leadership.

They're asking me to avoid commenting

To "protect testimony."

Nova swallowed.

They want reassurance....

Elliot watched three dots appear almost immediately.

Then stopped.

Then appeared again.

That you will stay quiet.

That you will not complicate things.

Elliot rested his elbows on the table and stared at the grain of the wood.

She asked the question he knew would come.

So, what did you tell them?

There was a longer pause this time.

Long enough for him to feel the cost of saying it out loud.

I told them I would not lie.

Nova exhaled slowly, realizing she'd been holding her breath. Her chest loosened, just enough to make space for it.

Marcy paced behind her. "We are losing time. They are drafting language right now. If you want input, it has to be now."

Nova turned. "Input into what?"

"Into how this disappears," Marcy said. "Or how it turns into something we cannot control."

Nova shook her head. "Control is already gone."

Marcy's voice sharpened. "You are not the only person this affects."

"I know," Nova said. "That is why silence is no longer neutral."

Another call came in. Marcy glanced at the screen.

"Legal," she said. "They are ready."

Nova's breath shortened. Her ribs felt tighter, as if the room had leaned in and forgotten to leave her air.

She thought of every time delay had cost her something she could not name until it was gone.

"What happens if I tell the truth," Nova asked.

Marcy did not answer right away.

"Then you lose control of how it lands," Marcy said.

She didn't elaborate. She didn't have to.

Nova met her gaze. "I already lose something every time I erase someone else to protect myself."

Outside, the noise surged again. Her name rose unevenly through the glass.

Her phone buzzed.

Whatever you choose, I won't hide either.

Nova closed her eyes.

Silence was no longer protection for anyone.

Her hands were cold against the glass.

"Tell legal I'll speak. Not for them," she said.

Marcy's breath caught. "Nova."

Nova did not look away. "Not their script. Mine."

Marcy searched her face. "Do you understand the cost?"

"Yes," Nova said. "I understand the cost of not doing it."

Marcy looked down at her phone, then back up. "When."

Nova glanced at the window. At the cameras. At the certainty that the story would move with or without her.

"Soon," Nova said. "Before they decide for me."

Her phone buzzed again. She texted Elliot.

I will tell the truth and let it land where it lands.

His response was quick.

I hear you.

She straightened.

The noise outside rose again.

This time, she did not step back from it.

CHAPTER FORTY-THREE

"He did not choose this spotlight. I did."

- Nova Hart, untitled

Nova's phone vibrated nonstop, her name flashing across headlines in bold.

Nova Hart to address rumors today, source confirms.

She didn't need to ask who the source was.

Outside, camera lenses tilted upward. Flashes popped.

Marcy stood near the door, phone pressed to her ear. "Yes," she said evenly. "We're aware."

A pause.

"No. She hasn't committed to that."

Another pause.

"We'll confirm within the hour."

She ended the call and looked at Nova.

"They're giving us a window," she said. "It's not generous."

“How long?” Nova asked.

“Two hours. After that, they run whatever they have.”

Nova nodded once.

Two hours wasn’t enough time to decide.

It was enough time to act.

Another notification appeared.

Statement coordination call.

Legal. Label. PR.

Marcy watched her carefully. “If you get on that call, you read what they draft. You don’t deviate. It slows everything down.”

“And him?” Nova asked.

Marcy’s expression shifted. “His name won’t be mentioned.”

Which meant he wouldn’t exist.

Nova’s phone buzzed. Elliot.

They’re asking me to confirm I won’t comment.

She typed back immediately.

So they want silence on both sides.

Yes. They’re calling it protection.

Another buzz.



I won't disappear. I know what that would cost.

Nova stared at the screen.

For years she had mastered this moment, shrinking statements, surviving headlines by becoming smaller inside them.

She felt the old instinct rise.

Soften it.

Control it.

Make it manageable.

Not this time.

She typed:

They want me to erase you.

A pause lasted before he responded.

Then the truth is already chosen.

The question is whether you'll speak it.

Marcy's phone rang again. She silenced it.

"They're not waiting," she said.

Nova walked to the window.

The crowd below had grown louder. A reporter adjusted a light. Someone practiced into a microphone.

The world had already decided she owed it a version of herself.

Her phone buzzed again.

I'm not asking you to protect me

I'm asking you not to erase me.

Nova turned from the window.

"I'm not reading their statement," she said.

Marcy went still. "Nova."

"I'm not getting on that call," Nova continued. "If I speak, it won't be through them."

"You'll lose control," Marcy said.

"I already lost it," Nova replied. "What I'm choosing now is honesty."

Silence filled the room.

Marcy searched her face for hesitation.

There wasn't any.

"If you do this publicly," Marcy said carefully, "you can't walk it back."

"I'm not trying to," Nova said.

Another call flashed across Marcy's phone.

"They want confirmation," she said.

Nova lifted her chin.

"Tell them I'll speak," she said. "But not on their call."

Marcy's breath caught. "That changes everything."

"Yes," Nova said. "It does."

Outside, the noise surged — as if the building itself felt the shift.

Marcy stared at her for one long moment, then began typing rapidly.

“Then we move fast,” she said. “Because once this starts, it won’t stop.”

Nova’s phone vibrated again. Alerts stacking. Speculation tightening.

She didn’t look at them.

She texted Elliot one final message.

I’m speaking.

The reply came quickly.

I hear you.

Nova slipped her phone into her pocket.

“Where?” she asked.

Marcy blinked. “Where?”

“If I’m speaking,” Nova said, “I’m not hiding in a conference room.”

Marcy studied her. Then nodded once.

“Lobby,” she said. “Five minutes.”

The lobby lights were too bright.

Microphones rose toward her as security parted the crowd.

Nova did not wait for quiet. She waited for breath.

“I know why you’re here,” she said.

The room stilled.

“I won’t offer a denial.”

A camera shutter snapped.

“There is someone in my life who matters to me.”

The noise shifted — not louder, just sharper.

“He did not choose this spotlight. I did.”

She held the silence after that.

“I will carry what comes with my name. But I won’t pretend he does not exist to make that easier.”

No name.

No performance.

No trembling.

Just truth.

“I won’t be answering further questions today.”

She stepped back before the noise could swell.

The questions started before she reached the hallway.

CHAPTER FORTY-FOUR

"Real was worth weather."

- Nova Hart, untitled

Elliot did not move while she spoke.

He stood in his kitchen with the livestream open, the volume low enough that he could hear the steadiness in her breathing.

When she said —

“He did not choose this spotlight. I did.”

— his hand tightened on the back of the chair.

Not pride.

Not triumph.

Responsibility.

The comments blurred below her image. Scripture fragments. Half-formed opinions. Screenshots already circulating.

He closed the laptop before she stepped back from the microphones.

He did not need to see the surge.

His phone began vibrating immediately.

Unknown numbers.

A local reporter.

Two missed calls from an elder.

A text from Clara.

Dad.

He let the calls go unanswered.

Instead, he sat down.

The kitchen felt smaller than it had an hour ago.

He bowed his head, not in performance. In reflex.

God, do not let my steadiness become pride. Do not let my fear become silence.

His phone buzzed again.

Clara calling.

He answered this time.

"I watched," she said.

Her voice wasn't angry.

It was braced.

"She didn't name you."

"No."

"She protected you."

"Yes."

A long pause.

"Dad... this won't stay quiet."

"I know."

"And you still want this?"

That question landed harder than anything else had.

He did not answer quickly.

"I want truth," he said finally.

"That wasn't the question."

He exhaled.

"Yes," he said.

Silence.

"I don't want to lose you to something that moves faster than you can see," she said.

"You won't," he replied.

He hoped it was true.

After she hung up, he opened the group text from church leadership.

We need to meet tonight.

He typed:

I will be there.

He did not defend. He did not explain. He did not preempt.

He would be there.

Across the country, Nova had made it back to the hotel before her hands started shaking. Now she sat on the floor with her back against the bed.

Marcy was still on the phone.

Greg had already texted:

You just split the internet in half.

Nova did not smile.

Her hands trembled now that the adrenaline had burned off.

She pressed them flat against her thighs and let them shake.

Her phone lit up again.

I'm here.

She read it once.

Then again.

Then typed:

Still?

A pause.

Always.

Her throat tightened.

Marcy ended her call.

"They're divided," she said. "Sponsors are nervous. But you didn't implode anything."

Nova nodded.

"They've identified him," Marcy said. "They found the church website. He's listed as an elder."

Nova's head lifted.

"Already?"

"Yes."

Nova closed her eyes.

Faith was never the part she feared losing. It was the part she feared being misunderstood in.

Her phone buzzed again.
An email preview flashed:

We are concerned about your public alignment...

She locked the screen.
For the first time in years, she had not curated the narrative.
She had entered it.
And it was wild.
She stood slowly.
“I don’t regret it,” she said.
Marcy studied her.
“You might.”
“Maybe,” Nova said.
“But not for speaking.”
Back in Oceanside, Elliot stepped outside.
The ocean was restless tonight.
Wind rougher than usual. Waves breaking harder against the rocks.
He rested his hands on the railing.
The phone in his pocket buzzed again. He didn’t look.
He let the wind hit his face.
Exposure.
That was the word.
Exposed.
His phone buzzed once more. Nova.

Standing.

He typed back:

Still.

He stared at the horizon. This was no longer contained.

But it was real.

And real was worth weather.

CHAPTER FORTY-FIVE

*"Integrity does not shield you from cost.
It simply clarifies whether you will bear it."*
- Nova Hart, untitled

The church was mostly dark when Elliot arrived.

Only the fellowship hall lights were on. The rest of the building sat in shadow, quiet and familiar.

He had walked into this place through grief. Through storms. Through years that had reshaped him.

Tonight felt different.

Inside, folding chairs had been set in a loose circle. No table. No paperwork. Just men who had known one another a long time.

Mark sat at the center of the arc. Mr. Avery to his right. Jack beside him, quiet and watchful.

Avery gave him a small nod. Steady. Not smiling, but not cold.

They waited until Elliot had taken his seat.

Mark leaned forward slightly.

"We are not here to question your character," he said.

No preamble.

"We are here because what touches one elder touches all of us."

The words settled evenly across the room.

"The coverage is widening," Mark continued. "Your name is attached. The church's name will not be far behind."

Elliot nodded once. "I understand."

Mark held his gaze.

"The reports say she stayed at your house."

There it was.

Elliot did not shift.

"She did."

Silence.

"Nova slept on the couch. I took the chair."

No elaboration.

"No one else was present?"

"No."

No one spoke immediately.

Mr. Avery spoke for the first time.

"We trust you," he said gently. "But the world will not."

Elliot met his eyes.

"I'm aware."

Mark folded his hands.

"How is Clara?"

"She's thinking more than she's talking."

Avery's expression softened.

"She's already had stability taken from her once," he said quietly.

"She doesn't need another season of uncertainty."

The reference to her mother hung in the room without being named.

Elliot felt that one.

"I'm watching that carefully," he said. Not defensive. Certain.

The room was still.

Mark exhaled slowly.

"We met briefly before you arrived," he said.

Jack shifted in his chair, the faint scrape of metal cutting through the quiet.

"There's something we need to ask plainly."

Elliot felt it before it came.

"Have you considered what it would look like to step back for a season?"

Not sharp.

Not dramatic.

But heavier than anything else said that night.

Elliot did not speak immediately.

He had buried his wife in this church. Sat in hospital corridors with these men. Prayed through seasons that had no good endings.

He had expected concern.

He had not expected to be measured.

Mark added quietly, "Not as discipline. As stewardship."

The word landed clean.

Elliot straightened slightly.

"If I saw this hurting Clara, I would not continue."

He let that settle.

"And I wouldn't stay in leadership if I thought I was putting this church at risk."

No one interrupted.

Mr. Avery watched him carefully.

"This isn't ministry," Elliot said quietly.

"It's a relationship."

The words were simple. Without ornament.

Mark's expression did not change, but something in the room softened.

"Are you reacting," Mark asked, "or are you choosing this clearly?"

"I'm choosing it clearly."

No edge. No heat.

"I have not hidden," Elliot added. "And I have not misled anyone."

"No one here believes you have," Avery said.

Mark leaned back slightly.

"Leadership is not only about being right."

Elliot held his gaze.

"It's also not about disappearing when things get complicated."

The room held that tension — not as argument, but as reality.

Finally, Mark nodded once.

"We trust you."

The words were deliberate.

"But if this church is drawn into public controversy, we will revisit what stepping back might require."

Not a deadline.

A boundary.

Elliot inclined his head. "That's fair."

Mr. Avery added quietly, "You won't carry this alone."

"And neither will Clara," Jack said.

Mark bowed his head and prayed. Wisdom. Protection. Clarity. Humility.

When they rose, nothing had been resolved.

Only defined.

Outside, the night air felt colder than before.

Elliot stood beside his car, keys in hand.

He had walked through storms here. Real ones. Roof damage. Financial strain. Illness.

He had always believed integrity was enough. Integrity did not shield you from cost. It simply clarified whether you would bear it.

For the first time since Nova stepped into his house, something had been taken from him.

Not visibly. But permanently.

Not position. Not trust.

Certainty.

He unlocked the car and sat behind the wheel. He was still steady. But the ground was no longer untouched.

And he knew, when he saw her next, he would tell her.

It had weight now.

CHAPTER FORTY-SIX

"So this didn't become something we handled in fragments."

- Nova Hart, untitled hat landed

The flight left just after dawn.

Elliot sat by the window and watched the coastline fade into haze. He did not rehearse what he would say. He had learned long ago that rehearsed words rarely survived real conversation.

Before boarding, he sent a message.

Are you free this afternoon?

Several minutes passed.

I have a break between tapings around three. Why?

Because I'll be there.

The dots appeared. Disappeared. Appeared again.

You're flying here?

Yes.

A longer pause.

I can't wait to see you.

That was all.

Los Angeles did not unfold gently.

Traffic crawled from the airport. Billboards climbed over one another. The air held heat even in early afternoon.

He arrived well before three and walked the length of the block across from the studio entrance. Production vans lined the curb. Security guards checked badges without looking up.

At two fifty-eight, his phone buzzed.

Coming out now.

He looked up.

She crossed the lot without an entourage. Ball cap low. Sunglasses in her hand, not hiding. No stage lighting. No audience.

When she reached the sidewalk, she stopped a few feet from him.

"You actually flew here."

"Yes."

"Why?"

"So this didn't become something we handled in fragments."

The noise of the boulevard moved around them — engines, horns, someone shouting into a headset.

She studied him for a moment.

“Okay,” she said quietly.

He nodded once.

“I met with the elders last night.”

Her shoulders straightened.

“They asked me to consider stepping back.”

She didn’t flinch.

“From being an elder.”

A bus rolled past, blocking them briefly from view. When it cleared, she was still watching him.

“And?” she asked.

“I told them no.”

There was no pride in it. No drama.

“They trust me,” he continued. “But if the church is pulled into this publicly, we revisit it.”

She absorbed that without interrupting.

“That’s fair,” she said.

“Yes.”

He hesitated.

“I did think about it.”

That surprised her.

“Why?”

“Because leadership carries weight. And I don’t treat that lightly.”

A pause.

“But I’m not uncertain about you.”

Her expression shifted — something steady settling in.

“I don’t want you losing something you’ve built for decades,” she said.

"I'm not losing it," he replied. "If anything changes, it will be because I chose it."

"And if the cost grows?"

"Then we decide again."

There was no defiance in his tone. Just steadiness.

A production assistant jogged toward the gate and slowed briefly when she recognized Nova, then moved on.

Nova folded her arms loosely.

"I'm tired of letting fear make my decisions," she said. "I've done that enough."

He didn't argue.

"They might name the church," she said.

"Then we deal with that."

His voice wasn't flippant. It was resolved.

"If that happens," she added, "I won't let you stand there alone."

He held her gaze.

"That's not your responsibility."

"It will be if I say it is."

There was no edge to it. Just ownership.

The afternoon sun caught in her hair. Studio noise carried on behind her like a separate world.

"You came all this way just to tell me that?" she asked.

"Yes."

A faint smile touched her mouth.

"Stay until I'm done," she said.

"I will."

They stood for another moment — not touching, not dramatic — just aligned.

A security guard glanced toward them but didn't intervene.

"I need to go," she said.

"I know."

She stepped closer, close enough that the space between them narrowed without announcement.

"Thank you," she said quietly.

"For not disappearing."

He didn't respond.

He didn't need to.

She turned and walked back toward the studio doors.

He stayed where he was.

Watching.

Choosing.

CHAPTER FORTY-SEVEN

*"I've been wrestling for a while.
I just got good at pretending I wasn't."*

- Nova Hart, untitled

The article went live at 6:12 a.m.

Marcy saw it first.

She read it twice before she called anyone, not because it was explosive, but because it was careful.

Pop Star's Faith Turn Linked to North Carolina Church Elder.

The tone was neutral. Curious. Almost respectful.

It named the church.

It named Elliot.

It referenced the overnight stay without embellishment.

It did not accuse.

It did not need to.

By 6:25, three additional outlets had picked it up. By 7:10, “Ocean-side Community Church” was trending.

Elliot read it at his kitchen table and stopped after the first paragraph.

He did not scroll.

He set the phone down and stared at the wall long enough for the coffee to cool.

It had happened.

Exposure.

He picked up the phone and texted Mark.

You’ve seen it?

Yes. Call me when you can.

There was no panic in the reply. No urgency.

That steadiness mattered.

In Los Angeles, Nova sat in her dressing room with her name taped to the door in black marker.

The room smelled faintly of hairspray and warmed light bulbs. Outside the door, production voices moved with practiced urgency.

Marcy stood near the mirror, tablet in hand.

“They named the church,” she said.

Nova didn’t reach for it immediately.

“Hostile?” she asked.

“No.”

“Speculative?”

“Yes.”

Nova nodded once.

“And Elliot?”

“Mentioned. Not quoted.”

That was worse. Silence gave other people room to decide what the story meant.

Her phone buzzed.

It's out.

I know.

Are you okay?

Yes.

Are you?

A pause.

Yes.

She set the phone down.

“The segment was supposed to stay light,” Marcy said. “Album. Tour. Process.”

Nova stood and walked to the window. The lot below was already full of cables, vans, and people moving faster than their expressions.

“What’s the angle?” she asked.

"They'll ask," Marcy said. "They always do."

Nova turned.

"Good."

Marcy narrowed her eyes slightly.

"Good?"

"I'm tired of being narrated."

Marcy held her gaze.

"If you name him, it escalates."

"If I don't, it distorts."

That was the equation.

Marcy exhaled slowly.

"Then say it clean."

Back in Oceanside, Elliot stood in the church parking lot with Mark.

The building behind them looked unchanged. Brick. Glass. A steeple that had stood through storms louder than headlines.

"Attendance will spike Sunday," Mark said.

"I know."

"You understand we may need to revisit the question."

"I do."

Mark studied him for a moment.

"We stand steady."

"Yes."

Nothing dramatic.

Just defined.

Applause rose, bright and practiced, then softened as Nova settled into the chair across from the host. The set was warm — soft amber lighting, polished wood, an audience arranged close enough to feel intimate but far enough to remain controlled.

“It’s good to have you back,” the host said, smiling. “The new album is already climbing.”

Nova returned the smile. “That’s kind of you.”

“You’ve called it your most honest work yet.”

“I think it is.”

“And the sound feels different. Quieter in some places. Bolder in others.”

Nova nodded. “It felt like time.”

The host tilted her head slightly.

“There’s also a thread people are noticing. A faith element.”

A small shift in the room.

She continued. “And now there are reports connecting that shift to a church elder in Oceanside, North Carolina.”

A pause.

“I have to ask the question the world is wanting an answer to: Are you in a relationship with him?”

The studio quieted in a way that cameras do not capture but people feel.

Nova did not look away.

“Yes.”

The host held her gaze.

“Is that something you’re comfortable saying publicly?”

Another breath.

“Yes.”

A slight shift in posture from the crew behind the cameras.

“And would you like to clarify that?”

Nova nodded once.

"His name is Elliot."

The room did not gasp.

It did not applaud.

It went still.

"And yes, he's part of a church in Oceanside, North Carolina," she continued. "But my questions didn't start with him."

The host tilted her head.

"Questions about faith?"

"I've been wrestling for a while," Nova said. "I just got good at pretending I wasn't."

Silence held.

"I'm not pretending anymore."

The host's tone softened slightly.

"And the relationship?"

Nova's voice did not rise.

"I care about him," she said. "And I'm not going to hide that because it's inconvenient."

The host blinked once, recalibrating.

"That's very direct."

Nova nodded.

"I'm done being indirect."

The red light dimmed.

The quiet lingered longer than applause would have.

Elliot watched the clip from the airport as he waited to fly home.

He did not smile.

He did not flinch.

He exhaled slowly.

She had stepped into it.

Not for him.

With him.

His phone vibrated.

Mark.

"I just watched it," Mark said.

"So did I."

"She named you."

"Yes."

"And the church."

"Yes."

"She didn't sensationalize it."

"No."

Silence stretched between them.

"We'll see what Sunday brings," Mark said.

"I'll be there."

"I know."

The line ended.

The plane lifted.

Los Angeles fell away beneath him.

Sunday morning arrived without spectacle.

The parking lot filled earlier than usual. Cars he recognized. Cars he did not.

Elliot stood near the entrance before service began.

He did not hide.

He greeted people as they arrived.

Some held his hand longer than normal. Some avoided his eyes.
Most offered a quiet nod that carried more than commentary ever
could.

Clara walked in beside him.

Not behind.

Not ahead.

Beside.

Inside, the sanctuary carried a different kind of awareness.

Not accusation.

Curiosity.

When Mark stepped to the pulpit, he did not reference the article.

He preached the scheduled passage.

Steadiness in uncertain seasons.

Trust that did not shrink under scrutiny.

No defense. No disclaimers.

Just Scripture.

After the benediction, people lingered.

One older man approached Elliot slowly.

"That must be heavy," he said.

"It is," Elliot replied.

The man nodded.

"We're praying."

No advice. No probing.

Just that.

Across the room, Mr. Avery caught Elliot's eye and inclined his
head.

Support.

Clara touched Elliot's sleeve as they stepped outside.

“That wasn’t terrible,” she said quietly.

“No,” he agreed.

The sunlight broke clean across the lot.

The ocean line cut the horizon steady and blue.

The line had been crossed — not by scandal, but by clarity.

And now the cost would settle wherever it chose.

Elliot stood there for a moment longer.

He had always believed integrity was enough. Now he understood
it was not a shield. It was a lantern.

He did not feel diminished.

He felt visible.

And he was still standing.

CHAPTER FORTY-EIGHT

"It didn't feel safe. It felt steady."

- Nova Hart, untitled

By Tuesday, the headlines had thinned.

They did not disappear.

They simply slid lower on the page.

Nova finished her remaining commitments without adding to them. She answered what was asked. She did not elaborate. She did not retreat.

The noise no longer felt sharp.

On her final afternoon in Los Angeles, Marcy closed the dressing room door and leaned against it.

"You didn't lose sponsors," she said. "Two paused. One asked questions. None walked."

Nova nodded.

"I expected worse."

"You usually do."

A faint smile crossed Nova's face.

Marcy studied her.

"So what now?"

Nova glanced around the room — lights, mirrors, garment racks, a schedule taped to the wall.

"I'm finishing what I committed to," she said.

"And after that?"

Nova didn't answer right away.

"I don't want to make decisions because they're loud," she said. "Or because they're quiet."

Marcy tilted her head.

"And?"

Nova met her eyes.

"I'm not going back just because it's familiar."

Marcy nodded once.

"Then make the decision because it's right. Not because it feels safe."

Nova exhaled.

"It doesn't feel safe," she said.

It felt steady.

Elliot met her at the airport.

No cameras waited.

No one cared.

She stepped off the escalator with one carry-on bag and a jacket folded over her arm.

"That's it?" he asked.

"For now."

He took the bag without comment.

The drive back to Oceanside stretched out in quiet.

Not strained.

Not fragile.

Just unhurried.

"You don't have to choose this because of Sunday," he said.

"I'm not."

She watched the coastline appear along the horizon.

"I've been choosing it for a while."

He nodded, letting that stand.

That evening, Clara sat at the kitchen table, homework spread in front of her.

Nova paused in the doorway.

"Need help?" she asked.

Clara glanced up.

"Probably."

Nova pulled out the chair across from her.

They worked through the assignment without rushing.

After a while, Clara set her pencil down.

"You didn't have to say his name," she said.

Nova met her eyes.

"I wanted to."

Clara studied her for a second.

"It was loud."

"I know."

A small pause.

"But you weren't weird about it."

Nova let out a soft breath.

"I'm trying not to be weird about most things."

Clara nodded.

"Good."

She hesitated, then reached across the table and squeezed Nova's hand once before pulling back.

Small.

But enough.

Later, Elliot stood on the back porch as Nova stepped outside.

Clara's light clicked off behind her.

"She good?" he asked.

Nova nodded.

"I think so."

He studied her face.

"And you?"

Nova looked out toward the dark line of the water in the distance.

"I'm not finished figuring things out," she said.

"I know."

She glanced at him, then back toward the horizon.

"But I'm not guessing anymore."

That was enough for him.

He stepped closer, not touching, just there.

The night settled around them — quiet, steady, unforced.

Something had shifted.

Not everything.

But something real.

CHAPTER FORTY-NINE

"The morning was mine until it wasn't."

- Nova Hart, "Without You"

The morning came without asking permission. Light moved through the kitchen in thin gold lines, the same way it always had. The coffee maker clicked and gurgled. A gull crossed the window. The ocean rolled in its steady rhythm beyond the glass.

The guest room had been Clara's idea. Practical. Uncomplicated. Nova had not argued.

Nova stood at the counter in the Harbor Light Cafe sweatshirt. She had not planned to wear it. She had reached for it the way she always had — without thinking, the way she had reached for it the first time in this hallway, the way she had carried it across twelve cities without quite knowing why.

Elliot came downstairs and stopped in the doorway.

He saw it.

He didn't say anything.

He crossed to the coffee maker and poured two mugs.

That was all.

The house did not feel hollow this morning.

It felt inhabited.

Nova sat at the kitchen table with both hands around her mug. The chair across from her had a small scuff on the leg she had not noticed before. The drying rack held two plates and a bowl. The morning light found the counter and stayed there, unhurried.

She closed her eyes and breathed.

Not catching her breath.

Choosing it.

The quiet had changed quality. It no longer carried too far. It simply sat, present and ordinary, neither asking anything nor offering more than it had.

She opened her eyes.

Elliot was reading at the table, his Bible open, a pen resting beside it. He was not performing stillness. He simply was.

This, she thought. *This is what I kept reaching for.*

Clara arrived mid-morning with a paper bag from the bakery down the street.

She set it on the counter without ceremony.

"Muffins," she said. "The lemon ones."

She glanced at Nova. At the sweatshirt. At the mug in her hands.

She didn't say anything about any of it.

She pulled out a chair and sat down.

"Dad, you have a package on the porch," she said. "Looks like it's been there since Thursday."

"I saw it," he said.

"And?"

"It can wait until Monday."

Clara shook her head slowly, the way she always did when he was being deliberately unhurried. But her mouth curved just slightly at the corner.

She reached for a muffin and broke it open.

Nova watched her and felt something settle.

Confirmed.

This is what faith looks like when it stops being afraid of being misunderstood, she thought. It looks like lemon muffins on a Saturday morning.

They walked to the Harbor Light Cafe just after noon.

The bell above the door jingled as they stepped inside. The air smelled like coffee and pancake syrup, the same as it always had. The walls still held the faded photos of fishermen. Every table still a little sticky.

Doreen was behind the counter.

She looked up when they came in.

Her eyes moved from Elliot to Nova. To the sweatshirt. Back to Elliot.

She did not gasp.

She did not freeze.

She simply reached for the coffee pot and moved toward their table.

"Morning," she said, filling their mugs before they asked. "Usual?"

"Please," Elliot said.

Doreen wrote nothing down. She never did.

She moved toward the kitchen without another word.

But at the pass-through she paused, just briefly, and glanced back once.

Her expression carried something quiet and certain.

Not surprise.

Recognition.

She had known since the morning she watched him stand in this same diner unable to stop looking at the door.

She had been right.

She didn't need to say so.

They sat across from each other at the table with the terrible chairs.

Nova wrapped both hands around her mug.

"This is where it started," she said.

"Yes."

She looked around the room. The same laminated menus. The same faded photographs. The same syrup-sticky tables.

"It doesn't look like much," she said.

"No," he agreed. "It doesn't."

She met his eyes.

"I'm glad it was here."

He held her gaze.

"So am I."

The silence that followed was the kind that only exists when neither person is trying to impress the other. It had taken them the better part of a year to get here. It felt, now, like the most ordinary thing in the world.

Doreen appeared with plates.

"Eggs and toast," she said, setting one in front of Elliot. "And the pancakes." She set the second in front of Nova. "Extra syrup. Don't drown them."

Nova looked up. "How did you remember?"

Doreen smiled — small, certain, unchanged. "Honey, I've been doing this a long time."

She moved away without waiting for an answer.

After lunch they walked the boardwalk.

The ocean ran alongside them, steady and blue. The wind came off the water in soft gusts, salt and clean.

Nova kept her hands in the sweatshirt pocket.

"I keep waiting for something to go wrong," she said.

"I know."

"Is that normal?"

"Yes," he said. "For a while."

She nodded.

They walked a few more steps.

"I'm not performing right now," she said quietly. "This is just — me."

He glanced at her. "I know."

"Is that enough?"

He stopped walking.

She stopped beside him.

The ocean moved. A gull called once and was gone.

"Nova," he said. "It's what I've been waiting for."

Her throat tightened.

Not with fear. With something that had been building since a Saturday morning when a pop star stepped into his doorway and something in him missed its step, like a hymn sung in the wrong key.

She did not cry.

She simply stood there, present and unhidden, in a faded sweatshirt that smelled like the sea.

That was enough.

More than.

That evening, the house settled into its familiar rhythm.

Clara had gone home. The dishes were done. The coffee maker was set for morning.

Nova sat on the back porch steps with her knees pulled up. Elliot came outside and sat beside her.

Not performing closeness.

Just there.

The ocean spread out before them, dark and patient. The horizon held its line. Above it, the first stars were appearing — not all at once, but one by one, the way honest things tend to arrive.

"I'm not finished figuring things out," she said.

"I know."

"But I'm not guessing anymore."

"No," he said. "Neither am I."

The weight of it settled between them — not as burden, but as ballast. The thing that kept them grounded rather than the thing that dragged them down.

She leaned her head against his shoulder.

He didn't move.

The night pressed in around them, quiet and unhurried, the way the best things tend to be when fear finally stops giving the orders.

"Soon," she had said, once, standing in this same house, on her way out the door.

"Soon," he had answered.

It had taken longer than either of them expected.

It had cost more than either of them had planned.

But here, in the dark, with the ocean steady and the stars arriving
one by one —

Soon had come.

*The morning was mine until it wasn't.
Now it belongs to something I did not plan for and cannot explain and
would not trade.*

That is the only kind of love worth the noise.

— **Nova Hart, "Without You," completed**